



arnica butler



a slight stretch
part I





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Chapter One

He might not have ever admitted it, even to himself, but as time went by, he liked "it" - her, their adventures, her sexual flings - best when she was in the role of storyteller.

She always began with a hint of discomfort that flashed in her eyes, or a quiver in her lips. Maybe a fleeting stain of pink somewhere on her face, while her mouth made odd shapes as she tried to figure out how to begin a story about her affairs.

Details were gauzy at first, as if doing the things she did was easier than talking about them. There was something buried in that discomfort that turned him on. It was like a strip-tease of her secretive mind in that way - sensitive, forbidden parts of her, bared one by one, but the whole thing always just out of reach.

Maybe it was because of his age: he'd reached a point in life where he knew an important secret: most things were better if they were just out of reach.

Once she began, there was always a point when her modesty or shame broke like a fever. The story, and all of its sordid details, would rush out of

her like moisture from between her legs when she was aroused.

And the delicious nuggets of filth on offer in a story were the kinds of details that he wouldn't have been able to see with his own eyes - even if he had been right there in the room. In some ways, he felt more voyeuristic when she *told* him about what she had done.

If he *had* been there - don't misunderstand him, he loved that, too - she would never tell him those details.

Not like this.

The one he liked best might have surprised her, but she never asked that kind of question. She knew he liked the stories, because his cock would be turgid when she brought things to a tantalizing conclusion. The dam often broke within minutes of her enclosing him in her velvet cunt - something she forgave easily, and luridly, by whispering wetly in his ear: *I'm so sore anyway*.

It was the film festival story that he most often wandered to when he was alone. Who could say why? It was dark and sleazy and weird, maybe.

She met him in the balcony seats in the faux theater that a movie set crew had erected in the convention center, bad weather driving them inside. She'd had a guy in mind for a fling: a filmmaker and actor. Like all the guys she went after, he was young: twenty-three. That was the kind of guy Sabrina liked to do: they needed no seduction, always had rock-hard erections, they came with no baggage, and they were putty in her hands. She was older, she was confident, she knew what she wanted and she asked for it, and she was hot as hell. Experience had made her formidable: at some point Sabrina had realized that *a lot* of young guys had fantasies about self-possessed, bossy, hot, older women. Once she knew that, she went wild.

She went to the balcony seats to plot her attack on *that* young man - the filmmaker - but a crew worker she hadn't noticed much before was up there alone, watching the film.

The inspiration had come to her instantly. He was muscular and quiet, expressionless behind the goatee and beard that had originally disqualified him - Sabrina hated beards, she claimed that they smelled like dust and annoyed her in all the wrong ways. (They were currently a plague on the age group she selected her bulls from).

But this guy was sitting there alone and looked back at her in a certain way - like he had been waiting for her all along.

"Like maybe he had, and maybe he hadn't," she had told Graham, the intrigue sizzling in his ears and his cock. "But either way, he seemed happy to see me."

So she sat next to him: a forward and provocative move. But that was Sabrina's MO, her secret sauce. She was a hot MILF in an unexpected package: Sabrina still looked young-ish. She was thin, shapely, *interested* in sex. Men still chased after her: the desperation of a lonely soccer mom past her prime didn't cling to her like it did other women her age, or even younger. She *had been* a soccer mom, and now she was past all that, too: but Sabrina wore it differently somehow. Like she could take it or leave it. Men were intrigued by that, and probably pleasantly surprised that she *did* take it when she did. Or that she reached out and grabbed it.

There was no one up there and rows and rows of empty seats. Their clothes were damp from the sudden downpour outside, and he smelled like damp tobacco and clean sweat. "He smelled like a man," she recounted: in Sabrina's world this was any combination of sawdust, sweat, tobacco, or motor oil. She preferred young blue-collar men. Everybody has a type.

She decided, the way she decided everything - in a rush - to pounce on this one.

When the next film started, she reached over and put his hand on her thigh.

A detail Graham liked emerged next: the music was too loud. So loud, she recounted breathlessly - in her overripe voice, a smile quivering in her lips - that it was uncomfortable. Distracting.

The guy didn't even turn toward her when she did that. She almost started laughing when he didn't move for so long: the sound was too loud, her own overture too forward. He didn't move at first: his hand lay on her thigh like the hand of a corpse, and she wondered if she'd at last met a man who wouldn't go for her. His lack of reaction intrigued her, so she waited to see what he would do.

But the hand - of course - warmed, and began to move. Just the tips of his fingers, stroking her knee. When he came to life a swell of victory rushed over her, and she had a craving for him. But he just kept stroking her knee, staring straight ahead.

So she nudged his fingers deeper: under the skirt, inward between her thighs. The movements were like that of a Ouija glass: controlled by no one, willed by both. His hand began to heat up and his fingers started to move more brazenly. She pushed them to the crease of her hip and parted her legs enough that he could work them beneath her silky panties and to the place she wanted him to stroke.

He didn't resist, but he also didn't press forward. Not until his fingers met the sticky sweetness dripping from her pussy did he begin to move completely on his own.

The blaring soundtrack soon faded beneath the churn of her own blood, the sound of her own breath. A dimming of outside sound, and a crisp tingle seemingly in the air - her own heart, thumping heavily and irregularly, trying to keep up with the rhythmic (and, it turned out, very expert) pulsing of the roadie's fingers.

It clawed between her legs until it burst and she tipped her head back, her juices oozing, hot and wet, into his hand. She let out a little gasp - one she said, laughing, that she couldn't imitate for a million dollars. Anyone who might have heard it would have recognized it for what it was, but the loud soundtrack glazed right over it.

Still, they both stared ahead. He had a smile on his face now.

When she brought her fingers to her mouth to lick them, one by one, it was inspired. That she thought of leaving after that - to never see the roadie again or explain - was a delicious paragraph in her tale, the kind Graham would have re-read again and again if it were in a book.

The kind of detail he would never get if he had been there to watch. Men fucked his wife much differently when they were alone with her, when they thought she was cheating with them.

She didn't leave like that, in the end: she slipped her hand into his pants and gripped his cock. She didn't say, but Graham liked to imagine: this was done as if to size him up, get an idea of his mettle. When her thumb encountered a slippery syrup oozing from the slight cleft at the tip of his very satisfying dick, her lips parted and she gasped as quietly as she could.

Approvingly, she pulled away. Looked back at him as she walked to the exit. Down the street, a light rain falling, into the stairwell back entrance at the Hilton. By then he had caught up to her and was right behind her through the door. Up, up, up, quietly walking, him following without asking

questions, his eyes unflinchingly gazing up her skirt. Graham wondered if the scent of her steaming pussy had lingered in the stairwell, like a perfume, a faint mist that enclosed him as he climbed the stairs behind her.

She went up to the fifth floor, one that nobody used with any regularity - which did not mean 'never;' anyone could have emerged and found them there. Why the fifth? No particular reason. She was tired of climbing, she was thinking about his cock, there was more danger to it than, say, the tenth floor, where there were only three suites, and no reason at all to be in the stairwell.

She could scarcely believe she was doing it when she did it. She seemed genuinely shocked by herself as she recounted taking off her clothes - all of them - so that she was stark naked in the stairwell with a young guy staring at her in happy disbelief.

She recalled placing her long rain jacket down on the floor first.

Graham had no trouble imagining his wife doing that: a naked, hot older woman having sex with a young guy she just met, in a stairwell, pausing to tidily spread her rain jacket on the floor.

She opened her legs and sat down in the corner, arms braced against the walls, and let him fuck her. *After* he ate her pussy, which she instructed him to do. He was the one who crawled to her, with his belly on the ground, writhing on the floor like a worm.

But none of this was the best part about that story, or the way Sabrina told it.

So she was wondering, she had said, by way of wrapping the story up that first time she told him about it. She was squirming in Graham's lap by then, her shirt and bra off, her pussy wet and heated, the scent of it rising to his nostrils.

She leaned back a little, thrusting upward for his gaze the unusual teardrop shapes of her breasts. Their oddly large, pink-hued areolae, with tiny spherical nipples transfixed him.

His hand was at the small of her back, facilitating this display, so he could admire the unique and pleasing shape of her with his fingertips on her silken skin - while she asked, falteringly - if he wouldn't mind her meeting that guy again.

If the chance came up.

The problem was, Sabrina had continued, squirming in his lap: the roadie had finished too suddenly. At the time, it hadn't bothered her. They were, after all, on a stairwell, and she had already come herself. Twice.

In the bedroom with Graham, she lifted her hips and settled her pussy on his cock and sank down over him, enclosing him in her very hot, somewhat stretched interior. She was wet, dripping, in fact, and he had no way of knowing in what percentages of arousal and another man's cum, even as the liquid rolled down his balls.

She smiled, and put her lips close to his, balancing her forehead against his as she bounced up and down. "I think I want to do it again, if I see him again," she panted.

Was that okay with him - her husband?

The thing was, she continued: his cock was snub-nosed and thick, and hit her very deliciously in the g-spot, and she would love it if he made her come again, this time from the inside.

It never happened: like all the other young men, the roadies and the entrepreneurs, the artists, the caterers, the buffet of youth that filtered through her work and then circulated away to never be seen again, he was gone, taking his well-formed cock with him.

Sabrina never told the same story twice.

But Graham re-lived them and told them to himself, when it suited him.

And that was a fucking good story.

Chapter Two

The man she wanted to sleep with the night she met Sebastian Grant was younger than usual.

His age did trigger a few pangs of unsettling guilt. He was closer to her son's age than he was to hers. He had a boyish face, the kind that would give him a youthful look well into his forties or even fifties - but those were decades in a distant future.

This particular kind of youthfulness was as unsettling as it was intoxicating.

A face could trick you, but a body could not: this man was still exquisitely lean, the kind of guy who had to work hard to gain weight. An adolescent metabolism still worked hard for him. He had to be at least twenty-one - he was in the bar with a beer - but he seemed unlikely to be much older than that.

He had sandy brown hair, carelessly cut and carelessly worn, thick and a little wavy. No beard, no traces of stubble, which could mean many things on a guy doing a job like this, but probably spelled lack of ambition.

None of those things really mattered to Sabrina, which was one of the things she loved about her arrangement with her husband Graham. She had permission - a mandate, even - to pursue the kind of men her mother had warned her about, or the kind of men who were headed for Loserville. She could prowl for men who were all wrong in so many ways, have the fun of flirting and bedding them, and then never see them again.

She had already forgotten his name, but that also didn't matter much. She had her reasons for fucking other men, younger men, and names were not part of it.

She had her reasons, she had her husband's blessing.

It was a blissful arrangement, and she knew that it was. Everybody was happy - except for the occasional stray, overly serious guy - but she couldn't be responsible for that, and she always lets them down decently. And she was always up-front about what was happening.

But contentment was a strange thing. Even though she had every reason to be satisfied, she sometimes felt a pull to go even further outside of the box than she already was.

She figured this was the reason for her attraction to this very, very young guy. The taboo, once commonplace, had to expand to keep delivering thrills.

She hadn't found a decent specimen in a long time - that wasn't to say she hadn't slept with anybody (other than Graham) in a long time, just that none of them *thrilled* her like before. This guy, for whatever reasons, ticked all the boxes.

It wasn't just about appearances - and contrary to what Graham seemed to think, it wasn't *all* about the size of his appendage (although she always found a way to check that out, because it may not have been everything -

but if a guy had a *tiny* dick, what was the point? What she was doing wasn't about personality or lifelong compatibility, or finding a good conversation partner: it was about sex).

There had to be *something else* to a guy she chose, though. Discretion. No signs of wanting anything *but* sex. A sort of current, traveling through him. A glimmer in his eye. A way for her to work into a crack somewhere in his youthful, unstable masculinity. Curiosity.

Above all, a decent pair of balls, so he would not be rendered a helpless baby once she made a move on him. There was nothing more annoying than taking her clothes off only to find that a guy's mommy complex was much deeper than the usual.

She wasn't a dope, and she was forty-seven this year: she knew by now that females were a jumble in every man's head. If you got into their heads by any door, you would occasionally brush up against a guy's mother: what mattered was not so much that it happened, but that it happened at a frequency that was tolerable to you.

And that it didn't get in the way of anything *she* wanted to happen. Otherwise, it was not only a little gross but extremely tedious. She wasn't choosing young guys to sleep with because she wanted to be their mother. She was choosing them because they were disposable, resilient, unlikely to get attached, and had rock-hard cocks ready at a moment's notice. Because they never said no, and because they hardly ever even mustered a feeble excuse. And they were wholly unbothered by the presence of her husband, if he chose to appear.

Most of them found it intriguing. With very young men, after all, she was offering them sex and it came to them gift-wrapped and string-free.

And she was hot.

That was usually where the questioning ended.

Sabrina watched him, a barely-sipped martini (not the pink drink of a young floozy, but a dirty concoction for a mature drinker) in front of her. When she was thoughtful, she ran her finger around the rim of her glass without realizing it, and she was doing that now.

This guy was curiously detached: he didn't check his phone; he didn't horse around; he didn't turn his head when gaggles of drunk, scantily-clad ladies marched their wares past him with obvious intentions.

She tipped her head to the side slightly. Maybe he was gay? It was harder and harder to tell these days, but she couldn't possibly be *that* out of touch.

His aloofness attracted her. Aloofness had always done the trick for Sabrina, who up until a few short years ago had been unaware of her staggering sex appeal because *so many men* feigned aloofness around her.

Real aloofness, however, was not something any man could really fake. Graham hadn't been faking, and that was why she'd been attracted to him. It was likely part of the reason she was here right now, hunting down a youthful fling: if there was one thing that could still get - and hold - Graham's attention, it was sex. It had surprised her greatly, but her flings had actually brought her and Graham closer together.

She suspected it was something about her being sexually appreciated, as a new conquest or territory. The enthusiasm of younger men helped her see for herself that she was still attractive, still in the game. So that when she went home to Graham, she went home like that: freshly enamored, more than anything, of herself.

But this guy. He wasn't really trying to land *anyone*. She held her phone up with two hands and wrote Graham a message, smiling to herself.

I'm starting to wonder if maybe my gaydar is off. This guy doesn't even turn around for 20yos in pink miniskirts.

Graham would like this. He liked Sabrina's mind, her rough edges - and that was why Sabrina fell in love with him, unlike so many others who had dared to hope. Other men saw her lovely features and her slight stature, her natural thinness, her whispery and sweet voice, and thought of her as a malleable doll.

She had played to that part for two decades, and it had never really suited her. Her large, dark blue eyes, hooded by a rogue Asian gene that had probably entered her bloodline in the time of Genghis Khan, gave her a look that was easily mistaken for submissiveness. The Cupid's bow of her upper lip, the tidy lines of her mouth, the swoop at the end of her unusually-shaped nose: they all combined to give her the sort of look that men misinterpreted as vulnerable. It had always been easier to play along with that, until she met Graham, who had seen intelligence in her kohl-rimmed eyes and defiance in the quiver of her smile.

None of that meant she wanted to baby-sit, or attempt to lure in a gay man, or even - as there seemed to be more and more (and more) of these days, a bi man.

Sabrina wanted a *man*-man, a man at least as manly as Graham. The kind of man who could take direction without his ego getting crushed or the need for dominatrix costumes. The kind of man who was interested in an adventure with an older woman for that reason - and would move on, without a hassle.

"Jimmy," she said, toying with an olive on the end of a wooden stick.

Jimmy, bartender at the Hilton mezzanine bar: Mid-thirties, now reliable after a series of bad choices had funneled his life to what it was now, bartender at a convention hotel in a mid-sized city. Lanky, rough tattoos. Possible prison record (disqualifying him permanently, in Sabrina's mind - the STDs and God only knew what else). Wild hair, more care put into it than he would likely admit. *Horrible* facial hair: a too carefully groomed and yet tangled, beard.

Jimmy *would* have made the cut, in spite of his beard, (prison record investigation pending, and probably a demand for a clean test just to be sure - this just wasn't fun if there wasn't intimate cum involved). But he was also stubbornly regular in his employment and not very ambitious, so he wasn't going anywhere.

"Going somewhere else, soon," was also a requirement for Sabrina's conquests.

Jimmy probably knew the score with Sabrina, even though they'd never talked about it openly. It was the kind of thing a guy like Jimmy sorted out pretty quickly. He seemed content to just watch it all play out.

Jimmy was to Sabrina's sexual exploits what a soccer hooligan was to the beautiful game: a fan. He cheered, he never missed a play, he sometimes drank too much and trashed things when it didn't go as planned. He would employ any dirty trick in the book to make sure his team won.

But he didn't *play*.

"What's that guy's name, there?" She pointed her stick in the direction of the guy she liked, and not at all discreetly. It was one am. Everyone in the bar was off work, going home tomorrow, drinking heavily, fishing for something in the last hours of the night. Nobody would even notice that kind of thing.

Half of Jimmy's mouth turned up with genuine interest: if it had been a long time for Sabrina, it seemed to have been a long time for Jimmy, too. He tossed a towel over his shoulder and submerged his hands in the glass washer so he could talk to Sabrina without taking a break from his job.

Her nose crinkled with delight when Jimmy got talking: his Cajun accent was sexy as hell, and he turned it up for her. Somehow imported from Louisiana, he had a rough, trashy way about him mixed with country charm and can-do.

And that accent. Nowhere on earth did the mischievous, fluid, sexuality of the French get distilled into a better man-drink than in Louisiana.

"Aha, the rich man. I'm afraid you're too late, boo, he has already taken up with the girls there, the models." Jimmy frowned theatrically, sticking out his lower lip. "I'm afraid *you* are too old, *cherie*."

Jimmy moved his arm away, as if he actually thought Sabrina would slap him, as he grinned widely and tipped his head back to mimic cackling without making a sound.

Sabrina rolled her eyes and chewed on the very tip of the wooden stick, one eye on the man she actually cared about, in case he looked over at her. If that happened, she had one olive left and a way of eating them that Jimmy claimed made any man horny.

"Nah," he laughed, without her saying anything. He knew she wasn't after the rich man, he was only messing with her. "Which one, boo, the muscles?"

Sabrina glowered playfully at him.

Jimmy glanced over his shoulder and then back at Sabrina, submerging his hands again. He had a way of washing glasses that was fairly erotic: his wiry forearms went up and down in the suds in a rhythmic motion that

cleaned the glasses efficiently, thoroughly, and without cracking anything. Suds rolled over his forearms and tattoos, and alluded to the kind of creamy, strong, sloshy experience you could have in his hands.

Nothing ever slipped out of Jimmy's capable fingers, however wet and slick it might be. He did earn points with her for that. She was always waiting for his last day at work. If he ever showed up and told her he was moving back to Louisiana, she would definitely consider a romp with him.

He grinned when she played coy and shrugged. "Ah. The one who looks a little like that actor, the Ryan Gosling," he said, a knowing tone in his voice.

Sabrina leaned forward, ignoring the comparison, which in her view wasn't very apt. "Is he *gay*, do you think?"

"No." Jimmy's answer was immediate, sounded like French, and made him smile into his suds. "A little young, though, no? And anyway, I have seen this man of yours. He's upstairs."

"Huh?" Sabrina said, dunking her olive and turning her attention to her phone.

This made Jimmy laugh. He didn't know *for sure* what was going on with Sabrina and her husband, and - his French blood apparently undiluted by generations of American existence in the swamplands - he didn't really care. He liked the mystique, and he was content to leave it intact by not asking questions.

"It's a joke, *cher*. You know what I'll do for you?" He was toweling his hands off, sleeves rolled up, stirring ideas in Sabrina's loins. "I'll make the magic happen."

"Graham is *not* here," Sabrina scolded, feeling the rush of excitement evaporate and leave her with a slight hangover. Her enthusiasm for the

conquest dampened a little: telling Graham about her adventures was fun, but it was always more fun for *her* if he was there for them.

Lately, this had become more true than ever.

When they had first started doing this, it had been intoxicating to the point of feeling like an actual drug. It was wrong, it was dangerous, it made them both wildly horny. She had been reluctant to go on her first adventure without Graham around somewhere close, watching over her.

But then she had finally done it solo, and it had been thrilling.

They had rules: she had to tell him everything. She did, of course: all the things that Graham was interested in.

But there was no way to *tell* someone *everything*. Something inevitably remained her own secret, and that had been delicious for a while, too.

Lately, though, she'd been feeling more like having Graham watching, even if she couldn't put her finger on why. Tonight especially: she hadn't realized it until Jimmy had joked with her and she had felt the spike of adrenaline, the flush of her skin.

Graham had written her back:

He's just playing it cool. go talk to him

She set her phone face down and sighed. Maybe she *was* getting too old for this.

The last thing Jimmy had said made its way into her consciousness. *I'll make magic happen.*

"What will you do?" she asked Jimmy. But Jimmy just winked, because by then someone else was seating himself at the bar and he needed to take

an order. Sabrina whirled in her chair and homed in thoughtfully on her choice of boy-toy for the evening. The after-party vibe of the bar was going to peak any minute now, and people would start wandering away.

She was high on excitement, her mind still racing like it did when she had to control all of the disasters and plans that an event like this required. She was *the* events planner. The head of it all, and her company handled the really expensive, the really big, the really important events.

It was over now, but her body and mind were still looking for something to do.

Someone, to state it more clearly.

"Bad break."

Sabrina heard this quite clearly. The timing was such that the comment could not have been meant any other way than the way she took it: as sympathy for losing her prospect. Her intended boy-toy had wandered off and now looked irretrievably lost, and Jimmy had shrugged apologetically for failing to "make the magic happen."

She was smiling into her still-unfinished martini before she even looked over at the man who had spoken.

It was the "rich guy" Jimmy had been joking about earlier.

Older than her, maybe older than Graham. Arrogant clothing, arrogant graying facial hair trimmed in a way that looked like it cost at least \$100 and he did it every day. Familiar face, though she didn't know why. Amusement in his features, interest in his eyes. Arrogance flowing off of him like radiation from Cesium.

She accepted another stickful of olives from Jimmy, who pouted sympathetically at her about the lost boy-toy, and plunked them into her drink. She did not play games with it in her mouth, but squished it like a farm girl and let a snort escape her nose.

She had, over time, developed the habit of not immediately revealing her voice to men. It was an ethereal, angelic voice that flitted around breathlessly and made her sound like a teenager on the cusp of womanhood.

The voice was so incongruous with her personality and actual age that it had caused headache after headache. Men heard it and thought all the wrong things: dainty, pushover, sweet.

She nodded in the man's direction, chewing, and swished the martini in its stemless glass, which was all the response this rich guy was going to get.

Jimmy was washing glasses again, freshly entertained and grinning at her.

Sabrina wondered if Jimmy had somehow filled this older guy's head with nonsense while she wasn't paying attention. Jimmy did shit like that.

When she looked back at the man, his eyes were on her wedding ring. She was twisting it subconsciously, a habit she didn't feel one way or the other about. For all she knew, it was part of her seduction game.

He did not immediately avert his eyes, like other men did.

"Plenty of fish in the sea, though," the man commented, at last looking up at her.

A ripple of white-hot heat seared through her and landed between her legs, out of nowhere, completely unexpected. It throbbed as it faded away.

She felt her lips quivering into an erratic series of smiles, something she couldn't disconnect from her nervous system no matter how hard she tried. It lured men in, anyway, whether she personally hated it or not. She downed

her martini in a sign of resignation and nudged the glass back toward Jimmy, who would refill it at his leisure.

She met his eyes. What she saw was startling: he wasn't hopeful, he wasn't dissuaded, he wasn't interested, and he wasn't intrigued.

He was still sizing her up.

"You're not really my type," she told him, flatly. There was no need for her to soften a statement like this: her voice did it for her.

And anyway, it was the truth.

"Nor are you mine," he returned, sanguine.

Jimmy, shaking his head. Under his breath: "She is everybody's type, man." He winked at Sabrina and strolled, whistling, to the far end of the bar.

Sabrina's eyes moved briefly to the man's hands. No wedding ring.

She knew the man had caught her looking, and that annoyed her.

She had better set him doubly straight about her intentions. She leaned in on her elbows, to say in a low whisper: "Do you know which guy I was after? Tell me this..." and then she paused, only long enough to register that he did, in fact, know which guy she was after: he was staring at her calmly without looking around.

Interesting.

"...do you think he's gay?"

"It's hard to know these days."

Sabrina smiled. Genuinely funny, though she resented the implication that this guy - pushing sixty, however well-preserved he might be - was bracketing her in an age group with *himself*.

"It is, isn't it?" she said, pulling on both sides of the plastic wrapper of a cinnamon mint Jimmy had deposited in front of her minutes before. The plastic untwisted, she twisted it again, holding it like a toy between her

hands. This allowed her to look at him and appear to be looking at the candy. "I'm guessing it doesn't matter much to you, though."

"I'm not gay."

She stopped twisting. Amused again, her mouth quivering away. "I know *that*. I just meant..." she lifted her eyes and met his - steely, unflinching, welcoming - stare. "You probably don't care if girls are doing girls when they're not doing you. Me...?" She scrunched up her nose in distaste.

He held his hands open in mock defeat. They were manicured, expensively. He was exceedingly rich. She imagined he had no trouble at all getting what he wanted.

"*That's* a bit unfair," she lamented. She was playing now. She was tired anyway, and she had never been *that* into the guy who'd just wandered off. Without Graham waiting, it was likely to be a little bit of a disappointment anyway.

She was going to stay in town that night anyway, she just decided, just to let Graham simmer a bit. *He* liked that.

Jimmy had another martini ready for her and set it down, raising his eyebrows to the gentleman, who nodded coolly.

"Hmm," he said, so delayed that she had to think for a moment about what she'd just said.

A real, sardonic smile on half of her mouth. "You don't agree?"

She boldly looked him up and down, and leaned over, to get her eyes around the corner of the bar. She did all of this very obviously: she wanted him to see that she was taking in the whole package. Fit, trim stomach, wiry build.

Inwardly a part of her mind emitted a snore: usually, this spelled doctor. Doctors, in general and at all ages, were a bore and way too insistent on

condoms and following rules.

"You don't look like a man who's having any trouble getting what you want," she commented dryly.

He was ready with his answer. "You'd be surprised."

Jimmy, hanging up wine glasses, head shaking. His lips moved: *she would not*.

Sabrina smiled the kind of smile that was for herself and meant to be seen that way. The man's right pointer finger subtly extended toward Jimmy, the remainder of his hand on the snifter of amber-colored liquid pooled at the base of a large ice block. "Is he your husband?"

Sabrina glanced at Jimmy. No one had ever been so direct with her about her lifestyle, so unflinching, so apathetic. "Jimmy? No. Supportive friend."

Jimmy, always listening, tossed a glass from behind his back and caught it as he whirled to the far end of the bar, glowing.

"Aha. And what's your husband like? If I may inquire?"

This caught her off-guard, and it was evident on her face before she could stop it. She shifted, re-crossing her legs, to buy herself some time. She didn't often get caught in a situation like this, not knowing what to say. Young guys wanted to pretend Graham didn't exist, for the most part.

Once she composed herself, she pulled an olive from the stick and popped it into her mouth in a deliberately un-sexy gesture.

"No," she told him. Graham was off-limits.

He lifted his glass and sipped his whiskey, smiling like he had hoped for an answer like that. "He intrigues me, either way."

A ruckus at the entrance caught their attention: the boy-toy was returning with his friends. A smoker, no surprise there. Sabrina didn't care: she had

mints, she liked the combination of tobacco and cinnamon, she usually didn't kiss that much anyway. Sometimes she smoked a cigarette after sex.

The group of young guys were sitting at the bar, deeply involved in a male conversation that, like most male conversation, involved a ton of shit-talking. She watched them: the boy-toy stole a glance her way. It looked for a moment like he might flinch when he met her eyes.

Instead, to her supreme pleasure, his gaze remained on hers. He smiled fleetingly, before a friend punched him on the shoulder and hollered "Explain that to Roy, then!"

Sabrina's hair was freshly cut to just above her shoulders. It was a sassy, brazen cut, with large natural waves that most young girls would kill for. She made the waves bounce as she turned her attention to the man sitting next to her.

Probably, if not for his presence, she would have just gone upstairs and gone to bed. Boy-toy was now looking younger, less appealing because he was drinking, and something about the change of light had rubbed the shine off him.

Or so it seemed.

She was confused by this change in her own feelings, almost as confused as she was by her original attraction to him. It came on suddenly.

Her sudden distaste was feeding in from a different place than normal. She knew this as she grinned at the older man, her lips parted to give him a pithy farewell.

"Well," she said. "Bye-bye."

"Are you going after him?"

Her heart raced for a second, and she was thrown off her game again. He answered so quickly. Almost like it *was* his business.

It infuriated her.

The older man was looking at her with a neutral expression.

She hopped off her bar stool, smiling. The less said, the better. She glanced over at the gaggle of young women in pink skirts with pink drinks at the table the man had come from. Their platinum hair shone white in the overhead lights. They were obviously interested in this old man (because he clearly had money, and he wasn't bad-looking). He had no reason not to be interested in them. Why was he up here bothering *her*?

"*Bon chance*," she said, her eyes moving to the women so he knew what she was talking about. Bon chance was a Jimmy expression. Happy hunting, she had meant to say: you for yours, and me for mine.

But the infuriating man had another quick answer: "I don't need it."

She picked up her drink and tipped it in his direction, ruffled by his blase reply, but only for a moment. Jesus, what a *jackass*.

"Me either. So... *bon nuit*, I guess."

She turned, exasperated for reasons she didn't fully understand, and left the well-trimmed and manicured rich man at the end of the bar.

She had no plan of attack for boy-toy, whom she'd written off when he went to go outside and smoke, and seemed like a lot of work now. He looked less appealing the closer she got to him, and if the well-heeled arrogant bastard at the end of the bar hadn't been there, she probably would have high-fived Jimmy and headed out on her own.

But a competitive instinct had been ignited in her. How dare that old man think he didn't need luck? How dare he presume she couldn't bag any guy she chose to?

So, to prove a point, she went up behind the young guy and slipped her shoulder between him and his friend. She had appealing, strong shoulders,

something that could only be seen or imagined when they were bare. She had slipped her suit jacket off as she walked, draping it over one arm and shifting her martini smoothly to the other hand.

She was broadcasting all this raw sexuality not to the boy-toy, not to Jimmy, not to Graham - but to the man at the end of the bar. But no one could ever find that out, and she herself wasn't going to linger on the thought for long.

She put it out of her mind and let her eyes wander over the more appealing parts of the young guy's physique.

"Hey," she said to the boy-toy, and her girlish voice washed over him like an elixir. She could see the change in him. "Can I talk to you about something?"

Of course she could, and of course he would.

She lifted her eyes as she retreated from between them. She gave him a meaningful look and then strolled out without waiting for a reply from the young guy. She met and held the older man's gaze for a full and sizzling moment as she did so. Her eyes moved in a smooth arch, up and away.

A victorious smile on her lips, she never looked back. Of course boy-toy was coming with her. And it would be fun, because it always was.

But the older man was on her mind as she walked out the door and into the lobby.

He was smiling, staring right at her, his own drink on its way to his mouth, a chuckle subtly shaking in his torso.

Chapter Three

"I'm surprised to see you here."

Sabrina had a coffee in two hands and she stared over it as the man from the bar pulled out a chair and sat down. Her heart began to thump wildly in her chest, and kind of nebulous sensation of eroticism coated the inside of her skin. It was pleasant and unnerving: she didn't want to fuck this guy, but she was getting hot in a kind of general way.

Who the fuck was this guy?

"Please," she said warmly, with an acidic twist. "Invite yourself to sit down."

He was already seated and made no move to apologize, or appear ashamed of his manners.

"I'm guessing this is safe, up here."

He was referring to the top floor restaurant, where coffee and a croissant cost you \$50. The implication, of course, was that the bedraggled roadie she'd taken to bed the night before couldn't afford to eat there.

And within this comment was the tacit acknowledgment that she preferred not to have breakfast with the man she'd taken to bed. A kind of dirty

complicity stretched between them: he was here having breakfast alone as well, not in bed with one of the pink-encrusted floozies he'd been with at the bar.

Sabrina glared at the comment, but her mouth was open in poorly disguised shock.

"How was your conquest?" he asked cheerfully.

"How were yours?" she retorted, with equal cheer.

He chuckled and produced a printed paper from somewhere. She glanced at it. *Wall Street Journal*. Naturally. And who read *papers* anymore?

Sabrina only had sex with guys who probably wouldn't know what a newspaper was if they saw it in her hands.

She was taken back to one godawful moment when one of her conquests had asked her what to write on an envelope in order to mail it, and where to put the stamp. It made her laugh, now, but at the time it had been deeply unsettling.

The man was looking at her when her eyes went back to his. A series of unspoken, competitive volleys went across the table. His lips twisted a little, hers curled in affectionate distaste. He found this amusing, she could tell.

She sipped her coffee and pretended not to care.

Her conquest, in truth, had been a bit disappointing. It was bound to happen. It had before. Sabrina had learned to brush that sort of thing off.

It troubled her, however, that she couldn't pinpoint the source of her disappointment: Hayden, aside from his unfortunate Gen-Z name, had followed her into the elevator, and then to her room. His eyes had darted around continually, looking for an exit or some kind of catch, but because he didn't find either, he had stayed.

Once she had stripped naked, he was re-activated. He had been very satisfactory and responsive to commands. By the end of the tryst, he had been functioning quite capably without much coaching.

Graham would like the story she would tell him. Everything was good... but the taste of dissatisfaction had still been in her mouth.

The man across the table from her raised his eyebrows. He was still waiting for her answer.

Sabrina became incensed. And then incensed that she was incensed. She had also asked him the same question, but he wasn't going to answer it, and she knew that.

He also seemed to know that she would eventually feel too uncomfortable not to spurt something out. Which is what she did next, to her own dismay.

"I've done a remarkable favor for some future lover," she said with a smile.

"How charitable."

"Everything has a price."

"Mmm. And your husband, I take it, approves of your... hobbies?"

The audacity. Really. Who *was* this guy, and why was she letting him sit here like this? "It's a shared hobby."

"I thought as much," he said, as his coffee arrived. He was almost paternalistic in his tone. Once again, Sabrina was thrown off: he didn't seem shocked in the slightest. If anything, he seemed to like the idea. If anything, he seemed to almost think the whole idea, the whole secret between Graham and Sabrina, was his own.

He looked around. "Are you swingers, then? Or something else?"

She smiled mysteriously and sipped her coffee. That was none of his business.

He liked this, too.

"It's just that I don't see him here this morning. Your husband."

Sabrina felt the contours of danger closing in around her. She needed to squirm her way out of this guy's orbit. She was getting interested in something about him, and that something wasn't as carefree as she wanted it to be.

It wasn't purely physical.

She had a test for herself: if this wasn't the kind of thing she'd enjoy telling Graham about - or God forbid, if it was something she'd avoid telling Graham about - then it was dangerous. In all the wrong ways.

She loved Graham, and they had a deal: There was fucking guys as part of their game, and then there were gray areas of which Graham was largely forgiving. But beyond that gray area was cheating, in its plain, old-fashioned, unacceptable form.

With younger guys, there was never any chance of a problem on her end: one or two misunderstandings on *theirs*, but those were easily cleared up.

When Graham was *in* the room, it was all very, very clear to everyone what was going on. Well, mostly everyone. Sometimes the crazy little shits thought they'd steal her away from her husband.

This guy, though: she didn't get what he was up to, and she didn't get what was getting under her skin about him. He was too old, he didn't seem to be hitting on her, and yet he had a hook in her consciousness.

Sabrina decided to get going. "Well," she said, standing up. She was not in the same clothing she'd been wearing the night before, and she wanted him to make note of that. This was not a walk of shame, and she was only up here in this restaurant because it was a lovely view and better coffee.

"It's been very... interesting, but I have to get going." She glanced down at the remains of her coffee, croissant, and a bowl of fruit. She fluttered her hand over it. "That'll go on my account," she told him. "I'll tell the manager to pick up yours as well."

"It's the least you could do," he quipped.

What the hell did that mean? "Okay. Well. Have a great stay in our fair city. Make sure to take in the sights."

"I live here."

She furrowed her brow. "What are you doing here, then?" she snorted, referring to the Hilton, which was notoriously expensive and - as anyone local knew - one of the crappiest Hiltons in the nation.

He leaned back and stretched his arms over a chair. "I came to see Red Velvet at work. I'm thinking of turning over several events to them."

Sabrina felt the blood drain from her face. She closed her eyes, bit into her lower lip, and nodded her head very briefly: a single, perfunctory dip. She was smiling in spite of herself, too.

Red Velvet was her company.

This guy was a potential client, and he was loaded. This was obviously, probably, very bad from a business perspective, but in Sabrina's case, not terrible: he only looked like a very wealthy client. In her experience, that didn't always translate to lucrative business for *her*. He could very well be the type of fake-rich bastard who would stiff her and everyone else on the bills.

Also, she was established enough and making enough money that, while it certainly stung that she might have lost business somehow, it was hardly devastating.

"Aha," she said, still smiling - a little sheepishly, she had to admit. "And what did you think?"

She wondered if he knew she was the owner. Most people assumed she was not: she worked too hard at a job she could have easily pawned off on a paid employee.

He grinned and unfolded his newspaper. "About the company? Or the employees?"

She shrugged. "Either one."

"Well. Everything seems to have gone off without a hitch," he said, opening the paper. His eyes drifted to the columns of text inside and then he began turning the pages, folding the paper closed as he did.

"You know you can get that in digital access," she told him, smirking.

"Does your employer know what you get up to at these events?"

She felt a very satisfying rush, a bloom of dopamine in her head that might as well have been injected like a hard drug. He *didn't* know she was the owner. How delicious.

"I don't have an employer," she said. "I own Red Velvet."

This information was unexpected to him, but the only disturbance it caused on his very tidy features was a slower blink, a minute curl of his upper lip, and a glimmer in his eyes that was gone before she could even be sure that she saw it. She concluded that he was a real man with real money, well-seasoned, not easily thrown off-guard.

She retrieved a business card from her purse, a set of motions she deployed so frequently that it came as second nature. It was on the table before she realized her blunder, and by then it was too late to take it back.

She, after all, had only meant to back up her (true) claim. To dismiss his attempt to diminish her by asking about her "employer."

The card, however, was embellished with her photograph, name, job title, and contact information. All of which could be taken by this mysterious and infuriating gentleman as an invitation for him to contact *her*.

Which it was not.

That was not, under any circumstances, what she wanted to do.

He moved the paper to look down at the card, smiled, and looked up at her. Amusement flickered in his eyes again, which steamed her right from the back of her neck, down her spine, and right to the end of the nerves that spindled out from the center of her clitoris.

She knew that she was still staring down at the card with what probably came across as surprise, because she herself *was* surprised at herself. All of this "game" was fun for her because it left *her* in charge, turning the tables on the tired old cliché of male dominance in the sexual exploits field. She didn't have anything to prove, she didn't answer to anyone. She was free of expectations about her behavior. And yet here she was, trying to sell herself to this... arrogant bastard.

She wished she could take the card back. There was something not right about him having it, about her giving it to him. It implied something, and the worst part about it was that the implication had some truth to it:

Interest. He was holding her interest.

Not the base, sexual interest she was allowed to have in her arrangement with Graham.

A gray-area interest.

Maybe even a worse kind of interest.

Well, she decided. It wasn't as if she could take the card *back* now.

"I didn't catch *your* name," she said, pulling her phone from her purse to make it look like she needed to attend to something urgently.

"Grant."

She gave a tiny shake of her head and laughed lightly. "Grant...?"

He turned the page, nodding at her like she was an idiot. He was amused with himself.

"Grant, that's it? Like Elvis?" she clarified, more than a little annoyed.

He chuckled. "I'll be in touch, Mrs. Cole."

She had no idea what to say to that. She hoped he didn't call, she hoped he did. A shard of guilt stabbed her in the chest: her reasons for hoping he did were not all monetary.

But "Grant" saved her from fumbling again.

"I like what I see," he added.

A simmering look over the pages of the paper. Sabrina, momentarily disarmed, struggled to think of anything to say back to that. It had been a long time since someone had been that direct, that suggestive, that... infuriatingly superior... with her. She was at a loss.

She was thrilled when the waitress headed toward them. She was pretty, young, a mass of sandy brown curls in halo about her head.

"Kit, make sure anything... Grant here... orders goes on my bill."

"No need," the mysterious Grant told Kit.

"No bother," Sabrina told him pointedly.

He looked up at her. Kit looked back and forth between them, aware that something dangerous was in the air but at a loss as to what it might be. Her torso shuddered with a trembling, nervous laugh that had no sound. "Uh..."

"On *my* bill," Sabrina repeated, putting a twenty in Kit's hand for a tip. "Bye, then."

And she turned, walked swiftly away, and did not look back.

Hopefully, she would never see this guy again.

Chapter Four

Is it cheating not to mention someone you only spoke to? Someone you wouldn't sleep with, even if he were paying you to? If you give all the details about the man you *actually* slept with to your husband, and if you will probably not see the other guy ever again? Was it cheating if she didn't tell Graham she had given this guy her card?

She talked to a hundred guys a day sometimes. She didn't tell Graham about every single interaction, every little puff of attraction, or errant thought about their cocks that she had. There was no way Graham told her every time he interacted with some woman he found mildly attractive or interesting in some way.

Men, after all, had *some interest* in the owner of every pussy they came into contact with. That was a fact she accepted.

She didn't feel like Graham had to tell her about every single one.

But would she have wanted to know about something like this? These weird thoughts in her head. The hum of sexual energy that encompassed her. How would she even do that? She didn't even know what the fuck it was herself.

Graham was waiting for her at home, she reasoned, and what he wanted was the story of her real, sexual adventures with the *roadie*.

Not some tepid, uninteresting story about an old man she ran into at the bar and then again at breakfast.

What would she even say about him? That he was older?

She wasn't going to fuck him. That was absolutely certain.

She knew Graham liked the stories. It was an intuition: he never said as much, straight-out. But she could feel the contours of his desires, and he liked hearing about it secondhand. But he wanted stories about what she did in a bedroom (or bathroom, or car, or stairwell), not details about the chit-chat at the bar or breakfast table.

All the advice they'd ever read on the internet or received from anyone "in the know" about their lifestyle recommended pure, undiluted honesty about every single detail. Deciding on boundaries well before the event. Always together, never without permission. That kind of thing.

But she and Graham had an understanding: some of the fun and the danger was in *not* scripting everything, not knowing for sure what would happen before things got going.

As long as their loyalties were ultimately with each other, who cared?

Up until now, that was how things had been.

So not mentioning this Grant - like not mentioning that the guy she'd fucked was wearing a yellow shirt, or that he'd had trouble finding her clit when she sat on his face - was not some unprecedented, crazy omission.

It was a sexless, anodyne detail.

Why was she even thinking about it?

It was gumming up the works as she tried to refine her story for Graham. The real story. The one about the roadie.

She tried out some ideas on her way home. She always did that. Graham liked her stories because she took some care and time to enhance them to make them their best.

The roadie - *Hayden*, she reminded herself, annoyed - had been afraid of her at first.

He was awkward once she got him alone, sitting nervously on the edge of the bed as if he wanted to bolt for the door. His skin, beneath the shirts and cargo shorts, was pale, and he had an avuncular strangeness to him, even with all of his wiry strength. She found herself wondering why she'd brought him up there, feeling ready to let him flee if he wanted to. She gave him ample chances, going into the bathroom to "freshen up" and taking forever in there.

Sometimes it was fun to have a guy like that under her control. Other times it was a drag. It really depended on her mood. And her mood, in this case, had been altered somehow.

By that ass-hat "Grant" at the bar.

But Hayden was a man, and a young man at that, and she had lured him up there with the very obvious promise of sex. He may have been nervous and awkward, but he wasn't going to run away on his own steam. He had a big cock coming to life in his pants, tenting the heavy canvas fabric, twitching with need, and he was sitting with a drink in his hand on the edge of the bed where she'd left him, a look of steely resolve in his eyes.

He was infinitely more attractive that way.

She had slipped into a black silk nightie and a pair of sensual, lace-embroidered panties. If he was going to fumble or run away out of fear, this getup would speed the process up. He swallowed a large ice cube and almost choked on it when she went back in (a detail Graham would love),

but after recovering (by swallowing the cube, tears gathering in his eyes as it slowly, painfully, made its way down his esophagus), he remained stubbornly committed.

Sitting on the edge of the bed. Waiting.

She stood in front of him and let her lips do their supposedly magical thing.

Like some actresses, her lips trembled and quivered in fleeting, micro-smiles. They dissolved and became another wave of half-expressed emotion, and then again shifted shapes. To someone who didn't know her, this could be mistaken for anything: hesitation, a secret, timidity, a private joke, desire. If she burned into their eyes with her limpid blues framed by her long lashes, men chose to look at her lips and see in their movements whatever they wanted to see.

Hence their magic.

Hayden gazed at her and then became uncomfortable. "Uh..." he said, scratching his head. His eyes went to her wedding ring and then back to her mouth.

She slipped one strap of the nightie from her left shoulder and stepped closer to him. He exhaled. "Your, uh... husband isn't going to, uh, you know... show up or something. Is he?"

She had flicked the other strap from her right shoulder. The nightie began to peel down, carried by the weight of the straps. She touched the receding collar line with her middle finger, rubbing her skin sensually.

Her lips moved in response to his question, but they gave him no answer. Did she think this was funny? Was she too timid to talk about it? He didn't know. But because her nightie was mostly slippery silk, sliding down her body, and her areolae so large that they were peeking out from behind it

already, his attention was getting drawn to them. She gave a shake of her head - enough to make the waves sway above her smooth shoulder, no more.

She smiled and moved closer, her knees within millimeters of his. Playfully, she brushed one against his leg. The glass in his hand - she had instructed him to make himself a drink and he had - was slipping from his fingers. He wasn't noticing.

She stepped closer. It was at this point that she could determine with certainty whether or not a guy had ever been propositioned by an older woman. If he had, he jumped right in at this point. If he hadn't, he stared at her like a deer, or a stray dog being offered a huge steak.

This was a moment that required discretion and skill. Some of them, she had to tell: *I have an arrangement with him*. Some of them knew about that kind of thing, and were seasoned professionals who packed up immediately afterward and left. Some of them became so fascinated by it they stuck around afterward, which could be a drag.

It was a risky move for that reason.

Hayden was staring at her lips, not moving. She stared him down, twisting her torso a little, making the silk graze his thigh just below his shorts. While she played this seductive role, she lost patience with the boy-toy.

Her mind kept returning to her unusual encounter at the bar, to the older man who wouldn't leave her mind. Why?

And then *this* guy, who was so infuriatingly timid.

It boiled over, the whole combination.

"Take your shirt off," she told him, more sternly than she meant to. Most of the demand in her voice came from some other place in her mind, the

miasma of thoughts about the man at the bar that she couldn't stop turning over and over.

Hayden looked surprised. Momentarily. But her insistent voice must have tripped a wire in him somewhere, and he rushed to comply. It had invigorated him. She took the slipping drink from his hand to help him along, and let it fall to the carpeted floor with a thud.

After ridding his chest of the shirt - revealing his appealing, work-induced chest muscles and the sparing wisps of hair on his lithe body, he kicked into gear and his hands came reaching eagerly for her.

That was more like it. She pushed his hands down to her knees.

"Stroke the back of my knees," she instructed him coolly, and then gave him a smile when he did it right. His fingers seemed like a hoard of huskies, straining at the end of their leads, wanting to go up further but compelled by her icy eyes to stay where they were.

Restlessly he pawed at the soft part behind her knees, while she tugged the nightie down to reveal her breasts. He was instantly absorbed: all men were. They were far from perfect, she would never be a lingerie model or renown for them. But they were captivating to men because they were somehow unexpected. Their shape was unusual, even more so on her frame. They captured Hayden's attention now.

His fingers became useless, and she was worried for a moment that he would be useless all around: it was one thing to gently order a young guy into the first few passes, but having to instruct one all the way through sex? *Tedious.*

Just when she began to despair, he took initiative. Seemingly overcome by something (perhaps he suddenly realized that he was, in fact, in a hotel room with a woman on offer who wanted no strings whatsoever), he bit into

the bunched-up fabric of the nightie and began to pull it down with his teeth.

His hands, at the same time, moved upward. Along her outer thighs, up to her ass. When he cupped it, he exhaled through his nose and the heat of it scattered across her belly.

Only then did the thing she was after - the undiluted, surging, optimistic testosterone of youth - start to fill his veins, and his muscles, and his breath, and his eyes. His fingers gripped more insistently, his muscles flexed. She moved her shin between his legs to rub against the cargo pants and she felt the pulse of his cock as it twitched in anticipation.

Her fingers had innocently moved into his hair. He hadn't noticed. So when she gripped a fistful of it violently in her fist and turned his head up to her, he was again surprised.

"I want you to eat my pussy," she told him, and he nodded. What else could he do?

She started to pull the nightie over her head. Nothing was left but her panties, and his eyes wanted to look down, but they were locked on hers and he was afraid to. This made her grin.

She wriggled sexily to get herself onto his lap: he had to scoot backward to keep them both from sliding off the edge of the bed. Settling in, still to his amazement, she brought her lips very close to his and met his eyes. Brushing first her breath, then her shapeshifting lips, over his mouth, she told him what she wanted.

What she promised to give him, if he made her come.

There was never any need for a threat after that: the simplest push backward and he fell down. His hands moved clumsily as she walked

herself over him, straddling him, crawling at first so that her breasts dangled just out of reach of his lips.

He returned his hands to her ass, and then surprised her, pleasantly, by flipping his palms to cup her buttocks and cradle them as she lowered her pussy toward his mouth. She drew one of her fingers sexily down her navel and to the panties, to part the sewn-in slit that allowed him access to her pussy.

He emitted a short, mangled murmur of surprised pleasure when he saw the panties.

She moved as he drove his tongue in, until she managed to get his tongue where she wanted it. She let the full weight of her body sink slowly onto his mouth, and then retrieved his hands - they had gone limp in shock - to place them on her breasts.

When she got close she squeezed his head between her thighs and rolled her hips against his face. She could feel the outlines of his teeth on the ridge of her clit and thinking of a bite at a moment like that gave her a perverse flutter of arousing fear. She felt her juices pouring into his mouth and let herself shudder to a sweaty, exhausted stop, all without letting him breathe much.

He was looking up expectantly at her. She would never know why it had taken her so long to realize the kind of power that she had over men, but now she did: they all had this look on their face after making her come.

She had always thought it was women who needed men's approval, and it was only because Graham had pointed this out to her, and it was only because of their lifestyle choices that he had done so:

It was actually the other way around.

And so, maybe there was more to it than just a game of domination and submission in the bedroom when she looked down at her latest conquest with an expression of neutral thoughtfulness, letting him think that she might scowl in disappointment and crush him.

She leaned back, still neutral, and used one hand to unbutton his shorts and dip her hand into them (he wore no underwear). He was stunned when she took his cock in her hand. It was hard, every inch of skin pressed out from the inside so that the veins, the foreskin (almost half the guys this age had one), the flesh itself, was taut to the point of bursting. She twisted her hand so the underside of her fingers were pressed against the base, near his ball sack, and then she clamped down slowly.

Only then did she smile, let out a laugh. It was not entirely for his benefit, but partly for her own. She felt the surge of semen, blood and electricity as her approval reached him. His cock, average in size, maybe a little longer than she had expected, fought against her grip. Under her thighs and her ass, she felt his abdominal muscles flexing, moving. He wanted to sit up.

She relented, letting her body go loose so he could wriggle his way to a seated position. The shorts were dispensed of somehow in this transition: she had long ago learned that men were very, very capable of undressing themselves somewhere along the way.

His hands took to her hips. Before she had to let go of his cock (due to physical realities), she felt a slow, steady drip of precum oozing down his shaft. She brushed over the crown as she pulled her hand away to rest it on his shoulder. The crown was as slick as if he'd just pulled it out of her pussy.

When he started to gently push against her hips - the expectation she had set up was that she would suck his cock and nibble on his balls, and he

evidently had imagined her on her knees for that - she resisted. Leaning in to his ear, tightening the grip of her thighs, smiling, she explained to him:

"I have to go home with a pussy full of cum, and I feel like..." She turned her head, felt his cock bounce against her tailbone, brushing up against her asshole. "You might..." she continued, lips always just about to brush his, "cum in my mouth... the minute... I..." She closed her lips around her own finger, the one she had been using to sweep up his precum while she said all this.

He shuddered. They always shuddered when she said something like this. She pushed her hips back and looked down between their bodies at the cock wagging between their naked centers. As if on cue, a bead of precum oozed from the tip, slowly at first and then in a rush. She pushed up on her knees, tossed her hair as if to indicate that she'd proven her point.

And then, smiling, but in her eyes not a trace of apologia like she would have had in her youth (*so I promised you a blowjob. Cry me a river*), she eased her dripping pussy to the tip of his cock. Her pussy lips swallowed the fat bulb of his crown, and he stated to pull her down to sink all the way in.

Her arms resting on his shoulders, her lower lip tucked under a white tooth - but not with uncertainty, with delight - she appraised his feverish need.

"It's very important," she instructed him, enjoying the bouncy struggle of his cock as it seized up inside of her, "that you make me come again before you fill my pussy up. Can you do that?"

Slavishly, eagerly, his lips wet and saliva brimming in the corners of his mouth, he nodded. Young, cock-sure, it was clear from the adrenaline tensing his muscles and the light in his eyes, a mist of fear of failure

gathering over them like a cloud, that no woman had ever given him a task quite like that, and his imagination had never been allowed to run this far and free away from reality.

She sank down and his cock was inside her. Smiling, she rolled and swayed on his hips, letting her face and her throat advise him of the pleasure she was taking in each position. She tipped her head back and groaned wetly with pleasure when she got his cock aimed where she wanted it, exactly. She had to lean back, holding onto him by one hand, her other hand brushing over her stomach. She tapped on the very small bump just above her pubic bone, where his crown was stretching and expanding her flesh.

"Can you do that?" she repeated. Just for the kicks. His cock seemed to fight like a cat in a sack inside of her.

She was clinging to him by her heels. The whole thing was probably terribly uncomfortable for him, but in her experience, men didn't give a shit about discomfort. The only thing he could feel right now was his dick and whatever she was radiating from her eyes. He tensed, his cock pulsed inside her, he had to squeeze his eyes shut while he nodded.

"Can you?" she asked, smiling, rocking her body. She made a bunch of noise then, and most of it was genuine. His cock felt so good.

"Yes," he grunted in a stage whisper, his fingers closing on her flesh and squeezing tight.

"Oh good," she said, grinding against him.

He had given up on doing anything but trying to keep his churning, boiling load of cum inside his cock. She moved slowly, and a breath of air inside him sort of sobbed, because he was so close that she knew by now he was thinking of car insurance or rotten food in an attempt to keep it all in.

Sabrina loved this kind of power. She loved the strain it put young men under - so different from men her own age, who had to turn inward to keep their dicks hard. Older men had no trouble completing this task, and that made it boring for Sabrina.

Pressing his head to the side of her face, riding him how she wanted to, gleaning her own second orgasm from him, so obviously without a care in the world for his struggles, she added: "I'll be very disappointed if you don't."

"Ptuhd," he sort of exclaimed, and his hands went back to the bed to steady himself. His face was red with concentration, he tried to shift himself so her pussy didn't stroke him in the same way, he looked up at the ceiling, his face was tortured.

She continued to grind against him. "I'm so close," she told him, a grin on her face. Some kind of partial meanness was coming out in her, and thoughts that didn't belong here at all: the smug expression of the man at the bar, a brief flash of him and the two dizzy pink-clad girls, a poisonous flurry of competitive urges that were base and nonsensical.

Hayden was gritting his teeth. He was holding himself as still as possible and watching her pussy sliding along his shaft, her belly curving inward, her breasts dangling before him, swaying with her unusual movement. When he finally met her eyes there was panic brewing in them.

She took pity on him, pushed him back to the bed, lowered herself onto him and rode him hard. She could feel his semen just before she came, admired his attempt to hide his orgasm in a frozen, open mouth from which no sound came, his red temples streaked by pressurized veins, terror in his eyes.

Her own orgasm was great, and she sat up to enjoy it. Hayden's cum spilled from her pussy and onto their thighs. Only then did he yell, and pull her by her hips to fuck the final spurts of his cum into her deep.

"Yeah," she said, "fill me up."

She moved her hands over his chest, slick with sweat, appreciating the youth of his body. There was always a moment that they lay there, stunned, as they took in the rational version of what they had just done.

Or rather, what had just happened.

She slapped him playfully on the thigh, and, lifting her leg over the top of him like one would dismount a horse, she hopped off and stood up to stretch.

"Hey," she said, turning around. He was still lying there, lifting his head to look at his cock, stunned. "Do you have your cigarettes on you?"

His shorts were bunched up around his ankles. He sat up, ran a hand through his mopish hair, and patted around for them.

She sat in a chair, shamelessly, tits out for him to admire. The panties were soaked and she made no move to do anything about them, other than pull them taut so they didn't bug her. She would show them to Graham while she told him the story, or maybe take them out and casually twist them in her hands. She folded her legs up to the chair and crossed just her ankles, holding a hand out for the cigarettes. With her other hand, she opened the window, and the eerie, concrete hum of the city came whooshing in after a much warmer than expected breeze.

"Toss them," she told him.

"I don't think you can smoke up here..."

She clapped her fingers to her hand. "I need a lighter, too."

He fished them out and tossed them, and she managed to catch them by diverting her knees to help her. She took one out, lighted it, inhaled, purred with pleasure, and then tossed the pack and lighter back to the bed. "Thank you," she told him.

He looked distrustful. She smiled. "I have to get some sleep before checkout."

He looked down at his shorts, his flaccid cock, the whole scene. She smoked and raised her eyebrows.

"Should we, uh...?"

Another smile. She waved him away with her fingers, shaking her head very slowly. His eyes were on her lips, like every man's at this point in the game: the same trembling secret or secret laughter or private joke pulled them into quarter-expressions and then into other fleeting expressions.

Flirty, flitty lips that never landed on any particular emotion, never parted to tell him what they meant - but conveyed very clearly that they were not the lips of a girlish whore who regretted what she had just done.

Quite the contrary.

Chapter Five

She was late coming home in the morning, which could have meant a lot of things. It was a tacit agreement between them that she was free to be her own creative director, so to speak. She sometimes sent him details in the middle of it, or teasing audio. Sometimes she went completely silent.

He sometimes showed up unannounced, or made suggestions.

This went against conventional wisdom among the lifestyle crowd, but Graham felt like it made both of them more honest. If they didn't know exactly what to expect, they had to adhere to the most important rules at all times, without losing the juicier parts of the whole idea: surprise, danger, an ambiance of things being taboo.

What was the point, without any of that?

He was puttering around all morning, wavering in a delicious suspense. Even if the guy she'd been after had turned out to be gay, or nothing had come of her evening, he was still aroused thinking about it. Just knowing it was possible. But as the early morning hours ticked by and she didn't return, he decided to go on a run.

She came home just as he was heading out the door.

With the look in her eyes.

"Oh," she said, her face teeming with sexual mischief. "You're headed out. Too bad."

She was wearing a businesslike but sexy black skirt, and a black bra under a white blouse that fit very snugly. The top three buttons were undone so that the two halves of the front provided snippets at every movement of her breasts, the bra, the shape of her body. She bumped the car door closed with her hip and leaned for a few moments against the vehicle, saying nothing. Her eyes did all the talking - all the searing of his inner organs, all the heating beneath his balls.

He backed up into the door to the house without saying anything, offering a grin in response. Sabrina knew full well that he would abandon whatever he was planning to do, so there wasn't any reason to say anything.

He knew she'd fucked someone. It didn't matter if she'd showered, which she didn't really seem to have done. It didn't matter if she was wearing the same clothes she'd left in, or her makeup was perfect. Fucking another guy always left a glow on her, one she couldn't hide if she'd wanted to.

But she didn't want to. Because that was their deal.

She was grinning as she walked past him, turning her head slightly, putting her mouth very close to his without actually touching him, trailing her fingers over the front of his shorts only to brush over his cock. He was in his early fifties, so even with his mind raging with pornographic images, his blood boiling as the unwashed scent of sex left her skin and slender tendrils of it curled into his nose - there was no guarantee his cock would be hard when he wanted it to. But today it was brought to life by the mysterious way she slinked past him.

Sabrina's smiles were innumerable, and many of them indecipherable. Just when he thought he'd seen them all, she showed up with a new one. Like a bizarre kind of Velcro, she picked things up from her contact with other people, from her own emotions, from some inner wizard that mixed and matched the elements of her smile with virtuosity.

There was something in *this* smile that he was sure he hadn't seen before.

There was an allure to this, and the allure is what he shared with her.

Never in a million years would he have confessed to her that the rawest emotion, the foundation of that allure, was actually fear.

White-cold, throttling, ball-gripping fear. Did the new concert of flickers and false-starts, quivers and upturned corners, signal that she was about to tell him everything and it was going to be fantastic?

Or had she found something in her tryst that she preferred to him? Something more than physical attraction, a hard cock, a bigger cock, great biceps (she was a fan), dangerous tattoos? A sigma male thirty years younger than him, who had not only the gift of youthful energy but a personality that could snatch her away?

That was the thrill. In a way, Sabrina knew it, but Sabrina understanding something and Sabrina hearing him admit to his fears were two different things. They had a safety net of sorts: Sabrina would never fall for some younger guy, because she loved Graham, and that love was real. That love was so strong it could endure any of this temptation.

"Besides," she had assured him once, "A young guy who wants a *relationship* with a woman that much older than him?" She scrunched up her nose in distaste. "That has mommy complex written all over it."

She wasn't touching *that* with a ten-foot pole. Sabrina had been an exceptional mother, but it was never her favorite cup of tea. And any

comparisons, spoken or not, between the age of a guy she was interested in and the age of her son, would shut everything down for a good long time. She did not want to go there, and she did not want to babysit.

She wanted to have sex with young, attractive guys with rock-hard cocks, and she wanted Graham to get off on it. None of this had even been her idea.

"I take it your gaydar was not off," he said, turning to follow her into the house.

Sabrina made a slow circle around the kitchen island and fluttered her eyes at him. "It wasn't." She had her middle finger down, the rest of her fingers poised like a pianist, and she was dragging it along like a needle on a record. Abruptly, she spun and opened the fridge, getting out a bottle of water.

A game ensued. "Can I make you coffee? Breakfast?" Graham asked. His cock was lurching to life.

She was drinking when she shook her head a little. Eyes on him, smiling over the water bottle. A drop of water - probably on purpose - escaped the bottle and splashed onto her bare chest. It slid, fattened, and then charted a sensual tack down her left breast and into the valley between them.

"I already ate."

He reached the counter and looked at her. She set the water bottle down and screwed the cap on, her fingers playing with the top of it, forming the same shapes she used to caress his dick and any other man's.

They simmered over the counter for a moment. Graham was happy to be in his fifties sometimes, and this was one such time. A younger man would not be able to stand there and get that much sexual energy radiated at him

by a woman. He would jump the gun. Graham was able to absorb it all, let it come to a boil, pressure building.

Sabrina was getting horny, he was getting horny. They had the house and their time to themselves. But unlike in youth, in the early days of their love - when they couldn't wait two minutes before tearing all their clothes off and fucking hastily - they needed to let things burn for a bit.

The game now was more like Chicken than anything else. Fun, sexy, Chicken. Sabrina undid another button of her blouse and fanned herself. "It's pretty hot in here." She unscrewed the water bottle cap and took another sip of water, let another droplet fall to her chest. Set it back down, twisted the cap closed again, grinning, looking at it as if she was devising a strategy.

Graham waited. Patiently.

"I'm still wearing the same underwear," she said, tightening the lid with three flitting fingers.

The underwear. The slitted underwear. Standing in front of the mirror they looked like ordinary, sexy underwear, and plastered to Sabrina's odd but alluring figure, they were hot as hell. But if she bent over, or spread her legs, a delicately embroidered seam cracked open, and the always carefully waxed, pale outer lips of her pussy and the dark pink line between them could be appreciated.

Graham raised his eyebrows, daring her to tell him more.

She leaned on her elbows and he was treated to a view down her almost-unbuttoned shirt. The bra matched the underwear, her tits were framed nicely. Sabrina couldn't beat him at any sport but this one, but in this single event she was - in the parlance of the GenZ masses - OP.

She made a series of cat-like moves, stretching, jutting her ass out.

Casually, smiling: "Do you want to see?"

The story was hot, detailed, erotic. She told it well, she laid herself out beautifully for him. The panties were damp with her own excitement by the time he probed them with his fingers, but a crusty hardness had been worked into them the night before.

She left them on with Hayden, so his dick had been rubbed by them, and his cum had seeped into the fabric after she fucked him. As he pulled them from her - up her thighs to her bent knees, stretched across the width of her playful legs, his eyes couldn't leave the soggy, crusty, dirty center of them, relishing all that its existence entailed.

"I promised him a blowjob," she said, at some point, grinning. Her hand had moved to his cock, gripped it, and its firmness had lit her eyes up. She was already wriggling her body down, between his legs, sliding onto the floor, her eyes locked on his. "But I never delivered," was the last thing she said to him before she opened her lips and the heat and wetness of her mouth took him inside. Her tongue moved busily, licking his balls, lapping at the underside of his cock, swirling around inside her closed lips with his turgid dick.

She released him promptly when she sensed he was close to coming. Sabrina liked cum in her pussy: it was what she wanted, and it was what she got. She was sometimes reckless about it, but the taboo thrill of bareback fucking turned them both on, and so Sabrina did what she wanted.

She used her elbows to work her way back up to the head of the bed, talking, telling her magnificently detailed story. She played with her pussy, her fingertip sliding through the folds of her gash with sticky expletives of juices, as she revealed the way Hayden's cock had curved upward and so, by leaning back and curling just so, it had protruded right here.

A manicured fingernail tapped just above her pubic bone, where her muff would have naturally ended if she ever allowed it to grow a single hair. He was on his knees, legs slightly apart, all of his clothing removed. His cock bounced with the movement of her finger.

She lifted her hands to the headboard, pressed her palms against it casually - to brace herself - and opened her legs.

"And then I told him, you have to make me come before you fill my pussy up."

A shudder traveled through him. Precum even seeped from the tip of his cock.

She grinned at him. As Sabrina was wont to do - he'd seen it a million times - she gathered a tiny bit of her lower lip behind one incisor, the left one, which was minutely longer than the other. He wondered if she knew she was doing this. It was something she had only started doing in the past five years, in this period of their lives. The look on her face that accompanied it was not the expression of a virginal Sabrina, waiting to be ravished. Nor of a young and loving wife, eager to please. There was no malice in it, but it contained an expression that was uncanny on a woman:

I expect you to meet my demands.

Graham crawled toward her. "And? Was he able to do that?"

He was holding his cock now, guiding it through the slippery channel of her cunt. Against the crown he felt the silky interior of her outer labia and the harder edges of her inner lips, the swollen nub of her clit, swimming and darting in all directions like a kettle of fish. But this was his kettle of fish, a terrain he knew well, and sooner rather than later he had trapped her nub beneath his dick and was stroking her with his cock from hole to the

exposed nerves of it. Sabrina squirmed and smiled, responding like a pet with whom you have worked out the perfect scratch.

A sound not unlike a purr left her lips and she curled her arms a little, twisting and giggling, the pleasure he was giving her evident on her face. "He did it," she told him, "but only because his dick just happened to rub me the right way.... and..."

He sank into her.

"...and?"

In his ear, hands folding over him, legs enclosing him, pussy shifting and opening and then clamping tightly on him when she had herself just where she wanted to be:

"I thought about you fucking me when I got home."

If he were not so old, if one of life's cruel jokes was not that testosterone diminished just when you figured out what to do with it, then he would not have been able to please his wife at all. He would have blown up inside of her the moment those words coalesced into an idea, and the silky heat of her body squeezed around his dick.

As it stood, he still had a time of it, getting her through her orgasm before his own.

But that was all part of the fun.

It was hot. But something seemed off about it. That impression didn't come until later.

Sometimes guys were a disappointment - to them both, or just to Sabrina. At first, he thought that was it. When he probed her on that matter, stroking her hair, her cheek on his chest and her fingers playing with his own stiff chest hairs, she shrugged.

"He was okay," she said, and then rolled away to get out of bed and take a shower. "You know how it is."

It was an odd thing for her to say. So abbreviated. When men disappointed her, she tended to explain why in detail: his beard smelled like dust in a retirement home; his dick was too long, which she never thought was possible but it was, like, *weird*. He was too nice, too arrogant, too rude.

One of their rules was that a choice of man had to be likely to be, in their ill-defined system, "worth it." Worth the risks, which were many. Worth the drama.

So disappointments were huge and Sabrina talked about them a lot.

A lot more than this, anyway.

He lay on the bed and listened to the sound of her showering. He wondered if it mattered, in the scheme of things: her performance here at home had certainly been worth it for *him*. It wasn't as if she was upset about anything. It wasn't like he enjoyed the details of why a man had disappointed her as much as the details of a man serving her well. This kind of thing happened. It had happened before, it would happen again.

It just felt off. Something about it. As if there was a lot more going on in her mind than what she'd revealed.

Here it was: the *real* unease. There was no way around it, no way to avoid it, no matter how many rules you set up. He had always known there was a risk that one day Sabrina would develop feelings for someone she slept with. The thrill of their lifestyle would have been diminished if that risk didn't exist, but it was still a risk. When it seemed to be lurking close by in the shadows it was chilling.

Sexily, angstily chilling. But chilling nonetheless.

He turned to his side and peered into the master bath suite, hoping that Sabrina would be standing in the one place in the shower, and that a mirrored door would be angled just so, so that he could spy on her from the bed.

All he could really do, he reasoned, was wait to see what happened. After all, Sabrina having feelings for another man was not something he needed to know about. Unless they endured, or became stronger, or made her act on them in some way, they were hers to have and keep secret. As long as they never got any stronger than her feelings for her husband, what did they mean, anyway?

He rolled again and closed his eyes.

Experience told him to leave it alone.

But the unsettling static buzzed inside him, and he sifted through the details of Sabrina's story with his eyes closed. He felt like an animal, playing dead, his mind dedicated to the hunt for a threat lurking in the darkness.

Chapter Six

I'd like a meeting with you. Call my PA to arrange.

She stared at the text. Private number, local area code. No doubt as to where it had come from: the well-heeled man from the bar Friday night.

"Grant," she said aloud.

He left a telephone number for his PA at the end of the text. Nothing more.

For the second time that morning, she tossed her phone into her passenger seat and tried to ignore it. She was stuck in traffic, inching along, so her phone was begging to be checked, and she had no reason not to look at it: it wasn't like she was actually *driving* at the moment.

She balanced her elbow on the car door, rested her head against her palm for a moment, placed her finger between her closed lips. The pang of guilt she had felt the first time she'd read the message had congealed into a kind of dull, uncomfortable mass somewhere in her chest.

She had never mentioned this guy to Graham, in the end.

She consoled herself by telling herself that it would have been too hard to work this man into the sexy story she knew Graham wanted to hear, but she knew better than that. There had been plenty of time afterward, and plenty of opportunities for her to do so. She'd been close to doing it.

And then she hadn't. And what was worse, she even tried to make excuses for *that*, by saying things to herself like, "if it really wasn't important to me, I would have just forgotten all about it."

As if that somehow made pretending to forget about him turn into actually having forgotten about him. As if that would make him "not important enough to remember."

Graham, she thought, had sensed something was off with her. He'd held the door wide open for her, on several occasions, to mention this older guy.

"That was all? You didn't see him again?" he had asked - of Hayden - like he knew something else was in her mind, *on* her mind, lurking around in her thoughts.

"I ate breakfast upstairs," was as close as she'd gotten to telling him about Grant.

It would have been so easy to just roll this guy right into the sentence: "...where I met a really strange character. Get this."

And yet she hadn't. And now the worst had happened: he was getting in touch with her. Using the phone number she'd given him.

At least she could give herself some credit: she really had only given the man that business card to prove to him that she owned Red Velvet. However silly *that* was, it did not come from a place of trying to trick her own husband.

"Handle it like any other client," she told herself, glaring at the traffic in front of her.

She plodded along in traffic for a few minutes. Alicia - who was as close to a PA as Sabrina got - called her to inform her of a problem with the dual wedding scheduled for the weekend. It was the perfect moment to ask Alicia to call "Grant's" PA and be done with the whole sordid business.

Alicia left the door open for her to do so:

"Anything else, while I have you on the phone?"

And Sabrina didn't.

She knew *why* she didn't: she didn't want Alicia making that call.

She wanted to do it herself.

Why she wanted to do that was a little less clear.

She was traveling down a path that she knew she should back out of, even if she didn't know why.

Aggravated, she plodded along in traffic for a few more minutes, and then, exasperated, ordered her phone to call the number as she read it from her phone.

"Hey. Sabrina?" a female voice answered. This threw Sabrina off: so casual, so familiar.

Whoever answered the phone was a woman, very young. She sounded like everyone under twenty-five who had ever worked for Sabrina: assured of everything and nothing, presumptive, overly casual. "Hey," Sabrina answered, irritation in her voice. It was so annoying when people answered the phone like that. And why did she know her first name and decide to use it? This phone number showed up as Red Velvet Events.

Composure.

Business.

"This is Sabrina Cole from Red -"

"Hey, Sabrina, right, I know. I have two times this week that Sebastian asked me to run by you: Wednesday at 1030 or Thursday at two pm."

Sabrina was irritated. She made a note of the man's first name, reeled from the GenZ conversational style, gave a private scolding to herself for thinking that this guy Grant wanted anything but an events planner, and tried to think business.

It was better if she didn't get involved in this. She wasn't hurting for business, if anything the opposite was true. She'd probably have to turn this guy down.

"Neither one of those works for me, I'm afraid."

"No? Well, that was expected. I have a note here... uh... yeah: if she can't make those times, can she squeeze me in this Friday night at the... God... uh, fry? Godfrey something?" A tittering laugh. "He writes these things in cursive, I can't *read them*, oh my gosh, hold on..."

"It's the Godfrey exhibit," Sabrina was saying, and then pulled her mouth taut with annoyance. GenZ had already put her on hold.

It was a fact of life that the receptionists and PAs of the world were now GenZ. They wore sweatpants that looked like jeans and sweatshirts that looked like jackets, and strange makeup. They did not know how to use a phone for speaking to people very well. They used first names with their own surgeons and spoke gibberish.

That was all fine. At least half of the money Sabrina had made as a start-up company had come from non-events these children threw for themselves.

Sometimes, though, it tried her patience.

This was one such time.

"Sabrina?" the PA chirped, coming back on the line.

"Yep."

If the PA picked up on the annoyance that oozed from Sabrina's voice, she gave no indication of it. "He says he'll be at this exhibit, if you're there, too, he'd like ten minutes or so of your time."

"He'll be at the exhibit?"

"Uh... yeah, I guess. As a guest, I mean. So do I tell him that's fine?"

Sabrina laughed as she shifted her jaw. She looked at herself in the rear view mirror, because at the moment she was the only one available to appreciate how arrogant this guy was. "Uh," she said. "No. Please tell him I give my full attention to the task at hand, so I can't guarantee I'll have time to speak to him."

"O-kay... phhhhhh.... okay, well, let me.... how about this, can you text me some times this week or next you can meet with him? In person?"

"Is there some reason we can't talk on the phone?"

A pause.

"Well... yeah."

"And that is?"

"Uh..." A laugh, calibrated to make it known that it was at Sabrina's expense. "I mean... Sebastian doesn't really... *work* like that."

Composure. Business.

This is like any other client, Sabrina told herself. Work it like any other client. Do what you would do with any other client.

Why was that so hard?

"I see," Sabrina said, through gritted teeth. "How long will this meeting be?"

"Ten minutes is what I need to schedule. But it will probably be fifteen."

"And where?"

A little laugh, an authentic-sounding attempt to stifle it. "Uh, it... that sort of depends on when it is."

"I see." Sabrina was actually seeing red. "I'm in traffic right now. I'll text you some dates and times when I get to the office."

"I could also call your PA, if that's easier for you?"

"It's not."

"Okay," the unflappable girl twittered. "You have my number there, so, I'll just wait for your text."

"Fine."

Sabrina hung up, inexplicably annoyed. Her heart was still thumping, and her curiosity was in overdrive.

"I mean, seriously," she muttered, and when she saw that the driver to her left was looking at her, she turned more fully to him to finish her rhetorical question to herself. "Where the fuck does that guy get off?"

The driver shrugged and smiled weakly at her.

She thought about texting him, again and again. She drafted a few messages, and discarded them. Too cute, too unprofessional, too professional, too cold, too ambiguous. By mid-afternoon, she was sick of the whole thing being on her mind.

She resolved not to text him, sometime around lunch. But by 2pm, she was thinking about it again - and infuriated that she was - and was starting to think that *not texting him* would reveal to him that he had somehow gotten under her skin.

She briefly considered calling Graham for advice about it. If she did that, she would accomplish several things: she'd be being honest and forthright, and Graham would tell her not to think about that guy or forbid her from sleeping with him, and then all her worries would be over.

Her hand hovered over her phone screen for a long time, Graham's number queued up, the call needing nothing more than a casual swiped to set it in motion.

And then she didn't do it.

"Okay," she told herself, as the clock wound down on the day. She pushed Sebastian Grant out of her mind and decided not to get back to him, or his PA.

Surely - surely - that would be the end of it.

The restless energy Sabrina had come home with on Sunday did not blow away Monday, but instead followed her home. She paced, she checked her phone, she typed messages and then deleted them. She tossed the phone face-down with exasperation sometimes, and brought a finger to her mouth to fake-chew at the tip of her thumbnail while staring vacantly at the laptop screen perched on her thighs.

"I'm just trying to figure out a scheduling nightmare," she told him, unbidden, when he walked through the master bedroom and glanced her way.

It was strange that she said this. In her younger years, and before they'd reached this understanding, Sabrina had done stuff like this all the time. But lately, she had become a woman who didn't feel the need to explain her every sigh, or what she was doing, when she was just working.

Graham worked in insurance fraud. His spidey senses, always on, became alert to this behavior. Back when he had started in that field, a mentor at his first job - a crusty old guy who was rumored to have been in the FBI and dishonorably fired - had told him quite a few things that had turned out to be very, very true.

One was that you can tell someone is hiding something when they explain something they ordinarily do not bother to explain. People always lost track of their usual personalities when they lied.

"And here I was thinking you might be carrying on with some younger guy," he told her. His tone was joking, and for the most part, he *was* joking. She had no motivation not to tell him if that was the case.

So he was surprised when she lifted her eyes and looked at him seriously. "I *wish*," she said, her lips moving in their enigmatic way. "But no, it's just scheduling."

Her eyes went back to the screen. Her hand edged closer to her overturned phone.

He went on his way, giving her a smile. Into the bathroom, over to his side of the counter, his sink, where he couldn't see into the master bedroom via the reflection of the large mirror hanging over the sink.

Sabrina had insisted that the large, wall-spanning mirror that had come with the build be removed, and framed mirrors hung above each sink. It did look classier, but Graham missed the lengthy mirror on the wall that allowed him to see into the bedroom from the sink, or into the bathroom from the bedroom.

It was quiet in the bedroom. No tapping of keys, no sound from Sabrina. He smeared shaving lotion on and began to shave, but something wormed around in his consciousness and he decided to walk past the entrance to the

bathroom, to Sabrina's side of the long countertop. While he passed, razor in hand, excuse at the ready - he wanted a washcloth from the basket of rolled washcloths stored at Sabrina's end - he stole a glance into the bedroom.

Sabrina was absorbed in her phone, holding it in two hands and staring at it intensely, her brow slightly furrowed. He walked by again, with the washcloth, and she was still like that. He finished shaving, stood back to appraise himself, listened for movement from the bedroom and heard none.

He strolled by the door again, taking the washcloth to a hamper for damp things, as Sabrina had instructed him to do.

She was still staring vacantly at nothing, her phone in her hands. But thoughts very obviously brewed there, because she was oblivious to his movement. When he went to the doorway and leaned against it, she didn't even notice him.

"Must be *some* scheduling nightmare," he said.

She jumped a little. Her eyes went to him and she seemed flustered momentarily. She swiped at a chunk of her loose hair, brushing it from her forehead. "Oh God," she said, tossing her phone to the side. She smiled at him and rotated, bringing the laptop with her as she rested on her side, head propped up in one hand. Her fingers played with the laptop screen suggestively and then closed it. "How long have you been staring at me like that?"

Graham shrugged, his intentions forgotten as Sabrina shifted in her loose, silky nightshirt. Parts of it fell away from her skin, allowing for inviting glimpses of the shape of her breasts, the slight swell of her stomach, the *womanliness* of it all.

What had his intentions been when he had said that? He couldn't remember.

It had surprised him that Sabrina had jumped, her reaction was unlike her. But there was nothing to really put his finger on, nothing to confront her about. It was just a feeling, floating in the air, that something was "off" about her.

Why had *he* jumped to suspecting a vaguely sexual secret?

Probably for the same reason that, now that she was looking at him warmly and invitingly, he was walking toward the bed with sexual intentions that were not vague at all.

Ordinarily, he would have made another joke about a younger man. Even with all of their practice, all of their rules in place: it was always possible that Sabrina would color outside of the lines, or develop feelings for another guy.

The risk, Graham figured, was part of the appeal for him. But sometimes it became too much, and he had to confirm for himself that everything was still how he wanted it: he would make a joke, and Sabrina would play along, creating a fictional account of her accidental emotional involvement with another guy.

Something was stopping him from making a joke like that. And when he climbed onto the bed, it wasn't as playful as he usually was. An urge to dominate Sabrina, right from the start, clawed in his chest.

He climbed onto the bed and picked the computer up and tossed it away.

"Hey, what -?" Sabrina protested, watched it land on the bed. She cut herself off when she looked at his eyes.

And just like that, the chemistry changed between them. He watched her mouth but couldn't detect a smile. Her face had no real expression. But

interest - the interest that had been siphoned off by her computer, her phone, her fatigue, her job - had returned to her eyes and it was all directed at him now.

In his spare time, he often tried to analyze what it was about really good sex that made it so good. How sometimes it was a fire, and they were perfectly in sync. They didn't have any new facts, didn't do any new things, didn't look any different, and yet sometimes it sizzled and other times it didn't.

He didn't say anything to Sabrina, and she didn't say anything to him. He straddled her, pushed her shirt up and pulled her panties down, looking into her eyes the whole time. And then he spread her legs, and fucked her.

There really wasn't anything more to it than that: it was quick, it was dirty, she was sopping wet, they didn't speak or play, they only kissed violently and fucked like animals looking into each other's eyes: but it was one of the hotter times they'd had sex in recent memory.

It was for Graham, anyway.

Who could ever really know, though - really, really know? - how Sabrina felt about it?

Chapter Seven

You never got back to Hazel

I have a busy schedule. I couldn't find a good time

I don't believe you

Sabrina stared at the text messages in the darkness of the toilet room, where she was seated in the dark, with only the glow of her phone to illuminate the small space. Graham was asleep in the bedroom, but she'd woken in the early hours of the morning and couldn't stop thinking about the mysterious Sebastian Grant and his bizarre texts.

Texts that really - *really* - shouldn't have been causing her to think as much as she was.

He didn't believe her? What the hell was that supposed to mean?

The tone was obviously flirtatious. She could hardly see how it could be taken any other way.

That a text from a man was flirtatious was not a scandal. Or even really a surprise.

It was *her own reaction* to it that surprised her.

Ordinarily, wouldn't she have just shown this to Graham and asked him what he thought about it?

Wouldn't she have worked it into, or leveraged it into, sex?

Ordinarily, wouldn't she have responded to any other man by now?

Why was she giving it so much thought?

She didn't want to write back too early, too late. She didn't want to say the right thing to keep the flirtation going, but she also didn't entirely want to shut it down.

This guy was so full of himself. This guy was *old*. This guy was not her type, and not Graham's type either, and she should have dispensed with thinking about him a long time ago.

And yet...

She sighed.

She had definitely waited too long to get back to him.

The only way to show him she didn't give a fig about him, one way or the other, was to truly not give a fig. The problem was, not answering a text was *not* what she would do, if she didn't give a fig about him. The man was ostensibly talking business, and she was a business owner.

Not taking a meeting with a wealthy potential client spoke volumes, she was sure of that. And they were volumes she didn't want to be speaking.

She tapped the phone with her fingers. What to do? She had been drafting a response for so long now she felt like a teenager with a dumb crush on a teacher.

Which was not the case. At all.

She wished she'd been more pithy in her first reply. She could have told him "Hazel" - she could only assume this was his PA - was a dimwitted GenZer whose tone was crap, and that's why she hadn't called her back: that much was true.

But she had opted instead to appear completely serious and professional - something he had obviously seen right through.

Which *irked* her.

She sighed. She'd been sitting in the toilet closet on the lid for so long that one of her feet was beginning to fall asleep. She'd done a few Google searches - which she'd erased the history of - and had stared guiltily at a few pictures of Sebastian Grant. Here he was, cutting ribbons; here he was, finishing a fucking marathon. He wasn't even a doctor. She kept closing the tabs as quickly as she indulged in opening them, hating that she even wanted to know who he was, or what he did.

Impatiently, she started typing. It was 430am, so it might look like she was just an industrious early riser, and in many ways that was an honest portrayal. God, she was overthinking it, and why?

"I don't fucking *like you*," she hissed at her phone as she typed:

Whatever. I'll try to give you 15 at the Godfrey exhibit.

She looked at the message. She deleted the "whatever," and then sent it.

She closed her eyes and exhaled. Good. That was good. After all, what was she going to do when she was at the Godfrey exhibit and quite clearly had fifteen minutes for some kind of chat? Pretend to be super-busy? This should take care of it all.

Her phone vibrated in her hand.

I don't want to interfere in your extra-curriculars

She smiled. In spite of herself. It was only then that she realized that she was having fun, sparring with this guy.

There was no strict rule against *that*, between her and Graham.

She looked at the wall after she finished typing her message, just to check in on herself, using the rule that had done so well for her up until now:

Would she show this message chain to Graham?

That was the internal rule about danger.

She was still looking at the wall when her thumb closed against the screen and sent the message, while the answer to her test-question rattled around resoundingly in her chest:

No. She would not.

And she did not know why.

And that was why she shouldn't be doing this.

But at the same time, what was the harm?

She swept the entire message string away with a finger, a stab of low-grade guilt permeating her consciousness as she did.

Now she was also hiding the messages.

Good to know. Stay out of my way if you see me with a hot guy then

She ignored her messages for the whole morning, so it was noon by the time she read his reply, and she twisted in a chair and savored the reply, and the cascade of guilt it triggered:

I never interrupt things I enjoy watching.

One of the most difficult aspects of her and Graham's relationship was that she didn't really have anyone to talk about it with. Jimmy at the Hilton *knew* about it, but he wasn't exactly a heart-to-heart kind of guy.

Nobody else: other than her friend Krista.

Krista was a pansexual, wild, serial-cheating vixen married to a dikey and possessive woman. Sabrina and Krista had been friends since university, but shared no social circles - making her a perfect sounding board. Also, Krista's own sexual adventures were so wild and varied that Sabrina felt confident she would never bother repeating Sabrina's comparably tame alternative-lifestyle adventures to a single soul.

Having sex with a guy with your husband's explicit permission didn't even make junior varsity intrigue in Krista's world, even if the guys were very young.

Krista was late to their planned get-together: drinks at a small bar with vague lesbian vibes, once a month, almost always canceled by Sabrina. She was pleased to see the date pop up on her schedule, and when Krista texted her flippantly (I assume you aren't coming), she was even happier to text back: surprise!

Krista had her long, sexy hair in a Brigitte Bardot style, and she had recently dyed it very blonde. She was flustered and alive with some kind of new sexual energy - not unusual for her, because she was almost always hooking up with someone new. Eyes followed Krista's long, lean, slinky form wherever she went, and with her long blonde tresses flowing sexily

around her bare shoulders and a low-cut leotard beneath some tight-fitting jeans, today was no exception.

Sabrina asked about her hair, and listened to a long story about a Swedish flight attendant who was sexy as hell but a complete loser, and an old college boyfriend who was putting the moves on Krista after all these years who she was thinking of fucking.

Krista started devouring a plate of tapas at last, and looked at Sabrina as she chewed.

"Okay, so what's new with you?" she asked, clearly prepared to be bored. Krista's affairs were all exotic and wild, and she actually cheated, so there was a lot of adventure to them. She was also much more attracted to women than to men, so Sabrina's boy-toys were a curiosity to Krista.

Like being married to a man ("why? Is it the car maintenance?") and having an agreement about affairs ("how is it fun?"), Krista didn't think much of younger guys ("like I need to explain what to do with my clit to yet another person").

Sabrina had been toying with the idea of seeking Krista's opinion about Sebastian Grant and whether or not to tell Graham about it or not. She hesitated again. Saying it out loud would add a layer of consciousness to what she was doing, and it also might come across as silly to Krista.

Krista stopped eating with her fork hovering over her food. "Oh my God," she said, smiling, speaking through some of her food. She chewed rapidly and swallowed. "You have something *interesting* to say." She smiled, stabbed at the garnish, and stuffed it into her mouth. "Tell me. Oh my God."

"It's not that interesting."

Krista rolled her eyes and grinned, chewing. "Okay, sure. Whatever. Dish."

"I need your opinion on something."

Krista laughed and put a fist to her mouth. Exceedingly feminine in appearance, her mannerisms were more like a lumberjack's. "Oh boy. This should definitely be good, then."

Sabrina lowered her voice and leaned toward her. "Okay, so, like... I'm not even sure what this is... and I... like, I don't know what's even going on..."

Krista started making a snoring noise and closed her eyes.

"It's this guy, okay? But like, he's old."

"Ooooh," Krista said, her eyes flying open. "How did *that* happen?" She opened her eyes wider. "What did *Graham* say?"

"I didn't - okay, first of all, I didn't sleep with this guy or anything. Or *anything*. I just, uh... well..."

Krista propped her head against her hand, leaning on her elbow, her big eyes getting sleepier by the second. "What are you even saying, Rin? Why are you even telling me this story?" She yawned.

"Not everybody can be as big of a whore as you," Sabrina said, slapping her arm. She took out her phone and brought up the messages from Sebastian. "So, like I said, nothing happened. I met this guy at the Hilton bar, just before I hooked up with this guy -"

"Young guy?"

"Yes, stop interrupting. And he... like, he just started a conversation with me when it looked like this guy I wanted to hook up with had left. And he totally knew the score, you know?"

Sabrina recounted her interactions with Sebastian, and then handed Krista the phone to read the messages.

Krista raised her eyebrows and handed the phone back to Sabrina without comment.

"Well?" Sabrina demanded.

"Well, what? This old guy knows you're a swinger - excuse me, *hotwife* - and he's putting the moves on you."

She smiled and popped some food in her mouth to chew and grin while contemplating Sabrina's annoyed expression.

"I mean, I don't mean to burst your bubble," she continued, after enjoying Sabrina's expression. "But it isn't exactly a fine art getting an old man to think about putting his dick in your vagina. Which you should know. By now." Krista smiled and stabbed at some remaining lettuce on her plate and looked thoughtfully at the ceiling. "Women, on the other hand, are trickier."

Sabrina looked sullenly at Krista.

"Oh gosh. Okay, sorry. What's the problem? I don't understand the problem."

Sabrina leaned back, chewing on her lower lip. She made a face. "I don't know. I don't... he's old, I'm not, you know, super attracted to him or anything. He's not my type -"

"What does he look like?"

"He's... you know.... rich. Like a doctor, trim. He has silver hair."

Krista was staring at Sabrina with her eyes wide. "Are you serious right now? What does... 'doctor?' even...? 'Doctor?!' That's not an adjective, Rin. It's... is he *hot* or *not*?"

Sabrina shrugged. "Hot. I guess. For an old guy."

"How old?"

"Late fifties... I don't know. Too old. For, you know..."

"But you're flirting with him," Krista said, smiling. She shook her head.

"I'm not -"

Krista pointed at the phone, grinned, rolled her eyes, and adopted a mocking tone. "Sabrina, please. 'I don't want to interfere in your curriculum...' 'No, don't, you brute! Stay out of my way while I do erotic things with some younger guy! And no matter what, don't watch me! That's so bad, Mr. Old Rich Hot guy!'" She poked at her food, smiling at her own wit. "'Stop it! You're not on the menu!'"

"*Krista*," Sabrina complained.

"Oh, don't Krista me," Krista laughed. Having been thoroughly mean and irritating, she pulled a typical Krista move and looked up at Sabrina, suddenly sweet. "Look. You aren't asking me because you wanted a bunch of bullshit. And you aren't asking *me* because this story is so squeaky clean you can ask Graham about it. Which I take it you haven't done. You're talking to me about it because it's intriguing to you and you *want* to talk about it, but I'm the only person in the world who will tell you to go ahead and do it, or not judge you. Whatever you're thinking of doing." She waved her fingers in the air and smiled.

"Like you could judge."

"Exactly. So, here you go: it sounds to me like you have the hots for this guy, and it also sounds to me like they're some over-the-line hots, which is why you're not telling Graham about any of it."

Sabrina huffed over her plate, putting her hands to her temples. "Right, so, thank you, for this really obvious summary of my problem."

"Is there a problem here? Is that what you're saying? You want to have a real affair? Or what?"

Sabrina became annoyed. She wasn't even sure now herself what it was she wanted to talk to Krista about.

Krista moved her jaw sideways and studied Sabrina with a gleam in her eye. "From where I sit, it looks like you want to go out-of-bounds." She crinkled up her nose. "With an old guy?" She folded her arms over each other and screwed up her face. "Why? What's this guy got?"

Sabrina looked at Krista. She shook her head slowly and shrugged.

Krista pointed at her, a knowing look on her face. "That's your answer."

"Huh?"

"You don't know what you're doing. Okay? And when you don't know what you're doing, or why you're doing it, then it's a sign that it's... well, for me it's a sign it's going to be fun. In your case? It sounds like a bad idea." She laughed. "If you're asking me -"

Krista shook her head and seized her vibrating phone, smiled at the message, and began packing her stuff up almost immediately. "Okay, I gotta go, I'm sorry." Krista stood up and leaned over to kiss Sabrina on the cheek. "Pay my bill? I'm... it's along story, I have to, I have to go, this girl is like, so hot."

"But...?" Sabrina whined. "My advice?"

Krista swung a light jacket over her tube-topped body while the whole bar watched lustfully. "My advice is always the same."

Sabrina sat back and closed her eyes.

"Either *do it*, and enjoy it, or cockblock yourself. Go home and tell Graham everything you told me." She shook out her fabulous hair and checked her teeth in a reflective decoration on the wall. "Anything in the middle is going to be a hassle for nothing." She smiled and tossed her head back. "You know. Commit."

Sabrina rolled her eyes. "That's your motto."

"That's my motto. Toodles."

Chapter Eight

Sabrina had something on her mind. It was always obvious when she did - so obvious that it was one of the reasons their relationship worked out like it did. He could trust that Sabrina wouldn't be able to hide any details from him, or any transgressions.

Of course, he'd have loved to tell himself or anyone else that the trust was perfect, 100%, and always. He behaved as if this was the case. In truth, tucked away inside him in a place he rarely peeked at, he was on edge about it sometimes.

"Who's the guy?" he asked her playfully, midweek, when she stared off into the sunset for over ten minutes without saying a word or taking a bite of her dinner.

Her eyes came back into focus, met his, and then she shook her head very quickly before looking down at her plate of food and picking at it absent-mindedly. "Sorry. Jeez. Nothing, really, just work stuff. I mean... no guy. No real prospects, lately. And I just have... a lot on my mind. Business-wise." She played with her food, and then began to rattle on. "It's just this... client. Potential client. He's being... difficult. I don't know. Confusing. Anyway."

She looked up at him and dropped her fork to pick up her wine. "It's pretty boring. Sorry."

Graham was not entirely convinced it was boring.

He was, in fact, convinced that it was not-so-boring. He lifted his glass and clinked it against hers. "This client is a man?" he asked, maintaining a playful tone in his voice despite a flicker of doubt that nagged at him, like a hangnail in the back of his mind.

"I mean," Sabrina snorted. "He is. But not like that. He's so old. And arrogant. And just... a weirdo."

Graham gave Sabrina a confused look, meant to prompt her to say more.

She shook her head and sipped her wine.

"How is he weird?"

"Huh?"

Graham was looking at her intently now. Something was definitely, definitely off about Sabrina's demeanor. In a worrying way.

A worrying but exciting way.

Because if he had to get right down to the truth, they'd been at this game of theirs for quite some time. It was fun, it was hot, it had been satisfying and dangerous and invigorating in the beginning. But like anything you do repeatedly, it had turned out "just fine" so often that the danger of it had rubbed away. And with that, some of the thrill.

The twist in his guts that he was experiencing now was refreshing, if he had to be honest.

Sabrina was hiding something, Sabrina was doing something that was a little dangerous. Graham felt tiny pricks of jealousy throughout his chest, and a cold deliciousness started radiating from them.

"How is he weird?" he repeated, almost wishing he hadn't asked. Part of him wished he'd dropped the subject, allowed it to play out a little longer. In all likelihood, Sabrina would tell him about actual weirdness now, and the brief fantasy would flit away as a realistic, and boring, story about a weird man.

Instead, she put her hand to her forehead and shook her head. "You know, I don't even know how to describe it."

"But he's old?"

"Graham," she said, a hint of irritation in her voice. She picked up her plate and her cutlery. "This isn't... I don't even want to talk about it, to be honest. He's just a weirdo, and he's being a pain, and I wish I could just blow him off, but he seems like a wealthy - I mean, he *is* wealthy." She stood up and carried her plate to the counter. "That's all."

Graham set his fork down and considered what to say next. It was very obvious that wasn't "all," but he wasn't sure what he wanted to do next.

The rules of their game would suggest he should confront her, and get her to tell him what was really going on.

And if he knew his wife, she would crack under the slightest pressure.

So this was easy to accomplish. All he had to do, really, was ask her one more time, more directly, what she was actually stewing about. Suggest that he knew there was something a little out-of-bounds to it all. That's all it would take.

She returned to the table and sat down, her eyes wandering to her phone - which she didn't pick up, but obviously wanted to.

Graham let another opportunity slide away.

"Well," he said. "I hope you figure it out."

"Yeah," she said, her thoughts very obviously somewhere else. "I'm sure it'll get sorted..."

Eyes to the phone again.

"You have work to do, I can see."

She gave him an apologetic smile.

Maybe she wasn't up to anything, he thought.

"I'm sorry, I just... it's a lot on my mind."

"Of course. Go take care of business," he said. Sabrina's business was doing well, and she would probably make more money than him this year if things kept up. It also paved the way for their sexual lifestyle. Who was he to complain, or interfere?

"Really?" she asked, and another alarm went off in his head. Sabrina knew the score with her business: it wasn't like her to double-check on something like this.

A cold fear settled in the center of his chest.

A rush of adrenaline surprised him. His cock twitched to life in an unusually robust way.

"Of course," he said.

She had her phone in her hand already. "Okay, well... thanks."

"Hey sweetie?" he asked her, when she trotted toward the kitchen door.

"Uh-huhn," she said, staring at her phone.

"Anything going on this weekend? It looks like I'll be free on Friday after all."

This had come out of his mouth without being run by any checkpoints in his brain. He was partially surprised to hear the words in his own voice.

In truth he wasn't actually freed up for Friday, and he didn't really have any reason to be asking her about it - she had, after all, just told him there

were no prospects on the horizon.

He knew why he'd done it, though: he wanted to see her reaction.

She was alarmed. Her eyes went to his and her fingers froze comically in a claw shape around her phone. He wasn't positive, but it appeared that a slight flush crept briefly into her cheeks. Her mouth hung open for a moment.

"What?"

"Friday. I have it free now. If anything is going on that -"

"Oh. Gosh. Listen... it's, this is part of the thing, this... it's just a fancy art exhibit, kind of, fundraiser, to be honest I don't even know what it's about. But it's like... old, rich people. So... boring. Probably. Not worth wasting your time, I think."

"Hmm."

"I mean..." she softened, walked toward him quickly, kissed him on the mouth, and smiled. "Come, if you want to, I, uh... I'll probably stay down there, because Saturday is an expo at the arena and I have to be there by four. But I... okay, just let me know, because I was probably just going to sleep at the office. You know? Save on the... there's no point in having a room. I didn't even book one."

All very, very suspicious.

He kissed her. Ideas were already blossoming in his head. "Well, then. Maybe Saturday?"

"Uh... sure, yeah, okay. I just... it's all so boring, honey. This weekend. I'll really just be busy the whole time."

"You never know if something could pop up," he said, encouragingly. "Someone, rather."

Her eyes were dull and disinterested. "I doubt it. But I guess. So, well... I mean, sure if you want to come, come, just, uh... tell me and I'll book a hotel."

The cool fingers of jealousy flitted casually across the surface of his heart. Was there a lie embedded in Sabrina's story? What would it even be? Nothing she was saying was terribly out of the ordinary... it was just the way she was saying it.

"How about you just book it? That way you don't have to sleep at the office. And then I can join you and we'll just see what happens?"

She looked stricken.

"Unless you don't want me to be there?"

She slapped her forehead. "I... no, of course I do. Of course. Just... be warned. It's likely to be boring. Especially Friday. I just want to sleep. I have to be at the expo by four."

This was all delivered with warmth that seemed genuine. He doubted himself again: was he just reading something into Sabrina's behavior because *he* was bored?

If she really was just going to be working, he didn't want to stay in a hotel, anyway. He was past the age where he could just sleep anywhere. He wasn't even actually free on Friday, anyway. What was he doing?

"How about you just book it? It's a business expense, right? And then we'll just see, okay?"

"Right," Sabrina said, much too quickly. She looked down at her phone, a glance that seemed to be automated. Like she expected something from her phone, and wasn't getting it. "Okay. I'll do that. Uh..." she looked back at the doorway.

"I know, I know, you have to work," he said.

"Thank you," she said, kissing him on the cheek.

Her demeanor changed again, abruptly. She looked at him intently and the machinery of her mind seemed to clatter away to some kind of conclusion. "Of course, this is a good idea," she said, cheerfully. Another smile. "We'll have fun. Okay. I'll book it tonight."

And away she went, the faint scent of lies trailing behind her like a perfume from the day before.

Graham stared at his wine glass and then out the window. He could clear all of his suspicions up in a heartbeat, and a part of him wanted to do that.

The feeling that was lurking in his chest, though, and flooding his arteries and oozing into his balls, was titillating enough that he didn't.

After all, there was probably nothing at all going on. It was just a fantasy, his own concoctions, a bit of fun.

A nice change.

He would just let it play out - almost certainly to a boring conclusion. A weekend in hotels ten miles from his house, Sabrina working, and nothing of any note or interest happening at all.

"Fuck," Sabrina muttered to herself, looking at her face in the mirror.

What was she doing?

Her entire body was tingling with discomfort. No matter how she tried to frame it to herself, she hadn't been completely honest with Graham back in the kitchen.

Sure, she hadn't *lied*. But she hadn't been open, either, and part of the agreement they had was to be both honest and open.

So why had she been so opaque? When the only reason for it was this Sebastian Grant character that she didn't even like as a person? She was terrible at lying (if it mattered - inconsequential lies for the purposes of attraction, or role-playing, rolled off her tongue). It sped her heartbeat up, her skin got clammy. She didn't *enjoy* the feeling.

And she wasn't about to *do* something with this Sebastian Grant character.

But beneath the layers of discomfort, she had access to one rational and true assessment of herself: she, for whatever reason, had not wanted Sebastian and her husband to collide.

The question at the heart of her transgression was less easy to face:

Why?

Sebastian Grant wasn't young. He wasn't temporary. He wasn't any of the things that Sabrina wanted. He wasn't even the kind of guy she was attracted to, or ever had been, in her entire life. Talking about him - shit-talking him, specifically - should have been nothing to her. Something she did without even thinking of it.

She dared to look at herself in the mirror one more time, right in the eyes, looking for the answer there.

But it was too difficult, and she looked away impatiently before she got to the answer.

In the shower, she resolved to put it out of her mind.

Chapter Nine

She spotted Sebastian Grant the moment she stepped into the tucked-away exhibit room at the back of the gallery to check on how well the cleaning crew was handling their tasks.

At least, that's the excuse she gave to herself to enter the room for the fifth time.

She was overtaken by rush of emotion when she saw him. But the emotion, she was sure, was not attraction.

Not really. It was more like the kind of low-grade fever that older guys had given her when she was younger, before she really blossomed, and there were still a few men left on the planet who wouldn't give her the time of day. Long ago, when she didn't have the advantages she had now, before she ran the show in the bedroom.

It was an exciting sensation.

But she also didn't like it. She didn't like what it was making her do.

She spun on her heel and put herself back in the room with the main action, her phone in her hand to make it look like she was as busy as she'd told Sebastian Grant she would be.

God damn this fucking guy, she thought bitterly. The end of this event couldn't come soon enough.

But that, too, was a lie she was telling herself. Because she could have easily departed, leaving Alicia in charge. Even Alicia seemed to think it was strange that Sabrina was still there.

The crowd moved, the way crowds sometimes do, in a sudden herd that emptied the main gallery and pushed nearly everyone into the back. Sabrina watched her crew obediently break apart and send a few people to follow along.

She stayed behind, a nexus of silly decisions branching out in her mind: would Sebastian think she was trying to run into him if she went? Or if she stayed? And what if she went home? What if she approached him as she would any other client?

It was all so high-school stupid at this point. She almost wanted to slap herself.

She swiped around in her phone, considering the idea that Graham and Krista - separately, and in completely different ways - had proposed to her: Using an app to find her "dates."

She didn't like the idea. It took some of the magic out of it for her.

In fact, the whole thing had gotten so transactional. She often wondered if it didn't suck some of the fun out of it for her.

"Mrs. Cole," a smooth voice said to her, sending chills all over her body. She didn't need to look up to know it was Sebastian Grant. She recognized his voice.

She glanced up immediately, and there he was. A glass partway to his lips, an arrogant grin on his face, his thick silver hair styled like he had just come from a high-end barbershop. He was poised as if he intended to stand

there like that - glass in hand, smile on his face - for a photo shoot or a portrait.

"Mr... Grant."

The pause was on purpose, so that Sebastian Grant didn't get some crazy idea that she had been thinking about him the whole night. It was a lie, though, and it didn't leave her lips gracefully. She could hear the quiver in her own voice, and a flash in Grant's eyes told her he had heard the same thing. She felt her heart flutter and her blood surged.

This man was fucking infuriating.

He sipped his drink at last. She let her eyes shift to see the liquid and then back up to his face. "How's the wine?"

"Terrible, I assume, but I bring my own so it doesn't matter."

She tucked her phone into her jacket pocket and shook her head. "You're not allowed to do that, you know," she chided him, but made sure to toss her hair and grin so he knew she wasn't going to challenge him on it.

"I do a lot of things I'm not supposed to do," he said.

There was no mistaking the innuendo, on the one hand, and Sebastian Grant had delivered this line with a trace of a twinkle in his eyes. It made her heart skip a beat, and she prayed a flush hadn't crept into her complexion.

"No doubt," Sabrina agreed. She looked around at the emptied main room. "Do you know why everyone headed back there?"

"The artist is speaking. It's odd, really, that you didn't follow them."

Sabrina pulled her phone out and looked at the time. "Huh. They told us 8:30, but I guess it's no big deal."

"I'm certain you can still catch him if you desire."

"I'm not here as a patron."

Sebastian Grant's eyes lit up again, and he smiled very faintly. "Ah yes. You own a business. You're here on business."

"Exactly. Which, I guess I'm -"

"I was referring to your extra-curricular activity."

Sabrina was stopped cold in her tracks. She kept her eyes on Sebastian Grant, her smile frozen in place, but inside her head it was like a blizzard. No one, aside from Graham and perhaps Krista, had ever spoken to her about any of this in a public place and so... *brazenly*.

Her mouth was hanging slightly open, she realized. "I..." she said, to fill the airtime and hopefully not let on to Grant that she was shocked in any way. "... am not really... trawling, but thank you. I was actually going to say," (she wasn't, but it seemed like a good idea to pretend), "...if you have time to do our little meeting right -"

"I don't, at the moment."

Sabrina looked him up and down, and then, theatrically, turned on her heels to look around at the nearly empty gallery room. "You... don't?"

"No."

"O... kay. Then... I guess I will...?" she looked around. Sebastian was still standing in the same place, his eyes burning into hers. She was knocked off balance and didn't finish her sentence.

"Is your husband here tonight?" he asked, after an uncomfortable moment.

"That's not your business."

"Is he, though?"

Sabrina's skin was becoming ever-so-slightly clammy. This guy was such an asshole. She was so unaccustomed, at this point in her life, to being subjected to this kind of male arrogance, that her mind was wiped clean.

She stared back at him, fury in her thoughts. Most men couldn't handle a look from Sabrina for that long. Sebastian Grant, however, was no easily intimidated man. He just absorbed it, and his mouth turned up a little at the corner before he sipped his smuggled wine.

"Is that why you're avoiding the artist?"

"Pardon?"

"Pardon. How quaint. One rarely hears that these days."

"I grew up in -" Sabrina began, about to tell him about her grade school years. She cut herself off just in time: this man deserved no information. "I'm not avoiding the artist," she finished.

"You don't find him attractive?" Sebastian asked, quicker than she could think.

A wave of infuriated heat flashed over her right cheek.

The truth was more awful than that, from a professional perspective: she didn't really know what the artist looked like tonight. Like most modern artists, it was anybody's guess what he would look like on any given day.

And the reason she didn't know that? Because her thoughts had been more on Sebastian Grant than Zader Godfrey.

She had no idea how to respond. She managed a weak "not really."

Sebastian Grant raised his eyebrows. "He finds you attractive."

"How would you even - ?" Sabrina began, and cut herself off because she wished that she hadn't started.

"Is your husband into black guys?" Sebastian continued, undeterred. Zader Godfrey was black - that much Sabrina knew - and that fact zinged around in her head, rattling her quite a bit.

There was the fact that she'd never slept with a black guy.

There was the fact that she thought Zader Godfrey's art was total shit and suspected he was riding on the DEI wave to undeserved fame (but in the art world, as far as she understood it, everyone was on a magic carpet of one kind or another).

And there was the inconvenient fact that she suspected that Graham might have an interest in seeing her fuck black guys.

But this guy? Sebastian Grant? *Who did he think he was?*

She smiled. A few beats more than she would have liked had passed, and she hoped Sebastian Grant didn't go thinking he'd rattled her. "I'm the one who decides who I sleep with," she said sweetly.

"Of course. As it should be. But surely you know what *he* prefers."

Why was this arrogant prick causing her pussy to throb with a dull ache? This was just a conversation. Between a dick and an event organizer. How had he managed to plant ideas in her head with this PG-13 conversation? How had this infuriating man summoned thoughts of huge black cocks that swam in her vision and wouldn't let her think straight?

She gave her head a shake, scoffed, and folded her arms. *Change the subject.* "What was it you wanted to ask me about tonight, Mr. Grant? This place seems perfectly under control, so I'll probably duck out soon."

He considered this for a moment, his steely eyes studying her with a feral, rabid intensity that made her insides tremble lustily. "Not now," he said.

She looked him up and down again. "You don't seem very busy at the moment."

He sipped his wine. "Are you afraid to approach him?"

Her heart banged out a few extra beats. "Who?"

"Hmm," Sebastian said, looking into his wine. "I think you *are*."

"Is this your game? Egging on other men's wives to fuck other guys?"

"This is the first time I've done it."

Her mouth fell open.

"I wouldn't have expected so much shock from someone... inclined, as you are, to a libertine sexual habit."

"This is completely different."

Sebastian moved his head side to side, like he was cracking it before a fight. As he did this, his age seemed suddenly different. Sabrina's attention went to what she could see formed beneath his tailored suit: shapes of muscles, an athletic physique. The stance of a boxer. His polished look transformed to a veneer in her mind: Sebastian Grant suddenly seemed rougher, more manly, more youthful. An aura of something criminal seemed to hang about him now, and she was shamed to find herself attracted to it for some reason.

He didn't speak, but made a face, his eyes toward the ceiling and only for the briefest moment - but long enough to make it clear that he didn't agree with her.

She lost her cool. "What's that supposed to mean?" she said, imitating his head shake.

"Have you ever slept with a black guy?"

She let out a caw, much like a bird, when she opened her mouth. The sound was semi-authorized, as it was much, much louder than she had anticipated. "That's not -"

"You should try it," he said casually, interrupting her.

" - any of your business. And really? Because I didn't answer your -"

"I think you're afraid."

"I'm not."

"Mmm. Then what is it?"

Her heart was now banging away so hard and so quickly in her chest that she could feel it inside her chest every other beat.

"It's just never lined up," she spat.

Sebastian Grant came closer to her, to the point that it was just a hair too intimate to be professional, and the air between them sizzled with an electricity that Sabrina didn't understand. It wasn't lust.

Was it?

Not really.

She hated being this indecisive and confused. It had been a long, long time since she'd been knocked off her game by anyone.

"Does your husband ever choose your men for you?" His voice was low and obviously sexual, his eyes on hers, making her stomach wriggle, her chest feel tight, and her skin sting with electricity. Between her legs, a sensual pang echoed the cold slam in her chest, and she was sure that some sweat beaded at the nape of her neck.

"*I* choose," she said, her voice flat, her eyes on the fingers of his right hand, which he was lifting between their bodies, the back of it toward her, the fingers together as though he were holding something, but he wasn't. He moved his hand within a breath of her very flattering, very tight red dress, the pointer and middle finger flitting out as though to brush her stomach, and then again her breasts, and then her exposed chest, and then her throat - but he never touched her.

"You want him to, though. Don't you?"

Her eyes flew in that moment, from his fingers to his lips. She had intended to look at his eyes, but she stopped at his lips, at the very thick, salt-and-pepper stubble that was just breaking out of his skin. A tremor went through her before she lifted her gaze to meet his eyes. He was staring back

at her so intently it made the tremor turn to a shudder and she wanted to look away.

You want him to though, don't you?

Her chest was cool and danger lurked in every inch of her body. Even though it was something she very rarely thought about, and would have denied under any other circumstances but these - there was a hard, pulsing truth to what Sebastian Grant had just said. And it dumped ice water into her veins that he had hit the nail so precisely on the head./

His fingers brushed so lightly against her throat that she would leave that night wondering if they had actually touched her at all, or it was just her imagination. Whatever it was, it sent a wave of delicious heat across her skin and thrilling goosebumps all over her body.

And then abruptly, he stepped back. Sipped his wine. He seemed very self-satisfied, which made Sabrina furious all over again. She was racking her brains for a way to get rid of him -

"I could tell you what to do," he told her, interrupting her thoughts.

She tried very hard to maintain an expression on her face that broadcast a disinterested and lighthearted attitude. She was boiling inside, her pussy throbbing, but there was no way in hell she was going to let this guy know that.

"I imagine you could," she managed to say, with a toss of her hair. "But that's not our arrangement."

She knew that Sebastian Grant had already registered his effect on her, no matter how she managed to say that sentence in a neutral tone. He was amused and cocksure as he looked at her.

"Of course it isn't," he said, after a long and uncomfortable pause.

Another beat of simmering heat that Sabrina couldn't put her finger on, and her head whirled within it, her knees weakened by the forces warring inside of her. People began to agitate in the next room: the artist must have ended his speech. Sebastian Grant's upper torso hinged very subtly and he leaned a little closer to her to add, "That's why you like the idea so much."

And then, just as the room began to fill and Sabrina felt like her blood vessels would break under the surge of energy that pulsed through them, he turned, sipping his wine, and strolled back the way he came.

Stunned by the exchange, confused about her feelings, Sabrina turned to find herself facing a wall. She played it as smooth as she could and walked along it, pretending to look at information panels, in case Sebastian Grant happened to be watching.

He was not. When she turned around he was gone.

Her phone vibrated. She took it out, half-expecting Sebastian to have written her, half-hoping that was the case. Instead, a pang of guilt: it was Graham.

How's the weird guy?

Another flash of intense guilt. Her hand went to her neck before she realized what she was doing. In here hair, at the nape, it was damp with a cool sweat that had come on her suddenly.

She even lifted her head and looked around, peering into the crowd.

She shook her head.

She didn't immediately want to write back to Graham, but he could see that she'd received the message. This was an agreement they'd come to, because not knowing if the other person was reading or typing the texts could make a person crazy in the situations they would get themselves in.

She wished, however momentarily, that they didn't have the text arrangement.

"God," she whispered under her breath, preparing to type something back to her husband.

She didn't like lying to Graham in any way: not by omission, not by obfuscation, not by invention. It was all the same to her, and she was pretty sure it was all the same to him. She finally responded:

He's still weird. Can't figure him out. Tell you later.

It wasn't untrue. It locked her in to a discussion somewhere in the future.

And Sebastian Grant *was* still "weird," and she *couldn't* figure him out.

All this time, the conversation with Sebastian Grant was on repeat in her mind. A low drone, half-finished sentences.

Does your husband ever choose your men for you...I choose...but you'd like him to, wouldn't you?... I could tell you what to do.

The urge to do what she did next came over her suddenly. It was reckless and nonsensical, it bordered on lawlessness. But in her hand her phone stared up at her with her text written out and the two check marks indicating that Graham had seen it:

The artist at this show is a young guy. Hot. I think he's into me.

He and Sabrina had agreements to "tell each other everything," but he had always believed that Sabrina and he were at the age, and the point in their marriage, where they both understood that some things didn't get said

because they weren't important, or it was better that they didn't, or maybe just because they wanted to keep something to themselves.

He knew Sabrina couldn't possibly tell him *everything*. And if she had - if every stray thought or flicker of attraction were suddenly bared to him - then it would take a lot of the fun out of what they had going.

So when Sabrina texted him that the artist at the show she was managing seemed interested in her, and then didn't add any details, he took it upon himself to look the guy up and fill the gaps in his knowledge in for himself.

And when the artist in question turned out to be black, and his cock unfurled into rock-hard rigidity, he took it upon himself to indulge in the fantasy he'd been keeping in his back pocket for some time now.

After all, Sabrina had always insisted that she choose the guys she fucked, and that made sense. And she never, ever chose a black guy. So that fantasy - which he already felt a little guilty about having - stayed on the back burner.

Coming to the arrangement they already had was difficult enough for him to step out on a limb and do. The beginning hadn't been easy, or straightforward. But after it a while, it had become the best of both worlds: safe, because they could both trust each other not to throw any curve balls, and exciting, because it was still pretty taboo.

He had never had the balls, if he was being honest, to rock the boat: he had a good thing going and his desires were fulfilled. He tried to play it cool, like he did with all of her other trysts, but his enthusiasm for the idea spilled over.

The artist at this show is a young guy. Hot. I think he's into me.

Good luck then, my sexy vixen.

I might as well tell you, I'm here at the hotel

You know, in case you come back here

And then, when he got nothing from Sabrina for a long time, he assumed she was putting the moves on her artist, and decided to see what he could find out for himself.

He was young. Great-looking.

Black.

And he had the reaction he had. There was no stopping it: the idea of Sabrina with a black guy has been a fantasy for long time. The floodgates were strained by this crack in them, and then they were wide open.

Sabrina still hadn't texted him back but he wanted to be in touch with her anyway. He began to pace, to search out more info about this potential lover, to check his messages every few seconds.

He started to tell himself delicious stories (Sabrina was doing this on purpose because she'd somehow learned of his fantasy and she wanted to surprise him) and then let his fears wash over the fantasies until he was about to burst. Why wasn't Sabrina texting him back?

He threw back a drink to calm his nerves. Maybe too much of a pour. The anticipation that he ordinarily felt when Sabrina was out on the prowl was amplified by an order of ten.

I just looked this guy up

He finally wrote, almost salivating for a response. The message went unread, no matter how long he stared at it, willing Sabrina to read it. She could be anywhere, doing anything with this guy, he thought, and he let his imagination run wild.

More pacing. More checking of the phone. A temptation to go out and try to find her - but where? They could be anywhere.

The message had been read, the next time he checked. No response, no rolling dots to indicate that she was typing.

A man had to trust in this kind of situation. Even if his heart was beating wildly out his chest. Did Sabrina know what she was doing to him?

Paranoia began to creep in, the same way it always did: through any crack, via any suspicion. If Sabrina was doing all of this on purpose, why hadn't she said anything to him about it? It wasn't as if she'd dropped a trail of breadcrumbs. Maybe she didn't know about his fantasy, maybe she didn't think anything of it.

But it wasn't as if Sabrina was some dumb woman who wouldn't register this as a change of pace. It wasn't like she didn't have any clue about the stereotypes, about how commonplace this trope was among men of his persuasion. Hadn't she even shaken her head and said she didn't understand it?

Why wasn't she writing back?

Hopeful thoughts - it was all part of her surprise - drifted along with the paranoia, until he was half out of his mind. He loved it, he felt utterly out of control. There was no clear relationship between those two feelings: he loved it.

But, or because, he felt out of control.

And all the while, the infuriating and tantalizing silence of his wife.

Chapter Ten

When the door clicked open it was after a series of thuds against it, dull fumlings with no discernible tempo. The kind of sounds made by two people who can't keep their hands off each other before they get into a room.

Graham's cock swelled again, he settled into his chair, he lifted the drink that was already on the table next to him. Mentally, he had prepared himself for acting cool while his wife banged her first black guy.

There would be time, later, to talk about that particular fantasy, to roll around in it with her. He could finally be able to admit his preference. He could taste the sweetness, for the first time, of feeling like like it could be hers, too. *Maybe*. This was a game of waiting, with Sabrina on the other side of the court, with the proverbial ball in her hands. Always.

Either way, it was so exciting that it clawed beneath his skin: the kind of desperation that had gripped him as a teenager, when sex had been just within his grasp. Time seemed to grind to a halt.

Silhouettes first: His, leading, walking backward. Sabrina was pushing him in, attacking him with her lips. He heard her laugh: she was having fun.

But the outline of the guy's hair against the blazing hallway light didn't seem right. It took them seconds to get into the room, but during that brief time Graham was able to ride a roller coaster of confusion: maybe he was misremembering the photo? He thought the guy had dreads. This looked like the wispy, funky hairline of some white guy...

Because it was. When Sabrina pushed him onto the bed and leaned against the dresser to catch her breath, there was no denying it: this guy was white.

Sabrina seemed very happy, though. Delirious, almost. she was out of breath, her lipstick long gone, her hair ruffled quite a bit. The stench of cigarettes had absorbed into her leather jacket, and that was a little annoying to Graham, who knew that she smoked sometimes but hated the smell.

Maybe it was the guy giving her this feverish look.

The guy glanced at Graham, but he seemed to expect him there. Graham had done this enough that he had perfected the art of just sitting there, of reading a guy's reaction to his presence. No one ever objected so much that they left. This guy didn't seem to care at all.

Sabrina shrugged her leather jacket from her shoulders. Beneath it, she was clad in a red dress so clingy it did in fact seem painted on, and the guy never gave Graham another look.

"Take your clothes off," Sabrina told him, leaning against the dresser with her hands at either side of her hips. She was still out of breath, like she'd been running. A wild, wild flush was on her cheeks.

Another shift of the eyes to Graham - very brief. Then back to Sabrina. A hesitation, like he couldn't believe this was true. Then he reached behind his back and pulled on his shirt, removing it to reveal his very fit physique.

"Your pants, too," Sabrina said, crossing over to the small counter with the mini-fridge. She took out a bottle of water and cracked it open, drinking three very large gulps while eyeing her boy toy. The guy smiled, looked hesitant for one second, and then, like every other guy in his position had done so far - he assessed that whatever risk he might be sensing was not enough to risk losing this opportunity.

Since hotwifing had become mainstream enough to make it into TV shows and occasionally a high-profile political scandal like any other run-of-the-mill sexual "impropriety," most guys his age seemed to know the score.

"Pants," Sabrina said, wiping her mouth.

Graham was mildly disturbed. Sabrina seemed off - nothing he could put his finger on, just a frenetic, hurried vibe to her games. Her eyes were rigidly fixed to the guy she'd picked up, and she didn't once look in Graham's direction.

He stood up, grinning with the kind of self-satisfied smile that only a guy with a decent dick could possibly have at a moment like that. He said nothing, just got out of his pants and when he turned to Sabrina for approval and she moved her finger in a circle impatiently as a response, saying "those, too," he removed the plain, dark-colored boxers he was wearing and his hard cock - decent, nothing to write home about, unfurled.

An average cock on a very attractive guy, Graham supposed. He had an unmemorable face and brown hair, a cock that bordered on being the definition of average and acceptable.

But his body hadn't clocked than twenty-two years of runtime, and so Graham assumed that youth - as usual - been the main appeal for Sabrina.

But he was white, and that lingered in the air as an unanswered question.

Tantalizing in its own way: was Sabrina playing new games with him?

"Sit down," she ordered the guy. "On the edge of the bed."

He looked confused, turned around to see what awaited him on the bed, and then sat. "What are you -"

"Feet on the floor," Sabrina giggled. She set the water down and strode back to face him at the end of the bed. Her attention went straight to his cock, which twitched as soon as her gaze caressed it, as if her hand had been there to stroke it.

"Good boy," Sabrina said. Softly, almost like she was a teacher tired of explaining something to a child. Graham's attention was sucked away by this, instead of what was happening right in front of him. For the next fifteen minutes the strangeness would remain. His eyes were treated to live porn, his wife was saying senselessly hot stuff... but something was not entirely right with Sabrina. She seemed unconvinced of her own power.

She approached the guy and stopped in front of his knees. Looking down at him as she was, Graham envied the guy on the bed. This happened every time - the envy. Sabrina had never been like this with him: bossy, in charge. They met young. He asked her to do it, eventually, and she humored him... but it had always seemed like an act when she did it to her husband.

Not like this. Not molten. Her too-sweet voice with hard edges, her eyes dominating.

She used her hands to drop the straps of her dress, which fit so tightly that it remained exactly as it was.

"Peel my dress off," she said quietly. Her voice was bossy, her eyes were murderous. When he began to stand up, placing his fingers at the bottom hem, her hands moved quickly to his forearms. "Stay there. Pull it *down*."

He began again, unsure, his fingers almost trembling as they reached for the low dip of Sabrina's dress. He tugged, and the dress began to slide over her skin. Inch by inch, she was revealed. When her nipples were finally freed, the guy lost his concentration for a moment and stared at her tits with raw appreciation.

"Keep going," Sabrina said. The playfulness in her voice seemed forced.

Down went the dress, until it was at her knees, and all that remained of her clothing was a pair of thong underwear. The scent of her pussy was strong and reached his nose immediately.

She stepped back to step out of the dress after shaking it down to a pile around her ankles. As she hooked her thumbs under the fabric of her thong, she gave the guy a simmering stare.

Then, as she pulled them down: "I'm going to climb on your lap and ride you until I come."

His cock wagged like the tail of a dog.

A step forward. She left her shoes on, ankle-high black leather boots with a three-inch, spiked heel. The soles were red and matched her dress. Everything else had been removed from her body, and the hapless guy on the bed on front of her was itching to grab for it.

She put a finger out to his lips and touched them in a strange way. "But you're not going to come when I do that."

He didn't know what to say.

Graham wouldn't have, either: this was a new-ish act from Sabrina. She liked to boss but not this much. Not *like* this.

The man on the bed nodded, his mouth hanging open, probably doing all he could not to mess up whatever it was that he had been lucky enough to get rolled into.

Sabrina inched closer to him, grabbed his hair, turned his face up to her. One knee went to the bed, and her free hand slapped away the guy's right arm. With her body so close to his he could bury his face in her tits, he had tried to put a hand on her luscious ass.

"Tell me you understand the assignment," she practically seethed. She was smiling, and it was hot, but Graham felt a current of unfamiliarity when she said this. Her teeth were slightly gritted. She didn't seem like her ordinary self.

"Understood," he said. His slapped-away hand was gripping the bedding, holding on for dear life.

"Good," Sabrina said, and she lifted her left knee to climb onto the bed, and his lap. Her own free hand went to the back of his head with the other, and she pulled sharply on his hair to force his face to turn up at hers.

His cock was pulsing visibly, close to her pussy that hovered just above it. Sabrina craned her neck to get her lips very close to his, staring him down until he was paralyzed - except for his cock.

"Hold your dick still," Sabrina ordered. Like a zombie he reached for it and wriggled his hand between their legs to catch his swinging cock. He directed it to the dripping lips between her legs, fear of failure pouring out of his eyes.

Sabrina sat on his dick, slowly lowering her cunt down his shaft. The reaction from him was immediate, his mouth hung open, he strained to watch with his eyes - but she had a handful of his hair in her grip and she wasn't letting him.

Sabrina wriggled on his lap and settled into a position that pleased her. She fucked him slowly as she did, looking around their bodies like she was checking things off a list. She released his hair and placed her hands on his

shoulders. She slid them down his arms while she rocked on his lap, and purred like a cat.

"Put your hands on my lower back," she told him. He did, but he didn't know what she wanted. Sabrina bent her arms and twisted them to put his hands where she evidently wanted them - Graham didn't know what that was, either. This was the first time she'd ever done this.

His fingers at the small of her back, his thumbs wrapped around her narrow waist, Sabrina seemed satisfied. She started to fuck him. At first, her hands were on his shoulders, but then she let go and leaned back so that her tits were at eye level, bouncing gently with her undulating hips, and she could throw her head back in abandon.

"Oh, oh," she gasped. Her voice, with its breathy and ethereal properties, gave a specific nasty bent to anything she chose to say between mewls. "Just like that, just hold me right there while I fuck you."

Graham could see a flash of fear in the eyes of the man who'd just been given these instructions.

It was diabolical, really, to do this to a young guy. A throb of excruciating sympathy pain seized Graham's dick. A glance at his own lap told him that he was oozing precum into his pants. He wondered how this guy must feel, with a wild beautiful older woman bossing him around and riding his cock like a banshee, telling him not to come yet.

"I'm so close," Sabrina said, bouncing. The guy's face looked ashen suddenly, like he might throw up. He sharpened his concentration by closing his eyes, which Sabrina didn't notice. She was too busy, with her head tilted back and her back arched to thrust her tits closer to his face.

Suddenly she swung her head back to face him. Her hair was clinging to her skin wherever it came into contact. She left it, not even bothering to

clear away the strands caught across her cheek and in her lips. Humidity caught in her hair made it stand up wildly, beautifully.

"I'm going to come all over your cock," she told him. And then leaned close to his ear, opposite Graham's side of the room. She whispered something to him that made him grimace in concentration, before throwing her head back and slamming her hips against him with three thrusts as she she howled. Between her legs, the wet slaps of their bodies were overridden by the spurting sound of pussy juice.

Panting, her hips in a slowing roll until she settled on him, her hands back at his shoulders, she stared into his eyes.

She smiled. "You didn't come," she told him.

"No ma'am."

This made Sabrina laugh. She rolled her hips again and made him groan. Still smiling, drunk on her power over him, she twisted a little and moved her body to tease him more. "Good boy," she said, partially breathless. "And now that my pussy is so sore, and wet, and swollen... you're going to throw me on the bed and fuck me until I come again."

"Understood," he said, eagerness in his eyes. He was now being a good soldier: he'd tapped into some reserve of sexual power and was determined to "understand the assignment" at all costs.

Sabrina licked his lips. Graham felt another wave of disorientation. The unfamiliarity in Sabrina was most unsettling because it was subtle: she was far more sexually wriggly, more commanding... herself but as if all the knives had been sharpened and her appetite had ballooned, all traces of tenderness or insecurity blown away in a windstorm. She was a ravenous animal.

It was hot as fuck, but a cool unsettled dread was brewing in Graham's abdomen. A chill skittered over his shoulder blades. His ball sack convulsed.

Sabrina was still sitting on the guy's lap. She bit into his lower lip, staring him down. "I want you to fuck me like a screen door in a hurricane," she told him. "Until I come again. And then, and only then, you can fill my pussy up with your cum."

He froze momentarily - Graham guessed because what Sabrina had said to him had affected him the same way it was affecting Graham: taking him right up to the edge of orgasm with just her words. Only the poor young man had his cock inside her pussy, and Graham knew that it was probably convulsing around it, squeezing him with a velvet flesh glove, urging him to fuck her hard and fill her up.

Sabrina looked at him sweetly, and then tipped her head. "Well?" she asked him.

He grit his teeth and nodded, but he looked more like a guy headed into combat than anything else.

"Can," Sabrina said, her tongue running over his upper lip, "you... do... it?"

"Yes ma'am," he said, but it was a garbled whisper.

Good luck buddy, Graham felt like saying. RIP.

"Remember: like a screen door. No matter how much I complain about being too tender."

The guy tipped his head forward, into her tits, and groaned. Sabrina laughed again. Then she gave a succession of little slaps to his back. "Get to it, then."

His wife was promptly thrown on the bed, and the seemingly docile guy came to life again. She sprawled on the duvet, a little surprised by his sudden manic action. His dick looked twice as big as it had before, his ball sack so taut it looked painful. It probably all was, Graham figured. Sabrina wriggled playfully on the bed while he arranged himself between her legs, his eyes wandering over her body. One hand held his cock, but between two fingers like he thought gripping it any more would send him over the edge.

Sabrina tossed an arm above her head carelessly. "Like a screen door," she reminded him. "No matter what I say."

She did not make it easy for him. As soon as he slid into her pussy she mewled and squirmed, and Graham smiled in empathy when he squeezed his eyes closed and inhaled. He wondered what the poor guy had to think about to keep himself from blowing up.

She really took it to the next level, moaning and mewling, whining that her pussy was too tender. "I can feel every inch of your cock," she wailed.

And then she changed - as suddenly as everything else she was doing. Her face grew serious, she ceased making noises. She hung her arm around the back of his neck and lifted her own head to watch between them. "I'm going to come soon," she mewled. "Oh, yes, just like that... just keep fucking me just like that... slow down now, nice and slow..."

"You want me to slow down?" he asked her, suddenly confused.

Sabrina wasn't really listening to him. She was watching his cock move in and out of her pussy, hanging onto his neck, panting... but her mind was on something else. "So close..." she panted.

"Oh, God, lady... I'm gonna come..."

Sabrina looked up at him sharply and let go of his neck to fall back onto the bed. She reached up with her other hand and grabbed a fistful of his

hair, yanking on it hard. "No you're not," she told him icily. "It's going to feel so good when you do, but you're not going to do it yet. What are you going to do?"

"Fuck you... I'm... oh God..."

"Fuck me until what?" Sabrina tugged on his hair.

"Until you come," he responded, his face setting back into a grim stare. Graham decided the guy probably had some military training, because he had a steely resolve to tap into. Most of the guys Sabrina had fucked would never have made it this far.

Sabrina let go of his hair, roughly. "That's right. So do what I told you to do."

With his features pinched in extreme concentration, Sabrina's bull nobly attempted to give her what she wanted. Responding to her commands, he started to fuck her slowly, his gaze wandering over her head to a point on the mattress. But Sabrina made constant, sultry mewls, promising with each one that she was almost there, reminding him each time how good it would feel to fill her pussy up with cum until it overflowed and ran down his balls... that he cracked.

Just before her screeching reached a fever pitch, Graham saw the man's entire torso shudder, and his face twisted in surprise as his eyes flew open. Sabrina came, and he valiantly continued to fuck her, but he had lost control already. His cum was pouring into her, and he had failed his task.

It didn't seem to matter to Sabrina until the end. She was tossing her head side to side and her thighs rippled with the spasms that coursed through her whole body when she had a really good orgasm. Her lover groaned and tipped his head into her tits again, collapsing on top of her body - kind enough to rest his weight on his forearms, at least.

Sabrina brought a hand to her face to wipe away some sweat. Then she turned her head at an angle to look at Graham, and his body went rigid as the searing image boiled through him. Sabrina's smoke-rimmed eyes were smeared with makeup, but the piercing blue looked even more seductive like this. "I love you," she mouthed.

Then she patted her man on the back. "Okay. I can't breathe."

He rolled and she pushed, and soon he was off her. She sat up and curled her feet to one side of her body. Moving her fingers over his heaving chest, she wandered playfully to his thighs, seemed thoughtful for a moment, and then smiled at him again. "You have an cigarettes you can leave me?"

He squinted, lifted his head to look down at his dick, as if he couldn't be sure any of that was happening.

"Sabrina," Graham objected.

"Whaaaaat?" Sabrina whined, sexily, tossing her hair as she turned to Graham. "I do it all the time when you're not here." She turned back to her guy. "I need a lighter, too."

He looked confused. Sabrina rolled and stretched out on the bed with her head at the top. "It's the least you could do," she teased him.

"I, uh... sure..."

He gave an awkward look back at Graham, and seemed momentarily stunned again. Then he found his jeans, rifled through them, tossed the pack at Sabrina with a lighter tucked into the plastic wrapper. They were Camels, the pack nearly full.

He put his jeans on without his boxers, picked up his shirt, ran his hand through his hair, and looked around. Sabrina was fiddling with the cigarettes after murmuring thanks, one knee bent, totally naked. Graham made eye contact but didn't say anything: typically, this was for the best.

"You don't need to give a speech," Sabrina laughed, without looking up at him. To Graham's surprise, she put a cigarette in her mouth and lit it up. "It was a good time. Thanks for the smokes."

"Should I, uh... are you... do you want to exchange, uh..."

Sabrina rolled her head slowly side to side and smiled.

"Okay," he said quickly, giving one final glance around the room, and then, he left.

Graham followed and locked the second lock on the door. He waved at the smokey air when he came back. Sabrina was already standing, stark naked, and opening a window.

"Sabrina, what's with the smoke?" he asked her.

She was on her knees in an armchair, looking beautiful. Raised up, not resting on her heels, tits out, on view for anyone in the building across the street, which thankfully was an office building with almost no lights on and probably no workers. The air from the city gushed in, whipping her hair around. The dull din of traffic rose up from below.

"I always do it," she said, bringing the cigarette to her lips and gazing wistfully out the window. "When I sleep with a smoker."

Graham had stopped, a few yards away from her. He admired the view and he wanted to fuck, but there was something utterly strange about Sabrina tonight.

"That was hot," he said.

Sabrina smiled. "It was." She turned toward him and ashed in a drinking glass. "Did you see the look on his face? He did give it his all." She smiled again. Her eyes dropped to Graham's crotch.

He stepped closer to her, and an invitation formed on her lips, in her body, in the way she dropped the cigarette carelessly into the glass without

another thought.

So all the questions he had would wait. Because his wife was beautiful, and she had a pussy full of cum, and he had just been forced to watch her get banged like "a screen door in a hurricane" - an expression he'd have to ask her about, if he even remembered.

Chapter Eleven

Things became instantly complicated. Faster than ever before, unexpectedly. From the point that she sent the message to Graham -

The artist at this show is a young guy. Hot. I think he's into me.

- a wild move she wasn't even able to explain why she made - she began to make wild decisions. Wilder things were set into motion, and she reacted to by doing things that would have been unpredictable to herself, even just that morning.

After sending the message, her pulse quickened and she looked around frantically. Then she went to the ladies' to check her appearance, which was funny because she rarely did that. She had no need for it. The woman who looked back at her in the mirror was herself: put together but not screaming for attention. Beautiful, obviously not in her twenties but any guess from 30-50 held possibility. Her shoulder-length, flippant hair was coiffed

perfectly, her make-up in place. She arranged her leather jacket to show off more of her dress and was pleased with the result, but unsure why she did it.

And then, she strolled right out in search of Zader Godfrey.

The black man to whom she'd given almost zero thought until five minutes before.

He wasn't hard to find: he was the only black guy in the room. He wasn't afraid to look at her, and he wasn't afraid to make his interest in her known. It sizzled inside of her, even if she had a penchant for being the hunter, not the prey.

She was walking toward him with a professional air about her, thinking of a professional thing she could say.

He, on the other hand, wasted no time moving his eyes up and down her figure with obvious interest.

"Mr. Godfrey, " she began, extending her hand to him, and her most alluring smile. "I -"

"You can call me Zader."

Just that. Fully confident, full of himself, casting a line with all the obviousness of an extra in a fly-fishing movie. No opening left at the end of the sentence, no indecision lingering in the statement. It came across as a command, even with the softening of "you can" at the beginning.

His eyes were still on hers.

He took her hand, and shook it, but there was a squeeze in his handshake that was obvious and sexual. She had a hard time meeting his gaze, because it was penetrating in a nearly literal sense. She half-expected him to ask her if they could go fuck in the hallway, just like that.

She would go with him, probably, if he did.

The excitement left in the wake of Sebastian's departure was re-ignited between her legs. She didn't know what proportions of it were from Zader himself - a guy she probably wouldn't have even considered looking at if not for Sebastian - and what percentages were from Sebastian's influence.

Or her partial lie to Graham.

A dip in her mood as she thought of the lie: guilt skittered across the surface of her heart but evaporated in the dark eyes of the dark man who was still holding her hand.

She was afraid of him, if she was being perfectly honest. And it was because he was black. She wasn't afraid of talking to him: she was afraid of sleeping with him.

Fear maybe wasn't the right word: it was more about the unknown than anything else. She knew the stereotypes that fed into this fear weren't true; she just couldn't help it that it simmered beneath her skin. She'd just never *been* with a black guy before. She was old enough to remember a time when it was uncommon, when things were different.

A time, though, that had never touched this man's timeline.

It was her turn to speak, and she had no idea what to say. "Zader, then," she stated, voice confident-sounding, at least. Or maybe just professional. She felt flustered. It was hard to know what was causing that: Zader's blackness, his confidence, her attraction to him, her fear of him. Sebastian Grant was somehow mixed in with all of it, and it bothered her.

The whole situation, even though she was leading it, felt like it was slipping out of her control. Her eyes moved around rapidly, taking in snippets of Zader Godfrey: his short dreads, his big lips, the pale color of the palms of his hands. His straight-backed posture. The confidence radiating from him.

The fact that her own confidence wasn't making a dent in it.

It didn't even seem to be intriguing him.

She couldn't know what he thought, but men his age were usually thrown off by her attitude. They weakened easily, fell into line. She sensed it in them like a weakness in a metal wire - they signaled it somehow, that she could tell them what to do and they would do it.

Not Zader. The black artist with the Jewish last name. He met it in the face. Hard.

Zader Godfrey was taking her in like she was just any other hot woman, and he wasn't hiding his intentions. He pressed his lips together and licked them as they unfolded, in a move typical of black men. "Mmm-hmm," he intoned. "Call me that."

"Very kind," she said. "I'm Sabrina Grant -"

"What's your nickname?" Zader interrupted. He wasn't looking at her face. His eyes were hovering somewhere around her hips.

Sabrina stumbled - what the fuck kind of question was that? - but quickly recovered. "I don't have one," she said, placing a hand on one hip and twisting a little. "What's yours?"

His eyes returned to hers. He repeated his quick lip-sucking and licking, and smiled. "I only got two syllables in my name. *Miss*. No need."

The "Miss" was flippant. Sabrina was sure that it was coated in a sexual "something," and even if she didn't know exactly what it was, it made her insides twist. She held up her left hand so Zader could see the wedding band: she was ma'am or missus. He looked right at it, smiled at it, and shook his head while smiling and looking at Sabrina.

Unfazed.

No man had ever conveyed to her, quite so directly and without saying anything, that the wedding ring was a turn on, not a deterrent.

She struggled to think of something to say. But only briefly.

"Ah. You two found each other."

Zader Godfrey didn't take his eyes off hers for more than one second to glance, and smile, at the owner of the voice, who was approaching from behind Sabrina. Zader's eyes went back to hers.

She didn't react or turn around: she already knew the voice was Sebastian Grant's. It traveled like an electric shock along her spine.

He appeared next to them, extended a hand to Zader, who took it and shook it, leaving Sabrina with the impression that the two knew each other quite well. He was also delighting in broadcasting to Sabrina that this was what he had wanted to happen all along, and that he was pleased with it.

That he was pleased that she was doing what he'd said he wanted her to do.

A variety of feelings poured through her veins: a twist of humiliation, because Sebastian Grant was taking pains to make her see that he was pleased with this interaction. It was also hot: the hum of sexual energy that he brought to her was back on, infiltrating her organs. She had already been turned on by Zader himself, and so this was an enhancement.

A strange, intoxicating enhancement that she had no explanation for, but an enhancement nonetheless.

But it was also all a huge problem, because a number of things had developed at a whiplashing speed, and she didn't have any idea why she'd even sent that text to Graham.

Graham, who was in a hotel room waiting for her, who would now expect to see her there with either this black man or with no one at all.

She'd boxed herself into something, and some of it was not quite kosher.

This was how, after years of being at the peak of her sexual prowess, in control of everything - and everyone - Sabrina Cole found herself pushed to the back seat of a sexual adventure.

"Let's go to Harry's," Sebastian suggested. Harry's was an upscale club frequented by the wealthy and the beautiful, not just drunk children looking to hook up to absurd music and strobe lights. You had to know people to get into Harry's.

"Yeah," the black artist said, .. His name in the immediate moment escaped Sabrina's memory. He was looking at Sabrina with an appetite that seemed more like a wolf's than a man's. "Let's go to Harry's."

Sebastian blinked at her, a challenging look in his eyes. The same came from Zader, though it was its own brand of challenge.

A rain of competitive impulses fell on the hot sexual layers beneath Sabrina's skin.

She could have said anything. Excuses were literally lying at her feet: she had more things to do here, for Red Velvet... she would meet them there... she had to be at the Expo at four am. She could extricate herself from this slow-boiling water and once she did that, the spell would be broken and she would escape.

These ideas flitted briefly through her mind. They evaporated, like so much rain on a superheated sidewalk, and turned to steam. The shape of Zader's muscles beneath his plain white shirt beckoned her. Sebastian Grant's intense stare nudged her, played with her mind.

She had *teased* something to Graham.

She really should follow through.

She tipped her head, letting her hair swing against her bare shoulder. Opened her leather jacket to display the dress beneath it, which clung to her form and left nothing to be imagined: the shape of her tits, the placement of her nipples, the way her stomach rounded almost imperceptibly before colliding with her hips, the creases of her thighs.

Both men took it in appreciatively as she asked, in her lilting, too-soft voice:

"Do you think they'll let me in like this?"

Neither man responded verbally. Zader sucked on his lip again, and Sebastian Grant took out his phone and began to type into it, smiling to himself as if someone had told him a great joke. He brought the phone to his ear and looked at Sabrina. "Yeah. Bring the car around front."

He turned ever-so-slightly, so that his face was out of Zader's sight.

That was when he winked at Sabrina. An impulse began in her pupils, and then zagged from her brain, down her spine, and right to the center of her legs.

"What game are you playing?" Sabrina demanded, once Zader was out of earshot. She was seated in a VIP section that they had waltzed into from the back of the club, where Sebastian's private limo had dropped them off.

Sebastian was pouring some champagne into a flute - for himself, Sabrina already had some - and rather than answer, he smiled and sipped it. She stared at him, slightly aggravated, slightly - well, more than slightly - turned on.

"No game," he replied, when she wouldn't stop glaring at him.

She growled, even though she knew he couldn't hear it. Glanced to the right to look at Zader again - he was glad-handing people for the moment, but his interest in Sabrina was known. It was obvious: he made no effort to hide it. He looked at her the way a cat looks at a mouse he intends to play with before devouring it.

As did Sebastian.

"Okay, well," she said uncertainly. "If that's the case, then, this has been fun, but I have to get going." She pulled her phone out of her purse. She was already being, and had already been, irresponsible enough.

She'd left things with Alicia to close down, but it had been obvious to anyone present that she was going out with these two men.

To an observant person, it was also obvious everything about it wasn't entirely above-board.

It wasn't kosher for her, either. So far, she hadn't lied to her husband, but she also hadn't told the whole weird truth. His final message hung in the air on her phone, bothering her even though she wasn't looking at it.

Sebastian leaned forward so she could hear him as he spoke in a low voice.

"You mean you're not going to fuck Zader Godfrey?" He raised his eyebrows playfully. "You don't want to?"

She tried to smile. "That's none of your business."

"Is it because you're scared?"

She rolled her eyes. At this point, while she was still mildly afraid of a black guy in general, she was attracted enough to Zader Godfrey for it to not be the things stopping her from fucking him.

Nothing was really stopping her from fucking *him* - except for the fact that Sebastian Grant wanted her to do it.

The fact that Sebastian Grant wanted her to do it also turned her on.
It was confusing as fuck.

She gave her head a shake and looked back at her phone, swiping through apps with no idea what she had originally intended to do. Her messenger app seemed to burn through the phone to her hand, the guilt white-hot.

"Don't tell me you're not interested," Sebastian continued.

She lifted her eyes to meet his. "I *am* interested."

"So why are you leaving?"

She let out a sigh. "Look. This..." she waved between them, from herself to Sebastian and back again. "It's like, over the line for some reason."

"Mmm. So you're going leaving. Like a well-trained wife."

"Excuse me?" She spat this out, and she sounded ticked. But the real feeling ignited by his statement were different. Wild, and confusing.

He shrugged. "I thought you did what you wanted to do. Or excuse me, *who* you wanted to do."

She was at a loss, but only for a moment. "Yeah, but you're the one who seems to want me to fuck this guy more than anyone."

He smiled. "I do want that. But what I want isn't especially relevant. *You* want to fuck him. So why don't you?"

She stared back at him.

"Because I want you to?" he probed. Then he sat back, and smiled.

Her head whirled.

She and Graham had ironed out the details of their relationship to such a point now that she had never even really considered the possibility of something taking place that she would need to think about like this.

But here it was: a situation that seemed like a bad idea, though she couldn't exactly say why.

Or why she was having any trouble at all with it.

All she had to do was get her phone out and tell Graham all about it.

Or leave.

Something was stopping her from doing that. A kind of rush that she hadn't felt in a long time. She struggled to put her finger on what it was exactly.

Feelings, she and Graham had talked about: if she started having deeper feelings for some guy, she had to tell him, and they would manage it together.

But she had no feelings like that here.

Not that kind. She was sure of it.

It was something else. A desire, maybe, to do something taboo again? A need to be out-of-bounds?

Sebastian Grant seemed to be reading her mind. He leaned forward on his elbows. "If you took me out of the equation, what would you do? Sleep with Zader?"

"That's..." she scoffed, not really sure what she intended to say. That's not the same thing? That's none of your business? The words evaporated.

"Maybe you don't have it in you."

"Are you goading me?"

Sebastian Grant's eyes lit up. "Does that turn you on?"

He *was* goading her, and she knew it, and she was infuriated by it. So when she gave her hair a toss, set her drink on the table, and folded her arms, she wasn't sure exactly what her tone was. She *was* turned on. But she didn't want Sebastian Grant to have the satisfaction of knowing that she was.

They challenged each other over the table like this for a few moments.

"I have a proposal for you," Sebastian said at last.

She leaned forward to hear him better, but kept her face as neutral as she could.

"You do what I say."

For a moment she was sure this was the end of the sentence and his thought. He did this by design, pausing so long that her mind went to a different place, while her body reacted to the idea with hot liquid between her legs.

But there had been a comma at the end of that sentence. He just took a long time to get to it.

"And let me watch."

She laughed, grateful to have something to do to take back some control.

"Why would I do that?"

But Sebastian Grant was unflappable. "I'll pay you, if you want."

She laughed again, this time less genuinely. Indecent proposal scenarios were something else she and Graham had talked about, but no one had ever had the imagination to think of *this* situation.

This didn't need more explanation from Sebastian. It was an explicit request to take Graham's place in this game. Her mouth was open to object, but Sebastian held a finger up to her and slowly moved it toward her lips.

"Before you say you can't do that, think: is it true?"

"I... what?" She was genuinely shocked. What kind of a question was this?

"Is it true? Do you have a rule with your husband that says you can't let another man watch you having sex with another man?"

Sabrina narrowed her eyes. She was getting uncomfortable. Flustered. She'd been preying on younger men for so long that she had forgotten what

it was like to not be in total control of a sexual encounter or so much as a flirtatious one. She ignored men her own age and older, and shot them down quickly and humanely, so she could focus on what she wanted: control.

So this question, which was also preposterous, revealed a power imbalance that had long been missing. Far from making her experience one pure, understandable kind of emotion, it muddied the waters.

"I mean," she said, hating that she didn't have a quick reply or pithy comment. "It's never come up, so..."

"So there's no rule against it."

"Not exactly," she said uncertainly. But it felt wrong. She moved her eyes very quickly to scan for an exit, just to reassure herself it was there.

"But...?" Sebastian prompted.

"But nothing. Maybe I don't want to."

This washed over him, making him blink once, deliberately. It sounded as false to him, she could see, as it sounded to her own ears.

So when he said, "I think you do," she was already primed, and the comment stirred inside of her, it hit sensitive things. She was buzzing on the inside, it was sexual, and she could tell herself it was Zader all she wanted, but it was not just Zader making her high.

She shook her head, felt her face crumbling: the assured, haughty expression that had become second nature to her began to fall away, and her features felt out of her control. She made a tisking sound - there was no way he could hear it, though - and shook her head. She shifted her attention to her fingernails. "What do you even want?" she asked him.

Sebastian Grant leaned over his lap and put his elbows on his knees. This movement made him seem younger. His voice was slow, the reverberations

of his whispery touch back at the gallery rose to the surface of her skin. "I want you to fuck a black man - it doesn't have to be Zader Godfrey, but he is right here - and I want to watch you doing it." His fingers brushed over her knee, sending a shockwave through her. "And I want to tell you what to do, and then I want to see you do it."

Her chest was rising and falling with the kind of gulps that made it very obvious and visible. Even if she was able to hide her feelings behind a placid expression, the way her breath expanded her lungs and then caved in, hollow, was telling Sebastian Grant all he needed to know. She was on the hook, wriggling, but unlikely to get away: this excited her.

"I have to run that by my husband," she managed to say. There were long pauses between each word, during which she needed to inhale a ragged breath.

Sebastian's finger went to the back of her hand, tracing a circle with a feathery touch. The sensation might as well have come directly from her clit. She watched his fingers and shuddered inwardly. She was very turned on, but she didn't know by what.

"Why?"

"Why, what?" she said, breath unruly. "I have to."

"But if you *fucked* me, you wouldn't?" he answered, too quickly for her to believe. She felt drunk even though she wasn't. He was right, she supposed, begrudgingly. The answer made no sense when he put it in that light.

"I would have to tell him everything," she told Sebastian.

He moved his head to shake it very slightly. "That's *your* business. I'm just telling you the way I see it: if you have permission to fuck me, or someone else - why can't you let me watch someone else fuck you?"

She had no idea what to say. The party to their right was beginning to break up, and Sabrina was grateful for that: Sebastian Grant wouldn't possibly carry on a conversation like this once people could overhear them. Zader was headed their way. The music was loud, Sabrina felt wild and vaguely out of control.

Sebastian Grant leaned in even further, and as a crescendo of techno beats reached its peak, he shouted in her ear. No one could hear him over the noise but her, but it shocked her nonetheless. "I want you to suck his cock in my car on the way home, while I admire your ass."

And then he sat back, and Sabrina was, for the second time that day and perhaps in her recent memory, left utterly speechless. She stared at him as Zader walked back to their seats, smiled at her, handed her drink to her, sat down with a few other people.

And the whole time, her pussy throbbed.

Chapter Twelve

When they got in the car it was hours later and Sabrina was tipsier than she meant to be. Sebastian had two girls on each arm as they walked out of the club, and they were young.

Sabrina was actually happy about this: if they got in the car with them, it would be an easy out for her: she was into some things but not others, and having some twenty-something women watching her suck a guy's cock was just not in the cards. She hung back, thinking she could easily slip away, feeling a little relieved.

But Sebastian sent them away, and opening the door to an Uber he seemed to have ordered for them. He gave them an address and they seemed happy as pie as they climbed, shrill and screaming into the cab.

"I asked him to do that," Zader told her, facing her suddenly. His hand came out in front of him, in a loose fist, and he moved it toward her body and grazed her pubic mound with the backs of his fingers before trailing his hand up the length of her body to between her breasts, which he was staring at. "I don't need a bunch of dumbass little girls in my face right now," he clarified, so that Sabrina could make no mistake about his intentions.

The car door was open, and somehow Sebastian was already inside. And then Zader was taking her leather jacket off, his fingers brushing over her shoulders. She was stepping into the limo, in her tight dress, aware that she was bending over and Zader was watching her ass. Sebastian was serious, unsmiling, but he met her eyes with lust and a clear happiness shone in them.

Zader was in the car. Then it was moving. Sabrina was draped across half the bench that faced Sebastian (this was no party limo, no rental car - it was his private vehicle and there were only two benches facing each other).

Her mind was racing, part of it wondering what she was doing. It felt like watching a show. At the same time, she knew what she was doing - what she was going to do, even before she did it. She rested an elbow on the back of the seat and set her head in it, stretched her legs out and crossed them, satisfied as the hem of her skirt rode up to nearly her ass.

All the while, the presence of Sebastian Grant loomed over everything, making a kosher taboo situation less kosher, leaving a fine mist of guilt hanging in the air, enhancing the high, amplifying the unease.

She tried to focus on the young man in hand:

Zader was looking at her appreciatively. There were subgroups among young men who slept with older women, this much Sabrina had discovered. Some were less genuinely attracted and trying to unlock an accomplishment, some were vaguely incestuous in their pursuits, some were just playing the entire field of hot women, because YOLO.

She'd come to recognize it all, and Zader was of the other type: men who genuinely liked mature women.

She smiled back at him, ignoring Sebastian as much as she could. He was there, his presence weighty and un-ignorable. She was doing something that

they had never drawn up a plan for, but she knew better than to do it. Somewhere in the back of her mind she was still thinking about leaving it out, lying, never mentioning it to her husband. Guilt was expunged by this dark idea, directly into her veins, but it almost felt good. Was it the source of the adrenaline, the lust between her legs? Who knew? She no longer cared.

"Lotta guys like banging them young hot chicks," Zader was telling her, when she dropped a hand to his knee and let her eyes fall on his crotch. He was welcoming this explicit attention, but he seemed mildly surprised that she was doing it in the car. His eyes moved to Sebastian, who was looking on at it as if he was watching porn by himself.

"But I like a mature woman," Zader continued.

Sabrina looked up at him, repositioned her head in her hand to shake her hair from her face. "Do you," she asked, in a tone that let him know she already knew this.

If anything had really shaken Sabrina's belief system to the core, it was the discovery that a lot of men did in fact like older women more than younger women. Not just as a temporary dating partner, or because of the low drama, or as an easier lay. And not just men who couldn't score younger women, like she'd always believed.

No. Some men - and Zader genuinely seemed to be one of them - liked something else.

She didn't give Zader time to answer. She uncrossed her legs and repositioned herself so that she could put her hand between his legs. Her fingertips went to the mass that was straining against them, and followed the length of it - it was large, running along his thigh. He stopped talking

and watched her fingers, with the sudden concentration of a man who is about to get laid. Full, centered, and unbreakable.

"I guess you do," she said, withdrawing her hand. "Take your pants off."

As she said that, she pushed her dress up to her hips, before rolling onto the floor and turning to face Zader.

He was frozen for a moment, maybe not expecting this level of action to begin so soon. But he began to fumble at his pants, eager to get them out of the way, as soon as her knees hit the floor.

"Whoa, you really movin'" he said, somewhere in the middle of her repositioning. She didn't answer, instead moving her legs and her dress with discrete movements, to ensure that Sebastian Grant, behind her, would have the view he had requested as soon as she bent over to suck on Zader's cock.

Once it was free, she had a moment of fear as it landed against the side of his thigh. Already enormous, it wasn't fully erect - though it was jerking toward full rigidity now that she was staring at it.

Forgetting Sebastian, she reached for the base of it and wrapped all her fingers around it. It was darker, a stranger color than she'd imagined. As it unfurled from the tight fist she barely managed to make around its substantial girth, veins became prominent and rose beneath his skin. It was, as the lore had promised, much bigger than the average.

For a moment she forgot where she was, what she was doing, the many games she was playing, all the balls she was supposed to keep in the air. The muscle flexed in her hand and sent a shudder through her, but she couldn't take her eyes off it. Saliva was welling up in the back of her mouth, under her tongue, as if she could already feel the smooth, clefted head of it against the back of her throat, or feel the ridge of the crown against her palate. But her body was imagining it between her legs as well. How it

would stretch her open, the fullness of having it entirely inside her. And everywhere, Zader's black skin reminded her of the line she was crossing, infusing her blood with a tingle of excitement.

"Baby, don't tease me like that. I know it's pretty, but damn," Zader said.

She looked up at him and was met with the same concentrated lust that had been on his face since she had told him to extract it. Suddenly she was back in the room (vehicle), and formed a mental picture of herself: ass bare except for her black thong, Sebastian Grant viewing it as she bent over the lap of a complete stranger and sucked his cock.

A black stranger.

In a car.

And maybe without her husband's permission. Maybe as a secret - forever.

The idea ran along her spine as guilt and lust.

She closed her lips around the tip of it and sucked the pooling drop of precum that had just begun to well up from the center of his dick. Its bitter taste coated her tongue briefly, before melting away in her mouth. She swept her tongue over the crown, fluttering her eyes up to meet his. His cock swelled in her hand when she did.

Her pussy was so wet now that she knew it must be seeping from her panties to the sides of her thighs. As she enclosed Zader's cock in her mouth and the veins pulsed against her cheeks and tongue with pleasure, the hot liquid between her thighs seemed to spill out like escaped urine. She struggled to get her jaw open enough to send more of his cock into her throat, to try and get to the base, and if not the base, then her own fingers where she was still gripping the root of his dick.

His hand came to the back of her head but he didn't press down. "Mmm," he growled. "Oh, shit, baby," he added. He shifted in the seat as she

continued to suck on him. Her jaw was getting sore but she didn't care: thoughts, guilt, discomfort - they were all pushed away by the response of Zader's cock in her mouth. The promises it held for her between her legs. She even forgot about Sebastian Grant, watching her from behind, and all that Sebastian Grant's presence implied.

Zader's abdomen was beginning to tense up in spastic waves, a sure sign that he was going to come. His fingers tightened in her hair and slowed her sucking by gripping the roots. "I'm about to come," he told her earnestly. He tugged on her hair, pulling her hair up gently, a hand dropping to her shoulder. He was trying to get her mouth off his cock, to climb up on him, probably.

Her body trembled and the ache between her legs reached a crescendo: she had never wanted to fuck somebody as much as she did in that moment. His salty precum was practically spilling into her mouth, leaving a briny taste smeared at the back of her throat. She could easily imagine - and she did - that same cum exploding inside of her, the silken crown of the dick in her mouth snug against her cervix when it did. There would be a mild, bruising discomfort deep within, the stretched tightness in her pussy, suddenly awash in hot semen that would burst at the same time as her own orgasm...

So why was she gripping his cock still, panting with an inch of it still in her open mouth. Why was she looking up at Zader through her dark lashes as she flicked her tongue at it. Why was she saying, "I want you to come in my mouth"?

The answer was sitting behind her, and she knew it. If she'd been alone with Zader she'd have ridden on his lap and gotten his cum banged into her. If it was only him.

It wasn't like Zader objected. He went silent when she went back to work on him, and it didn't take long for her to suck the cum from inside him. His veins gushed against her skin, a spasm of muscle told her it was coming, and she let the bitter liquid gush into her mouth and fill it. She closed her throat to keep it there, and once he'd squirted the largest load, she tipped her head back and pulled her mouth from him, letting the remaining squirts fall in ropes onto her face. One particularly messy splurge landed across her forehead and her cheek, and fell into her eyelashes. She made sure to jerk the last drops onto her face and her neck, her eyes on his. Then she neatly folded herself up and sat on the seat next to him as he panted, open-mouthed, eyes vacant as he stared at his cock.

She wasn't paying much attention to Zader now. The intense need between her legs drowned almost everything out, and also her mouth was full of cum.

Like she was watching a show, and also like she already knew she would do this, she opened her mouth while staring at Sebastian Grant, so he could see the creamy contents nestled in her throat, before she snapped her smiling mouth shut and swallowed it.

He smiled.

She turned to Zader, who was panting, his dick semi-hard and leaning against one thigh as he stared at it. He turned to her as she rotated to her side, placing her head in her hand and fluffing her hair a little.

"Dang, girl, I...."

Zader Godfrey may have had something to say, but he failed to finish his sentence. Possibly because Sabrina wiped the cum from her face in sensual movements with her middle finger, and then sucked the liquid into her mouth.

"We're nearly there," Sebastian Grant said, after watching this with no change in expression as far as Sabrina could tell. She was looking at Zader, her pussy was throbbing, and her peripheral vision was all she had to rely on.

There was no mistake, though. Even if she was looking at Zader, even if her pussy throbbed with desire for his cock to be inside her... she was sucking cum from her fingertips for an audience of one at the moment.

And that one was not Zader Godfrey.

Why?

They were just blocks away from the Hilton. Sebastian got out when the door was opened for him, and Sabrina started to, but Zader's hand caught her thigh as she started to climb out. She looked down to see his youthful hand wrapped around her white skin, felt the inherent strength of it against her thigh muscle, and her pussy throbbed again.

Insistent in his grip, he pushed her back down to the seat and moved in to kiss her. His lips were full, and they seemed to be everywhere. It was not difficult to imagine the sensation of his busy, aggressive tongue in other places on her body.

"I gotta go to this after-party," he said, his hand working its way down her ribcage, under the jacket she'd put back on once she knew they were stopping. Swiftly, he was under her skirt, fingers seeking her pussy. The driver glanced in and very slowly and discretely pushed the door to nearly closed, his back to them.

Zader's big lips were on her ear now. "You gonna stick around," he said, and this wasn't really a question. "'Cause I want to fuck you... feels like you want that, too." He had just reached her panties, felt the wetness that seeped into the material. One finger wriggled beneath the fabric and into the swollen, aching, slippery flesh that her pussy had become. He smiled when he felt her hardened clit pulse, and a shudder she couldn't subdue enough traveled through her body.

His eyes went to the window. Outside the car, people were clustering, loitering, loosely coming together like any drunk group on its way to an uncertain party. Young girls giggled like chirping birds, someone yelled, no one was really paying attention to anything but themselves or who they wanted to fuck. She didn't know - or care - where Sebastian Grant had gone. Zader's finger was inside her, and then a second, and then he was bending them toward the root of her clit, searching for her g-spot, his thumb pressing on the nub of her clit.

He smiled. "You're so wet. You like sucking cock? Hmm? It got you hot?" He looked down her body. "Let me return the favor."

Another glance outside. Sebastian Grant was standing by the entrance to the hotel, looking displeased and pleased at once. Her pussy spasmed around Zader's fingers. She was so close to coming that it made her feel like she'd hit her head - part of her mind spun one way and the other was tingly and distant from her, a painful dizziness was gathering in her temples and she could hear her blood rushing in her ears as her heart pounded.

She stared at Zader's face, pushed one hand up to the dividing glass between the driver and the back compartment to brace herself, and struggled to think of a way to claw back the control she wanted to have.

She slapped a hand to his wrist and encircled it forcefully. Her voice came out in a whispery and staggering breath as she moved his hand to position his fingers just at her g-spot. "Curl out," she commanded. She pushed his thumb into her clit. "There. Make me come. Do it fast."

He did, and it took almost no time but it seemed like an eternity. A molten heat built up all over her body, she sweat beneath the leather coat, rigid with concentration until he found his rhythm and easily made the dam burst inside of her.

The sweat turned cold as ice suddenly. She felt like she'd been slapped across the face after the first wave shook her. She smiled at him, pushed him away, straightened her jacket, and pushed gently against the door after running her fingers through her hair.

When she stepped out of the limo the scene entered her eyes in jagged movements, like a montage from an old art film. The driver gave her a brief nod, his face composed into a look of steady, professional disinterest, but a reddish tint stained his cheeks and a glimmer was in his eyes.

He knew what happened in the back of his car.

The younger girls were mostly busy with themselves, but a few turned to the opening door with interest - almost certainly in Zader - and then their eyes glowed with a very specific kind of female jealousy. Sabrina felt a smile on her face, an extreme high, and there was way more to it than just the orgasm Zader had given her.

Cold sweat rolled from her neck to her spine, traveling the route a mischievous lover would take with his tongue. Sebastian with his eyebrows raised by the revolving door, his lips in a smile of pleasure and displeasure, impressed and disappointed - all of it a further intoxicant. Her thighs were slippery against each other. She stopped, turned to the car, and saw Zader

getting out behind her. He was composed, but unable to take the smile off his lips or the lust from his face.

She twisted her mouth into an impish pucker and winked at him before stalking right past them all to the revolving door. The message she wanted to send to Zader is that she didn't expect him to hold her hand, she didn't give a shit if he went right into that circle of young girls and started fucking them on the street.

Sebastian, his smile unreadable, stepped out of her way and held a hand out in the gesture of a doorman. She glided right in, head held high, and then realized she didn't know where to go or what the plan was. A gust of reality, cold and brutal, seemed to sweep in from outside.

What the *fuck* was she even doing?

She spotted a sign for the lobby restrooms. She'd been in this building at least half a dozen times. Turning as she walked, pleased with a brief reflection she'd seen of herself in a mirror, she gestured at Sebastian with a thumb toward the bathrooms. She completed her turn, still walking, and headed to the restroom corridor.

She had seen herself throwing cold water on her face, straightening her hair, wiping away some of the viscous juices oozing down her thighs. She didn't need to pee, and her pussy was still wriggling away with the remnants of her orgasm. She wouldn't have been able to, anyway.

She turned the corner and put a hand to the cold marble when an attack of vertigo came over her. Her mind stubbornly produced images of Zader's cock that floated into her field of vision and made the ache between her legs return. And then Sebastian, his presence at her back, the feeling of his eyes on her. The shift of power was like being on a boat in the sea: she felt

unsteady, sick. She was drunker than she wanted to be. The high from the limo and the fingering and the triumphant walk into the hotel collapsed.

At the end of the corridor was another turn, and there a set of stairs that led to an overhead walkway that almost nobody knew how to get to and nearly nobody used. It led to a mall with a subway stop beneath it, and an exit two blocks from here and the opposite side of the building, and that's where she was headed.

She paused by the bathroom door, put her hand to it, stood whirling, untethered in the universe for a moment, pulled in ten directions.

And then she walked determinedly past it, up the stairs, almost running across the glass walkway over Sixth Avenue, a turn, another turn, a wrong turn, a locked door. Panic of no discernible origin rose in her blood for a moment. She found the exit, went into the darkened and largely closed mall, down another escalator, in the direction of the subway station, and then out a door before she had intended, because she felt claustrophobic.

A cab, something she hadn't done in along time. All the while thinking of Graham, what she tell him, how she would explain.

Could she assemble this into a story he would like?

Could she find a way to explain Sebastian Grant, to tell on herself for what she had done?

But for what? Thoughts? Everything she'd actually done had been above-board, provided that she told Graham about it all.

How would she explain leaving?

And then, a thought reared its head like a monster in dark waters, and she lingered on it only for a moment before it frightened her and guilt seeped in through every pore of her body. Dirty, shameful guilt with a terrible twist: it made an erotic heat tingle beneath every layer of her skin:

She didn't really *want* to tell Graham about any of this.

"Thanks," she said, as the cabbie pulled up at the Hilton. She tossed a fifty - it was all she had - at him and climbed out of the cab: he had interest in his eyes, thinking she was an escort.

She was at the Hilton so often it might have looked that way to him: she skipped out with her skimpy skirt and leather jacket on, a doorman waved at her and she gave him a cute wave back. Her head was whirling. She still didn't know what she was going to do.

And then, emerging from the revolving doors: thick white t-shirt, no beard, short hair, expensive jeans. A young guy, cigarette between his lips, a box in hand. His eyes locked on her as soon as she saw him. She stopped in front of the door.

"Oh thank fuck," she said breathlessly, and he stopped in front of her, the kind of guy who was cocky and had no trouble getting women, because he was good-looking. But she could see a woman like her had never planted herself in his path this way.

Her eyes went to the cigarettes. "I need one of those *really* bad."

He looked down at the box, then back at her. Opened it, shook the cigarettes forward so she could take one. His eyes were partially squinted in confusion, the cigarette still between his lips.

She took a cigarette and smiled. "I need a light, too."

He stared. Behind him, someone else was coming out of the door, and the doorman was inching over to tell them to move. She waved him off and took the cigarette boy by the elbow, a reckless plan forming in her mind. "Smoke with me?" she said.

Maybe because she smelled like sex, because she looked like a high-class hooker, because she was stunningly beautiful, because she was so much

older than him - who knew? But that was all it took.

They smoked their first cigarette in silence until the near end. He offered her the box again.

"Can I ask you something?" he asked, finally.

She ashed and blew a stream of smoke at him. "No."

"O-kay," he began, raising his eyebrows.

"Would you be interested in going upstairs with me and having sex while my husband watches?"

The words were out of her mouth before she could filter them. He was stunned, but agreeing before she even had time to think it through - why she had asked, what she planned to do, why she planned to do it. The secrets she wanted to divulge and at the same time keep boiled in her lower abdomen, and some fanciful idea in her head told her she could just change the whole evening and brush it away with this simple act.

After all... what if Graham just never asked?

And she never told, and she never saw Sebastian Grant or Zader Godfrey again?

Like any reasonable man before a hot woman offering free sex, the guy was startled for a moment and then agreed. They smoked their second cigarettes and she shifted her head to tell him to go in, and then strode confidently into the hotel without looking back.

If he followed her, he followed her, and it was going to be what it was going to be.

Chapter Thirteen

He waited, patiently, for Sabrina to start the story about the night before. They made love, and it was wet and delicious, and then she fell asleep. It didn't bother him: Sabrina often did this after an especially eventful night. Graham could only conclude that the night had been eventful, because she had begun by chasing one man, and ended up with another.

All through the wild ups and downs of this lifestyle - the beginnings of it, when it was awkward and difficult to talk about. The highs, the lows... Graham had always been able to depend on Sabrina eventually telling him everything. All he had to do was be patient.

Sabrina's phone began buzzing wildly in what seemed like the middle of the night. She sat up, fully awake, very suddenly, and jumped out of bed. Checking her phone, stark naked next to the window with its open blinds, she was beautiful in the glow of the phone light.

"Shit. Oh, shit, shit... I forgot to set an alarm!"

She rushed around, taking the phone with her into the bathroom, while Graham rubbed the sleep from his eyes and reclined on the pillows to watch

her flutter in mild panic.

"I can't believe I did this..." Sabrina muttered, coming through the room. She put her hand to her head in distress and whirled around. "Oh no," she said, her face going pale.

"What's up?" Graham asked, not too loudly. Sabrina didn't usually want to explain this kind of thing, she got very impatient when he asked. But it was damn hard not to ask a frantic woman what was wrong.

Sabrina was fetching things from the floor and muttering. "I just... oh my god, all my clothes are in the car..."

"Where's the car? I'll go get it for you."

Sabrina sighed and stood up, frantically pulling the dress down over her bare torso. "I can't find my underwear," she complained.

Graham sat up. "Sweetie, just tell me where -"

"No. God. It's too far. Look... I'll just... I'll get some out of my suitcase before I go in." Her phone was ringing again. "God. It's 4:30! I was supposed to be there at four!" She sighed and looked around again. "Ugh. I have to go," she complained, and snatched her purse from the floor. She rummaged through it as she headed to the door, and Graham was stunned and certain that she'd just walk out.

She stopped and rushed back to him. Her eyes were wild, she seemed jittery. She kissed him quickly, and seemed to add as an afterthought only: "I love you. That was hot. I gotta run."

"When are you gonna tell me what happened?" he called out, in a sing-song voice.

But Sabrina didn't do what she normally would have done and toss back a joke at him. She sounded annoyed and the door banged like she was struggling to get through it - probably still looking for something in her

purse. "I don't - not now, later," she rambled, in a hurry and clearly not really thinking about his question.

And then she was gone.

Graham was exhausted and definitely thankful that *he* had seven more hours left in the hotel room. He closed his eyes, began thinking about his sexual adventures with his wife in the past 24 hours, and dozed off with a semi-hard cock.

By the time she got into the bathroom, Sabrina knew she really didn't have to hurry as much as she originally thought. The dependable Alicia was already on the case, already at the convention center, and everything was going according to plan. Her texts had begun frantically (WHERE ARE U), but one text from Sabrina to confirm she wasn't dead was all she'd needed. She simmered down to informational statements that all was under control.

At least that's what Sabrina hoped: Alicia had an extremely young, online vocab via texts, so she had to guess sometimes. Fairly confident that "clutch" was positive, she was almost 100% certain she didn't need to rush.

But in the bathroom, once the emergency was under control, she experienced full recall of the night before. Rather than face the challenge of explaining what had happened last night to Graham, she opted to continue feigning being in a huge hurry.

She needed time to think.

There was nothing really wrong with anything she'd done last night - provided that she tell Graham what it was. He'd been right there in the room

(and very pleased with what he saw, if his enduring and rigid erection was anything to go by), so the guy she'd taken upstairs was not a huge issue.

Or, he wouldn't have been, if not for the fact that she would need to explain why that was the guy she'd shown up with, and not Zader.

In order to tell that story, though, she'd have to come clean about giving Zader a blowjob in Sebastian Grant's limo. Having done that wasn't a big deal, either, as long as she told Graham about it. But in order to tell Graham about it, she'd have to tell Graham about Sebastian Grant.

And for some reason, some very peculiar reason she could only see in the periphery of her mind's eye, she didn't want to do that. It weighed on her all day. Why? Why didn't she just tell Graham about Sebastian Grant and the things he said to her, and the perverse thrill it gave her?

One element was obviously related to her own thrill, which she sensed would somehow be ruined by telling the story. The other was related to protecting Graham's feelings: no matter what he said, she was sure he'd be hurt that another man saw her suck off a black guy before he himself did.

She knew he had his fantasies about it. It was all there in his porn choices.

She managed to get to work and smooth things over with Alicia, who seemed to be very happy that she'd had to run the show until her irresponsible boss arrived late. Alicia didn't ask any follow-up questions, and by the afternoon, Sabrina couldn't even remember what bland story she'd told her.

What she couldn't do all day was extract herself from the conflicts raging inside of her. It was too late to go back in time and make a better choice, and she realized this. The solution was to tell Graham everything, and she knew this as well.

It was always the solution.

The cover-up was always worse than the crime.

Graham would just be more hurt if she kept a secret from him.

But, like a lot of people, Sabrina also knew she was too much of a wuss to inflict that pain on Graham - even if it was the right thing to do. And there was the tantalizing, glittering, holy grail of all unfaithful activity:

Maybe he wouldn't find out.

But what kind of explanation was she supposed to give for coming home with a different guy? One chosen so recklessly? That was the puzzle, and that was the part of the problem that she worked the hardest on in the back of her mind. Running around, working, but always looking for a magic bullet: one that would spare Graham the details involving Sebastian, give him the details about Zader, and also explain the decidedly non-black man she'd brought home.

Thinking, thinking, thinking. Creating a lie. All day long. It felt terrible, but the alternatives must have felt worse to her. Because she still hadn't decided what to do by the time she was driving home. Or walking through the door. Or gently calling out for Graham.

She went home. In the upstairs hallway, she heard the running water of the shower, and she resolved to tell him. Everything.

It twisted in her guts, cold and awful, but she was already picturing herself getting into the shower with him, soaping him up, seducing him a little, and with her lips just inches from his cock, unloading all the secrets.

Most men seemed amenable to apologetic summaries if they were delivered in a whispery voice, the air from her lungs blowing over their turgid flesh.

But once she was in the master bedroom, she could see the shower reflection in the mirror. Graham had a hand on the tiles and the other was

pumping his cock.

She stepped back, and retreated, walking backwards, slightly stunned. A big reason for this choice of lifestyle had to do with Graham aging, not being able to perform like the old days. But last night he'd been rock-solid, and he seemed to be there now, as well.

Her plans were blown to smithereens: a chance to have sex with her husband again, so soon after the last time, was appealing to her. It was, or at least it had been, the main reason she did any of this.

"Hey?!" she yelled, very loudly, walking toward the room again. "Are you here?"

When she went into the bathroom, Graham was under the shower with his head completely drenched, rubbing his face with both hands. His cock, fully erect, throbbed in front of him.

"He-llo," Sabrina said, staring at it.

She peeled her clothes away, including a trashy pair of thong underwear she'd had to buy at nine am from a dollar store a few blocks from the convention center. The underwear she'd packed didn't work with her dress, and after wearing the same dress all morning, she wasn't about to change it and call anyone's attention to the fact she had worn it the night before. They could *think* what they wanted, but she wouldn't have anyone believing she cared.

Graham was wiping water from his face, his eyes open, when she stepped into the shower. She looked at his cock. "Happy to see me?" she asked, playfully. She reached for it and gripped it firmly in her hand. Graham did not, of course, do anything to put a stop to this.

She put her hands on his chest and kissed him. Who could say what was the exact blend of thoughts in her head? Some of it was purely Graham,

ready to go at a moment's notice. A lot of it was elsewhere: the wrongness of what she had done and planned to do and maybe wouldn't do was titillating, the memory of Zader's cock was titillating. Even Sebastian Grant watching her from behind was.

Her intentions had been to fall to her knees and take Graham's cock in her mouth. She turned off the water and dropped to her knees, seizing his dick by the fist and guiding it to her mouth.

She had every intention of purring into his damp skin:

"Do you want me to tell you about last night?"

She brought his cock to her lips, her mouth open, and the words were there at the tip of her tongue. A fleeting hesitation tripped her up. In that brief moment, a pearl of precum oozed from Graham's cock, and his shaft pulsed in her fist.

She looked up at him. He wasn't going to make it through a story like that.

So she smiled, wickedly, and when his cock pulsed again, she knew that Graham would rather hear it all later, so she opened her mouth and drew him inside her. With her eyes on his, it took under a minute to fill her mouth his cum, his hand clamped to the back of her head and his face twisted in feverish desire.

"I really do want to hear about last night," he joked, as he toweled off in the bedroom. Sabrina had interrupted him masturbating, so he was glad she'd been smart enough to get down to business. He was grateful she hadn't caught him, either: it would be pretty hard to explain to her what it was about last night (the feeling that something untoward had occurred) that had

driven his urge to masturbate. The fantasies that were in his head when he did so - a jumble of feelings he couldn't understand - had still been fresh in his head when Sabrina had entered the shower like a fantasy woman and fallen to her knees to suck his cock.

And now his dick was revving up again, because he'd come in her mouth abruptly, and she'd swallowed it... or so he thought. Then, smiling, she'd stood up. She had that look in her eye: mischievous, hotter than usual. He'd pushed her against the tile wall and slipped his fingers into her pussy - just after noticing that her pussy lips were still reddened and swollen.

He was looking at her as he did this, his fingers gliding in her buttery wetness. Sabrina was still smiling strangely. And then she opened her mouth, and he watched her tongue play with a wad of creamy liquid for several beats without understanding what it was.

He fingered her, and then fucked her with his hand, and made her come in no time at all, once she swallowed his cum.

All the while thinking of his own fantasies, fueled by the wetness of her pussy. Surely just falling to her knees to suck her husband off in her own shower hadn't made her so wet. Surely not the thing that had driven *him* wild - the cum-play. So what, then?

Sabrina continued to shower. His cock continued, against all odds, to harden. His abdomen roiled with cold fear and jealousy and arousal, his mind swam with unfamiliar titillations. All of it was so sexual he couldn't put any of it into a coherent thought, other than slowly firming plans to fuck Sabrina again when she came out.

He fumbled for the remote to the TV: he was fifty now, he couldn't be fucking anyone or anything this many times in a row, it would almost certainly end in disappointment. For him - not Sabrina.

He came across her phone like that. It had fallen out of her tipped-over purse, and the screen was black when he picked it up. He didn't go *looking* for anything. In fact, if chance had played out differently, he would have just set it on the night table and gone on with looking for the remote.

But.

But.

As the fates would have it, a number - no contact name entered - sent a text at that exact moment. Sabrina's phone was not a scion of security: she used a simple code to unlock it, she had previews of all of her texts.

I'm very disappointed

was followed by an attachment. That was all he saw, and he was already reaching across to the night table when he glanced at it. The shower stopped, the door opened, and Sabrina appeared in the mirror, toweling only her wet hair. So he set it on the table and looked at her instead.

But inside his mind, the intrigue brewed with what was already there, and he began, for the first time in a very long time, to form suspicions about his wife.

Graham was of the opinion that any man who tells you he trusts his wife completely and never suspects her of anything sexually out-of-bounds was a flat-out liar. It was more about how willing a man was to live by a code of trust and push those suspicions to the back of his mind. Maybe a man could be trusted, because men didn't have as many sexual opportunities banging down the door. Men didn't have men after them. And Graham was an adult: he knew not every exchange between Sabrina and her lovers was perfectly above-board, not every feeling or insinuation made its way to him.

But with their relationship being it what it was, he did by and large trust that he heard about everything. At least a little bit.

And this text did not seem like something Sabrina had explained, or would explain. It reeked of secrets and games.

Didn't it? Maybe it was just a text about a bad cake or event decor that was terrible.

He looked at Sabrina, who was approaching him now, smiling her seductive smile.

"I want to hear about last night," he said. *I'm very disappointed.* That was it, that was all there was to the text. Inside, he burned with curiosity and the aftertaste of jealousy. Maybe it was innocuous. Maybe it was something she'd tell him about now. Maybe it was a secret. It was slippery and taboo in his thoughts: he was violating her trust even thinking about it, and yet he couldn't stop.

And then there was the flutter across her face. Briefly she paled, and looked stricken. She did not look at the phone, and she recovered quickly. Maybe it was all in his imagination.

"Last night?" she asked. She sat down on the bed and smiled at him. She turned to face away, toward the bathroom.

And didn't say anything else. She turned her hair upside down to dry it in some special way she had for her big, natural waves.

"Well, yeah," he said, maintaining a friendly, carefree tone as much as possible. Inwardly, he tried to tame the weird excitement he felt, the mistrust, the paranoia that he was drinking in. "You said you were headed with one guy, and then you came home with..."

Sabrina tossed her hair back and sat up. Facing the mirror in the bathroom and looking at her own reflection with some pleasure, she grinned. "And I

came home with an entirely different color of guy?"

She turned to him. Graham's attention was newly - and maybe for the first time - drawn to her expressions, her eyes, even though she was naked and gorgeous. Her skin was still damp. Beneath the smell of soap he could still smell her pussy, and he wondered if that was because she was so wet, and then if that was because of... whatever this was.

It briefly flitted through his head to ask her about the text, to mention it. He felt like, if he delivered it right, he could just explain how he saw it and make it lighthearted. For a moment he was poised to do it.

Sabrina, though, looked down at his chest and off to the side - sheepishly, you might say - as she put a solemn hand on his chest. "Okay, look... I have to tell you something about last night. I just... didn't want to break up the mood." She smiled at him hopefully, lifting her eyes. "Because it was kind of fun."

He sat up straight and pushed a pillow behind his back to let her know he was listening attentively. The tone had changed, and he didn't know what to make of it, but she did seem to be confessing something. Maybe it would all get cleared up.

She looked at the ceiling. "Heh... okay, so... that artist, the uh..."

"Black guy?"

She smiled and nodded. "Well, yeah, okay, the black guy. Um... as you know..." she curled up a little bit, sweetly, lifting her legs to turn and face him on the bed. She played with her feet and took on a childlike manner that was not typical of her. "I have never slept with a, um... black guy."

"I do know this," he said agreeably. Whatever thoughts had been brewing in his head had been set free to soar away to Fiji for all he knew: she was

talking about sex with a black guy and so she was talking his fantasy. His cock was rock hard.

Sabrina noticed this - her eyes shifted to the left and then discretely back, with a knowing look in them. Her lips fluttered through a number of possible emotions, she tucked her hair behind her ear even though it was wet and not falling forward. She looked vacantly at his chest and her mouth settled at last on a shy smile.

"So, I went to - or I was going to - a party with this guy. You know, thinking, this would be the night. And I, um... got into a situation with him, which I'll tell you about, but I *didn't* tell you about when I got back, because, uh, well... I freaked out and I just like, jumped ship. So it wasn't really... a great story."

Her cheeks grew red. Her face gave every indication that she was telling some uncomfortable truth.

"You freaked out?" he said. Kindly. But also with a hint of laughter.

Sabrina looked up at the ceiling and held her hands out. "I don't know!" she laughed. "Something like that... I just, you know, decided I didn't want to go up to the party, or something. And I just ran away, and then I felt like, a little bit stupid, and I was thinking how the hell I was going to tell you the story and explain myself, and then I got here and that guy was walking out the doors with some cigarettes and he was good-looking, and so I just kind of panicked and picked him up." She twisted an arm and leaned on it. Blinked shyly, smiled at him.

"Okay, well... are you going to tell me the story now?"

"About what?" She batted her eyes and feigned innocence, and then moved seductively. There was something about this reaction that seemed "off" to Graham: they had just done their thing in the shower, she knew he

wouldn't be ready for another round if things went like they always did. It wasn't like her *not* to keep a story tucked away for future fun.

But then again, it wasn't like him to ask for it at a time when he was so unlikely to have said fun as a reward.

"What happened with the black guy?" he asked. When the words formed in his mind, he had meant them as an answer to her question: about what? *About what happened with the black guy.*

But his mouth had turned the statement into a question, and it sounded more like interrogation, to boot.

Sabrina's alluring features briefly looked taken aback. She opened her mouth, looking a little shocked. "I..." she began. Then she closed her mouth, walked her hands all over his chest and downward, flirting with his cock but never touching it, watching it twitch, as impressed as Graham was that it was hard.

Her eyes went back to his. "I gave him a blow job in the limo," she said.

The memory of the shower, of her open mouth and the glob of cum that she rolled expertly with her tongue, flashed through Graham's mind. His cock reacted accordingly, flexing. Sabrina noted this without looking at it, a smile on her lips.

"Did you swallow?"

She nodded, grinning, biting her lower lip. She stretched out, leaving her hands on his chest, extending her lower body on the bed after climbing up on it, moving down, looking for all the world like she was planning to give him another blowjob.

Which, impressively, he seemed to be up for (literally).

She purred when her neck hovered just above his cock, and then winked, turned her body, pushed away, and escaped from his hands like sand. "I

want to save the story for when you're more... fresh," she said.

This only made him harder, more convinced that he could perform again.

"Wait a minute," he called out, as she giggled and disappeared into the closet. She was naked, hot, still damp, and he could smell that she was turned on. His voice sounded lighthearted but he really wasn't: he wanted very much to fuck her now. Hard.

She was still in the closet, and from the clacking of hangers, it seemed like she was picking out something to wear.

"So you sucked this guy's cock," he said, and the words clanged around in his lowest abdomen as cool erotic pulses, "and then you just... hopped out and blew him off?"

"I'm saving the story," she complained.

"I don't want you to save the story," he responded, causing her to peek her head out and check. She raised her eyebrows when she saw his erection.

"I'm so *sore*," she told him, pulling a tight shirt over her breasts without a bra on.

"Take that off," he said.

His voice was serious. She paused tugging on the shirt and looked at him, and her mouth failed to settle on an expression.

She ended up on a pouty, teasing, fake defiance. "No," she retorted.

"Yes."

She leaned on the dresser and grinned, shaking her head. But he could see that she was giving in.

"Check your phone," he told her. "I think you got a message from this guy."

Alarm flashed wildly across her face, and he quickly held his hands up. "Look, it just popped up there and I saw it, I promise, see for yourself. It

says 'I'm very disappointed.' I didn't open it. But I assume that's him? Your guy? It has a picture attached -"

Somewhere around the time that he said *see for yourself*, Sabrina made a beeline for her phone. When he mentioned the picture, she became visibly shaken and opened her phone as fast as she could.

The spell of seduction was severed completely as she took in what was on the phone.

Graham could read her face clearly and whatever she saw was not fueling any arousal. Instead, she looked afraid, going pale and letting her lips part haphazardly. Her fingers moved rapidly over the screen, she muttered "shit," and then swept some more.

Put the phone down.

Looked at him, the last remnants of her scared look still clinging to her features.

"What was it?" he asked.

She changed tack, began to crawl towards him, smiling. "It was that, silly."

"Mmm," he said, because she was climbing onto his lap. "I meant... what was the photo..?" His hands were on her smooth, supple thighs because she was straddling him, and his thoughts were funneling into single-minded determination.

She peeled off her shirt and her tits swung and bounced. She still had underwear on, but that never stopped Sabrina - she pulled it aside and fucked with it on, and he had a fun technique of grabbing the fabric by one hip and pulling it taut so that it rubbed against her clit. He reached for that now, pulling hard on it.

She gasped as the fabric stretched and then formed a rope of twisted lace, and sank into her wet pussy lips.

"It was probably... just... a picture of my... oh, mmm..." she rocked on his pelvis, the wetness of her pussy dripping onto his pubic bone. His cock was hard against the crack of her ass, into which slippery female cum had seeped. As she rocked on him, the flesh of her ass enclosed the topside of his shaft and stroked him.

"Of...? Can I see it?"

She shook her head. "It was corrupted or something."

This was obviously and blatantly untrue, and he knew it as soon as she said it. A knife of intense, testosterone-generating fury stabbed him in the chest, but since he was already half fucking, it was commandeered as sexual energy. He seized her by the hips, sat up, and threw her on the bed on her back. She was surprised - but pleasantly so, he could see - and stunned, so he took advantage of that to press her wrists into the mattress after pulling her panties down to her knees and tearing one side of the fabric.

"What was it before it was corrupted?" he growled.

"I don't -"

"You don't remember him taking a picture?"

She smiled. "I mean, it was me sucking his cock," she said.

He pushed against her and sat back on his knees for a moment, tossing her legs open, filled with the kind of lusty thirst for dominance that he had assumed had been left behind in his early forties, never to return again.

"So you sucked his cock," he said, guiding the tip of his dick to the squishy petals of her pussy and finding the hard nub of her swollen clit.

"And then what? I want to hear the story."

She glanced at his dick.

They shared a moment of white-hot, simmering *something*. Something that they hadn't ever shared before. Her lips moved as something else seemed to play out in her eyes, and it was impossible to know what emotion she would land on. But there was a secret embedded in it all, somewhere.

Her hips ever-so-slightly lifted from the bed and she rubbed herself against him. The crown of his dick passed over her clit and made her limbs tremble. Once, twice, and then he dipped himself lower on her body so that the next time, her cunt enveloped the tip of his dick.

The heat of her pussy, the insane wetness of it, and the silky mouth of pussy flesh sucking at his dripping dick overwhelmed him.

He thrust inside her and she arched her back and let out a mewl, and from that moment they just fucked. Hard, and like they had never fucked before. No special tricks, no tangible physical action was any different.

Just whatever it was that sizzled between them in their eyes: the unknown secret, the untold story, and the vague air of something out-of-bounds. It fueled his fucking; he slammed into her almost like a revenge for thing he couldn't be certain had happened.

He could never be sure about a woman's orgasm: what part of it was real and what part "enhanced." But if Sabrina was acting, she was a brilliant actress, and her pussy was in on the act. As for himself, there was no lying: it was his second orgasm in fewer hours at his age, and that wasn't an everyday occurrence.

Panting, face up, Sabrina looked stunned, stretched out next to him.

"Wow," he said.

Sabrina's response was delayed. Then she turned her head to him. "I have to tell you -"

He grabbed her head and pulled her face close to his, kissing her to quiet her.

"Save it," he said. He smiled. "No sense wasting it."

She did not look pleased with this instruction. The displeasure registered in her eyes, and then washed over her features for a moment. Her mouth opened and she sucked some air into her throat, like she was going to protest.

He cupped her jawbone and kissed her. "Tell me later."

Her eyelids grew heavy and she closed her eyes. "I *am* pretty tired," she said, smiling. A yawn overtook her. "That was a long day."

He kissed her forehead. "Take a nap. I'll go do something... quietly."

She nodded, eyes still closed, and then appeared to be dozing off.

He got up, found some clothing, and put it on, all while Sabrina remained blissfully sleeping.

He crept out and closed the door, turning the handle carefully to keep it from making a loud click. It was still on the handle, holding the pin retracted, when he saw movement in the final moments of closing the door, or maybe shadows on the floor.

An intense feeling filled his veins and made his heart pound. He stared at his hand, at the closed door, and for a moment he was in a limbo.

He pushed the door open as slowly as he could, until a sliver of Sabrina was visible in the reflection of a dresser mirror. Movement, as she turned, and with a little more of an opening, a slice of her hand on a flat black object. Her eyes, looking closed, but actually open, and her head propped up against a pillow.

And then her hand emerged and slid the phone onto the night table again, and he froze and held his breath. He stood there for a long time, listening

for the rustle of the sheets and scanning for any movement from the pile of sage green on the bed that he could see a sliver of.

His blood was boiling when at last he pulled the door gently closed again, and a cramp began to pain him in his wrist and his lower back as he released the handle very, very slowly to close the door. He was bent over as he stepped away, also slowly.

There was a secret on Sabrina's phone, in Sabrina's mind. She was keeping it from him. There could be no doubt of this: it all added up that way.

Maybe she had really been planning to tell him just then. He, after all, had cut her off.

As he strolled down the hallway, though, and then into the kitchen, he felt like he was soaring. The lusty ache in his balls was returning, an enthusiasm building. He felt... *competitive*, the old thrill of trying to best another man awakening from a dead slumber. But not just that. The feeling was cold and raw, exhilarating, and definitely arousal.

Chapter Fourteen

Sabrina heard the soft thud of the door being very quietly closed, and she waited as long as she could stand it before slipping her hand out from under the covers and sliding her phone to herself. Her heart was pounding again, and sweat gathering at her neck and behind her knees. Guilt had her stomach twisted in knots.

She could tell herself anything she wanted to: it wasn't as if she had lied about anything *important*. She had told her husband about the sexual contact she'd had. What would he care, and how would he even know, that Sebastian Grant was there? She didn't even know what that meant to *her*.

But she *had* lied now. Officially. The photo was not corrupted.

She swept through her messages and her downloads and assured herself again that her deletion of the picture was complete. As complete as she knew how to make it, though she was sure there was probably a catch, a way for the photo to be retrieved by Graham, and she had no idea how to ensure that it couldn't.

More disturbingly, Sebastian Grant had the photo on his phone, and there was no fixing that.

And there was no way to explain that photo, that very obvious picture of herself, except to tell the truth. It was taken from behind and showed her ass and her head in the lap of Zader Godfrey. Turned to the side a little, his big black dick spreading her lips to a thin red line and forcing her jaw wide open.

No explaining away how it was taken: seated, male legs appeared in the lower portion of the photo.

I'm very disappointed.

That was all he'd written. She deleted the message, deleted the record of the calls and texts, and deleted the photo. She was now infuriated with herself because she didn't have the number to block, but she could do that later, after finding his card.

She had lied, and as soon as she did, she saw that Graham had not completely trusted her.

Less explicably, the sex had been fucking amazing.

This whole thing had come about five years earlier because they had been looking for ways to deal with his lessened performance abilities. The fantasy had always been there, lurking in his mind, but he had believed Sabrina wouldn't have been into it. And he was right: there was a time when it would have been unthinkable. But in her forties, with her husband's performance flagging, the idea had pulled her in.

And now here they were. She had lied to Graham and he seemed to know something was up, but his cock had been hard as a rock and whatever had gone on between them in that moment before he rammed her had been scorching.

So there was that.

A set of strange, incongruous facts.

And then she'd felt a huge drop in her mood, an overwhelming emptiness, as soon as she came. She'd tried to tell him, but he was the one who'd asked her to save it for later.

It was his own fault he didn't have his confession.

Sabrina looked up at the dresser and contemplated whether or not she should replace the phone there: what were the chances Graham would notice a thing like this? She didn't like having these thoughts. She would definitely, definitely have to tell him, because whatever had just happened might have been hot, but Graham didn't have all the information.

She didn't really *want* to tell him that, though.

She was more than a little curious about Sebastian Grant. What he had wanted when he sent her that photo, what he planned to do if she responded to him.

She closed her eyes, decided to try and sleep on it, opened them again and started to replace the phone.

And in the mirror she caught it, and it stopped her heart cold and changed the dynamic of everything, all over again:

A one-inch black stripe running from the top of the doorway down, along the length of... the door?

Slowly disappearing.

Gone.

The handle turning ever-so-slowly.

Graham had seen her.

For a moment, guilt held her in a cocoon of paralysis and she thought she might never move again. Her heart had stopped in her chest and then thundered back to life, and now kicked at her sternum and felt wild. Her spine tingled. She had goosebumps on the back of her neck.

She sat up, but she knew that Graham had retreated.

She should go and tell him, now. She threw the duvet off.

A moment of pause. Like a sledgehammer, a thought came crashing into her skull:

True, Graham had caught her sliding her phone off the table, or sliding it out.

But what was it that had caused him to open the door so slowly, and close it so surreptitiously? Suspicion?

It was true that it wasn't undeserved, but... why had he hidden it from her? And fucked her like that?

She pulled the duvet over her head and flipped onto her other side, closing her eyes. She was dog-tired from barely sleeping the night before. Her pussy was sore from all the sex - mostly from her husband. Zader Godfrey - more precisely, his cock - wandered through her attempts to think and distracted her by causing a dull throb between her legs. Her thighs slid over each other, greased by Graham's cum and the endless juices welling up in her pussy.

An image of Graham masturbating materialized in her head: she had almost forgotten that that had happened.

What to make of it all? You could, she realized, make whatever you wanted of it:

Graham knew everything, Graham knew nothing. She hadn't lied about anything important, she had lied about something important.

One thing you couldn't say about it all: whatever it was, Graham had been very aroused by it.

Her fingers wandered as she thought, down to her pussy, her hand tucked between her legs. A fragment of her imagination felt like Graham was still

there, peering through the crack in the door, so she didn't shift to her preferred position for masturbating (on her back). Her body shuddered when her fingertips sank into her very wet pussy lips and brushed over her tender clit.

Did it matter? she wondered. If everyone was getting what they wanted - to be more turned on, to have hotter sex - and she hadn't *really* crossed a line, not by the letter of the law? If all actual physical contact had been reported and accounted for, if Graham himself had told her to hold onto the secret, if he was having fun himself?

More than "fun," too, she would say.

She began to get heated up again, and so she stroked her clit until she came.

Did it matter that some of what she thought about was Graham? And some of it thick black cock? And some of it a sort of ambient fantasy, that Sebastian Grant was watching her, or in his own shower somewhere, jerking himself off? All of that was just stuff in her head.

When she came, she was thinking of it all, all at once - and if she had to be totally honest, there was an angle of that thought that hoped "it" - whatever this was, wasn't over already.

He stood in the kitchen, man in his fifties with his third burgeoning hard-on of the day, and asked himself for not the first time in his life: am I actually turned on by this?

Sure, he wanted the story. He didn't have any real reason to think his wife was lying to him: she'd told him about a blow job, admitted to running

away, and had, in the end, come home with a white guy, and he'd seen everything that happened between those two with his own eyes.

What could she even be trying to hide?

Unless...

Standing in the kitchen, staring into the fridge, the fears that came with and enhanced the high of her hotwifing ways took flight in his mind. It was like a blizzard: he could make no sense of any one thought, much less access some coherent statement of what was bothering him, getting him hot, and nagging at him.

There was always the danger of her developing feelings for a bull. The danger of going black and never going back. Of Sabrina hiding something because she had feelings. There was the ease with which she accepted - hell, that she even concluded - that the photo was "corrupted." It was a lie that made no sense, a lie he couldn't even prove, a secret he could only suspect existed but not even find the blurry contours of it in his imagination.

And then the most inexplicable thing, the one thing that he knew to be true because it was within himself:

He was so aroused by this possibilities this behavior implied, that he had fucked his wife three times in 24 hours. And what an exhilarating fuck the last one had been.

He closed the fridge door and stared at the steel.

A buddy of his had a gambling problem, and Graham had asked him once what the hell he was thinking when he did things like bet the \$10K he was up on one hand of blackjack. Joey's response had been to laugh his ass off and shake his head. "I don't know, man. All I know is that the thirty seconds before those cards get flipped, I just stare at that pile of money and it's like I

have three dicks and a pussy on every one of them. Money can't buy that feeling. Unless it's on the table, and you might lose it all."

At the time, Joey had sounded like a lunatic.

But what if this was one long poker game, and his wife was the pile of money on the table?

Framed like that, Joey didn't seem quite as crazy.

He opened the fridge again, swiped the orange juice, twisted the whole cap off and chugged it straight from the container while staring out the window into his yard.

He replaced the cap and stashed it back in the fridge. It was an act of defiance that might have given a little thrill to him just two hours ago, but now it was dull and it sort of sickened him that something so banal had ever been the least bit thrilling.

Because now he had this.

He pushed Joey's other observations away as they sprouted like weeds in his thoughts. Especially, especially, the thing he knew he should probably focus on: Joey's ruined financial life. A fable whose moral he should learn from.

As the fridge door gave a soft ploosh and closed, Graham Cole made a conscientious decision, and sure, he knew it was a bad one.

But as soon as he made it, a rush went into his veins. He glanced down at his rock-hard cock. Joey's metaphor seemed as apt as anything he'd ever heard in his life.

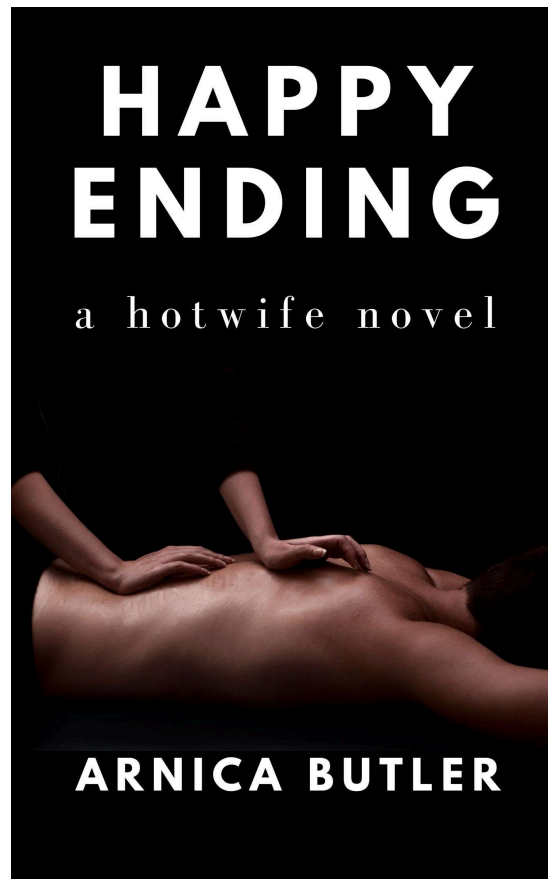
There was a profound sense of satisfaction blossoming in his chest as he realized that he was over fifty and still being led around by his own dick. Sure, he was old enough to know better, old enough to know that he was probably going to lose.

"Course," Joey had added, after a nostalgic summary of his worst losses and how they made him feel like a multi-dick Chad, "a gambler always figures he won't lose."

Still.

He was going to let it ride.

Also by



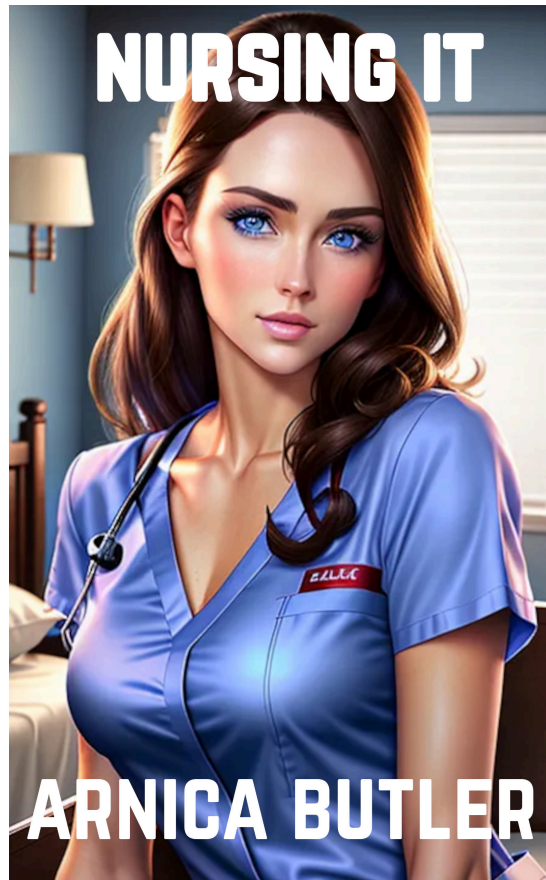
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